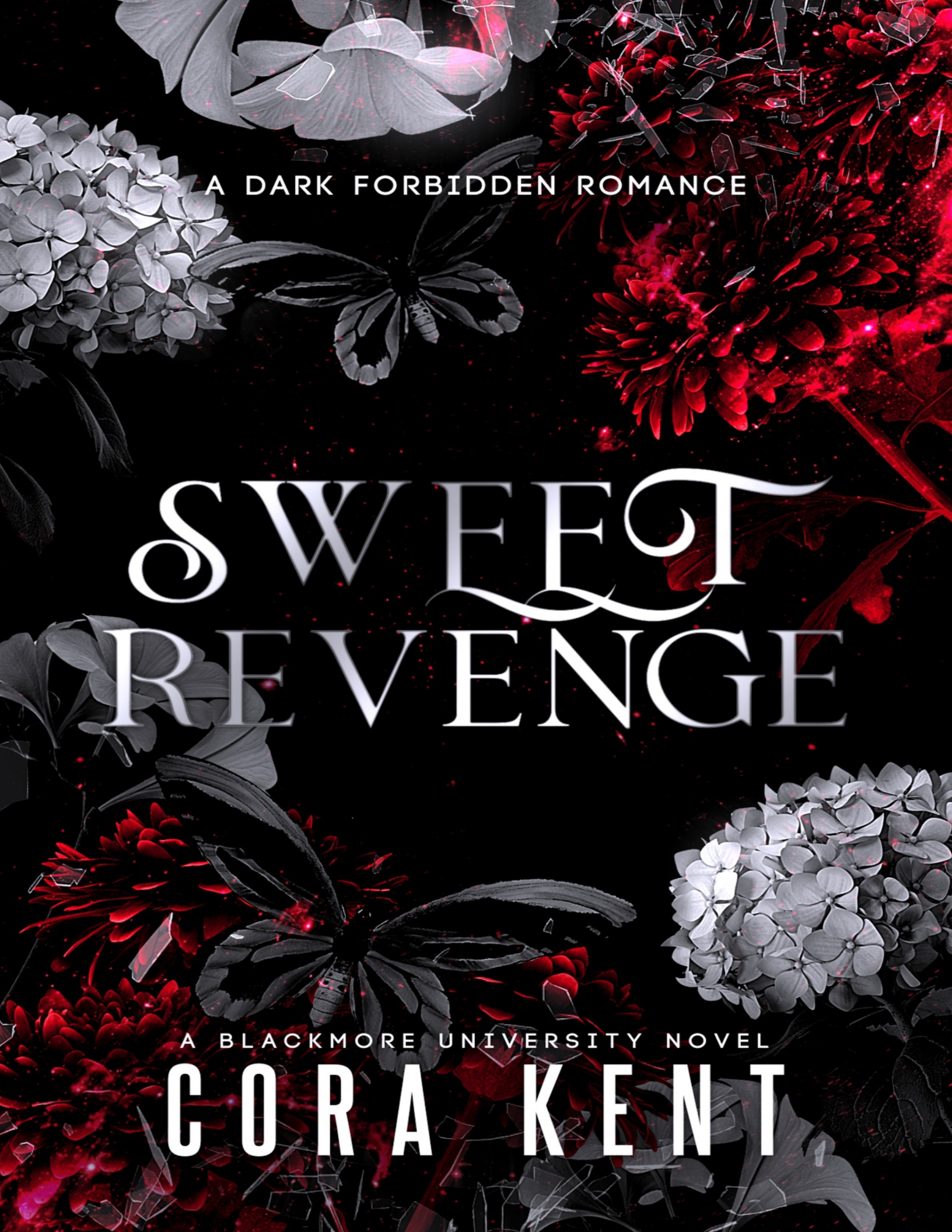




A DARK FORBIDDEN ROMANCE

SWEET REVENGE

A BLACKMORE UNIVERSITY NOVEL

CORA KENT

Sweet Revenge

A Dark Forbidden Romance

Blackmore University

Book 3

Cora Kent



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To all the women who walked down the aisle and married their biggest mistake: we can't change our pasts, we can only make a better future.

Content Warning



Sweet Revenge is a dark romance novel containing morally ambiguous characters and plot lines that include sexual content, violence, and questionable behavior. This book contains subject matter with the following themes:

Sexual Content: light dubious consent, primal play, public sex

Behavior: stalking, blackmail

Abuse: references to and scenes of spousal abuse (not heavily detailed)

This list may not be a complete picture of triggering content. Please remember that even though this book contains a happily ever after, you can put it down any time the storyline, characters, themes, or sexual content exceeds your expectations.

These warnings can also be found on my website:

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Chapter 1

Jackson

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I smooth the fabric across the Windsor knot on my tie and take a deep breath.

One voice in my head says that it's just a knot; stop worrying so much.

The other voice says that I need to fit in with my peers; this knot could be the difference between bringing down my father once and for all or being kicked out of the Illuminate Hope charity gala before I have a chance to introduce myself to Carrie.

It's a lot of pressure for a tie knot.



My phone chirps in the seat beside me. I grab it and find a text from Oliver.

OLIVER

Hope you have a good time. Let me know when you can swing by and build the computer.

Six weeks ago, Oliver Hastings emailed me about the charity gala. I have a few well-placed friends on high alert for news about Carrie Pennington. I've been watching her these last four years, waiting in silence for the perfect moment to destroy my father to reveal itself. When Oliver sent me the invitation to Illuminate Hope, an event to raise money for education in underserved communities and disadvantaged children in need, I knew the moment was upon me.

I would have traded all my worldly possessions for a shot at getting into the charity gala, but thankfully, it only cost a promise. If Oliver purchased the materials for the computer he wanted, I told him I would build it for him. In exchange, he'd get me an invitation to the coveted event under the McCade Library's name.

I have spent the last four years waiting for this opportunity. When I found out that my father was cheating on his first wife with Carrie, I wanted to make him pay by revealing his affair. But before I could tell Victoria what was going on, Malcolm left his wife for his mistress.

I'll admit that I didn't see it coming. After Malcolm carelessly discarded my mother when she told him she was pregnant, I thought it was a pattern of behavior. But something about the young, beautiful, ethereal Carrie Pennington made him change his ways.

And I understand why. I ran into her on the street outside of my father's law office the same day I confronted Malcolm about his abandonment. Something about her stopped me in my tracks and left me breathless.

I never expected Carrie to marry him. I didn't think she was the kind of girl who would give up her career and become a housewife. Granted, I only knew what I gleaned from the internet about her, but I felt like I knew her.

The Illuminate Hope invitation said the event was being organized by Sophie Bellamy and Carrie Pennington. Buying a well-fitted suit was expensive enough. And while Oliver was gracious enough to put me on the list as an invited guest, I still had to pay an exorbitant \$500 fee just to get in the door. I grew up comfortably in the lower middle class, but the men and women arriving at the hotel for the gala have undoubtedly been wealthy their entire lives.

“You fit in,” I remind myself. “You bought the clothes. You perfected the attitude. You spent years planning this.” I feel a little silly having to give myself a pep talk just to get out of my car, but I feel so out of place in the high-stakes circles Malcolm runs in that it ties my stomach in knots.

I open the door of my beat-up Chevrolet and pray that nobody sees me. I might have the suit and the haircut, but I couldn’t afford a new car just to impress the people in the parking lot.

A giggling couple in their thirties pass by me, but they only have eyes for each other. They aren’t dressed in their finest ballgowns, which leads me to believe they’re here to check into the hotel. I breathe a sigh of relief that my cover hasn’t been blown.

I give myself a quick reminder, mumbling: “Malcolm would see himself as deserving.”

With a deep breath, I straighten my spine and pull my shoulders back until they form a perfect line. Then, with practiced ease, I slip on the mask I’ve spent years carefully crafting.

My steps are marked with unwavering self-assurance as I glide through the expansive parking lot. The sleek facade of the hotel looms ahead, beckoning me inside. A woman dressed in a crisp suit stands at the entrance, her posture and attire exuding professionalism. Her voice is warm and welcoming as she asks if I am here for the hotel or Illuminate Hope.

“The gala,” I nod my head deferentially to her. “I’m Jackson Reid.”

She glances down at the clipboard resting on the polished wooden surface of the hostess podium, her perfectly manicured fingers gently tapping against it as she scans the names and reservations. “Welcome, Mr. Reid. We’re happy to have you this evening. Your contribution to Illuminate Hope is greatly appreciated.” With a graceful sweep of her hand, she motions toward the grand ballrooms lined with shimmering chandeliers and elegant guests.

The Four Points by Sheraton exudes an air of grandeur, its refined interior bathed in subdued lighting that casts a warm glow over the plush furnishings and rich fabrics. However, as grand as the hotel may be, it pales in comparison to the extravagant decorations brought in by the Illuminate Hope organizers.

The walls are adorned with intricate gold trimmings, adding to the luxurious atmosphere. The mix of rich colors and intricate decor gives off an air of sophistication and indulgence, setting the perfect backdrop for tonight’s affair.

The floor is a polished mosaic of black marble. Deep red velvet curtains cascade from the tall windows, adding a splash of bold color to the otherwise muted room. Each table is a masterpiece of elegance, draped in pristine white linens and intricate floral centerpieces.

I am taken aback by the sheer beauty and scale of the ballroom, which buzzes with the gentle hum of guests who’ve already arrived. A live orchestra plays a gentle melody in the background, its music weaving through the throngs of people, inviting them to sway along.

I expected a formal event, but the extravagance of the gala surpasses what I had imagined. The combination of the opulent setting, the elegant attire of the attendees, and the vibrant yet refined ambiance create a sense of splendor. I feel as though I’ve stepped into a different world, one where every detail has been carefully curated to create an unforgettable experience.

And that’s when I see her.

Standing in the middle of thousands of dollars in floral arrangements and place settings is the woman I’ve been following since I met her outside my father’s office. With tastefully applied makeup and her hair falling around her shoulders in soft, curled waves, I see Carrie Pennington.

The embodiment of my obsession and the catalyst of my father’s downfall.

Chapter 2

Carrie

I'm proud of what I accomplished with Illuminate Hope. Though if I'm being honest with myself, I think the decorations cost the foundation more than we'll be raising for the children.

"Are you listening to me?" Sophie waves her hand in front of my face. "Hello? Earth to Care-bear."

It snaps me out of my reverie, and I have to blink several times to refocus my eyes on her. "Sorry, Soph," I wince apologetically. "Can you repeat that?"

She huffs in annoyance and rolls her eyes. "If I must."

I like Sophie. She's been one of my closest friends since joining the volunteer scene in Manhattan, Kansas. But she's someone's trophy wife and grew up with wealth beyond her wildest dreams. Raising money for underserved children is a hobby for her, but for me, it's personal. I was a disadvantaged child in need; it's how I wound up pregnant at fourteen with my daughter, Kaye.

"I was telling you that Courtney, Britt, and I thought it would be fun to auction ourselves off tonight." Sophie takes a sip from her tall, slender champagne flute, the bubbles tickling her nose and going straight to her head in a delightful rush.

"We already have an auction," I frown. "The silent auction." Local businesses jumped at the chance to be featured at tonight's auction. The local spa and pool place donated a Jacuzzi, one of our biggest prizes available tonight. When Sophie, Courtney, Britt, and I were soliciting people for donations, they were donating stuff hand over fist when we told them their logo and business name would be visible to 200 of Manhattan's elite.

Sophie doesn't hide her frustration with me. "I *know* about the silent auction, Carrie. It was *my* idea." The superiority in her tone makes me feel small and insignificant. "I'm saying that we should auction off the organizers. It'll be a way for us to make an extra few thousand dollars for the underprivileged or whatever."

Malcolm won't like this. If I had to guess, he would drop a \$10,000 check if it meant keeping his wife from standing on a block and being sold to the highest bidder. "I don't think this is a good idea," I tell Sophie, suddenly feeling anxious. "What if our husbands find out?"

With another roll of her eyes and a healthy swig of champagne, Sophie admits that she doesn't care. "I'm not saying we should have sex with the winners. I'm just saying we auction ourselves off for the night. Give the single guys a chance to win a night of dining, dancing, and sparkling conversation with some of Manhattan's most beautiful ladies."

This isn't going to bode well. "When Malcolm finds out," I begin, but Sophie quickly cuts me off.

"No one is going to tell him, Care-bear. And even if someone does, so what? He should have been here tonight if he wanted you that badly."

Her words sting because they're true. Instead of being here, Malcolm chose to stay home. He told me at lunchtime that it was going to be a long day, and he didn't think he'd make it to the gala. "What about Nora?" I ask hesitantly.

Nora is the personal assistant Malcolm gifted me for Christmas two years ago. He said that between all my new responsibilities as his wife and my volunteer hours, I needed someone to help keep me on schedule and take some of the burden off my shoulders. Nora goes everywhere with me, and I think she secretly reports back to Malcolm on what I'm doing.

"Forget Nora," Sophie scoffs. "I'll have Britt send her on an errand. Are you in or not?"

I nervously chew on my bottom lip, feeling uncomfortable with the consequences of saying yes. “What if just you guys auction yourselves off? I don’t have to participate for it to be successful.”

A deep furrow forms between Sophie’s perfectly groomed eyebrows, and her annoyance is palpable. My words always seem to fall flat in her presence, as if I can’t quite speak the language of the wealthy. Since I didn’t grow up rich, I struggle to understand the nuances and social cues of the upper class, and Sophie never lets me forget it. “Come on, Carrie. This isn’t a big deal. I thought you said you cared about poor kids.”

I care about them more than she does. Until I met Malcolm, I *was* poor. I struggled to pay rent, not to mention put food on the table and buy my daughter new clothes. I was lucky to meet Malcolm when I did. It felt like Kaye and I were one emergency away from losing it all, but thanks to his help, we’ve made a miraculous recovery. “Okay, fine. But please emphasize that this is for charity. I don’t want this to get back to Malcolm and him freak out.”

“Pfft, if he does, he’s a big baby. Come on!” She grabs my hand and steers me toward the stage that the live orchestra is playing on. Along the way, Courtney and Britt join us.

“She agreed?” Courtney asks, her eyebrow raised in curiosity.

Britt links her arm through mine, patting my hand softly and shooting me a wink. “Of course she did. Carrie is a team player. Isn’t that right, Carrie?”

I feel sick to my stomach. “Right,” I mumble.

Sophie releases me as we climb the stairs onto the stage. She quiets the orchestra and grabs the microphone to begin her introduction. “Welcome, everyone, to Illuminate Hope. I want to thank each and every one of you for your contribution to our cause. This is a charity that aligns deeply with our hearts. We want you to know that every penny you spend tonight will go to schools in underprivileged communities to help needy children.”

Polite applause follows, as is expected from an event of this caliber, and Sophie continues. “My fellow organizers and I would like to offer the Illuminate Hope charity an opportunity to raise a few more dollars by auctioning ourselves off for the night. We would love nothing more than to contribute to the cause by giving four people or couples the chance to pick our brains on event planning. Or whatever else you have in mind,” she says with a wink.

A smattering of laughter peels through the crowd. Sophie invites me to the stage during the break in announcements, presenting me to the audience. “Twirl, Carrie,” she whispers into the mic.

I feel like a kid on Christmas who just opened up a sweater from grandma, and now mom’s making me model it for pictures. I take a few steps forward, and with a hesitant smile, I spin.

“Carrie Pennington joined the Illuminate Hope Foundation a couple of years ago, and she’s been knocking the events out of the park ever since. She’s a born planner and highlights her skills with a touch of class and minimalism. If you’re looking for a night out with a beautiful woman who can sing, dance, and juggle, Carrie’s your girl.”

I nearly blanch at Sophie’s description of me. She forgot to mention that I’m married, and she lied about my abilities. I don’t have a single graceful bone in my body. The closest I ever get to singing or dancing is in the shower when everyone has left the house for the day. And don’t even bother asking me to juggle unless you want something broken.

“\$300,” comes a starting bid.

I smile graciously at Nathaniel Alexander. He’s a widower who’s attended every Illuminate Hope event I’ve been involved with. His deceased wife used to be a member of the volunteer committee, and this is how he upholds her memory. When she passed a year ago, we all showed up at his door with bakery-fresh muffins and homemade casseroles. I haven’t seen him with a woman since, but I appreciate his faithfulness to our cause despite the event not catering to single men.

“That’s a great starting bid,” Sophie announces, undeterred, “but you guys can do better than that!”

I feel so uncomfortable standing up here that I might throw up. Even as the bids casually come in, increasing by \$50 with each new bidder, I feel like I’m betraying Malcolm. Nora stands in the corner of the room with her face buried in her phone, no doubt informing my husband of my indiscretions.

“\$2,000,” someone announces in the back.

I look through the crowd to find the joiner’s voice, and the people part in reply. A divide forms in the middle, every eye

looking back at the young man standing with his hands in his pockets. He wears a rueful smile that reminds me of a long-forgotten memory.

Sophie claps her hands together excitedly. “Now you’re a man that cares about the kids,” she passively aggressively shames the rest of the attendants. “Can anyone do better than \$2,000?”

Someone increases the bid by \$100, but my hero in the back of the room exceeds the price once again. “\$2,500,” he nods his head at me.

My heart beats in double time, my palms sweating. I can’t stop from admiring the stranger’s handsome face. His cheekbones are chiseled and sharp, giving him an air of confidence and allure. The cut of his suit seems explicitly tailored for his body, hugging every curve and contour perfectly. I can sense the strength and power beneath the expensive fabric, a solid and muscular frame just waiting to be uncovered.

Stop it, Carrie, the little voice in my head scolds me. *You’re a happily married woman.*

And the little voice is right. Malcolm McCade is a good-looking older man. He has a voracious appetite in bed and a successful career, and he treats me like a queen. There is no reason for me to look at another man because I have the best one there is.

But the devil on my shoulder reminds me of a memory I put aside months ago.

I walked into my husband’s office to surprise him with dinner since he had to work late. Most of the lights were off, and the sun was setting. I knew the floor plan of McCade & Manchester like I knew the back of my hand, so I didn’t bother turning on any lights or announcing my presence. It wasn’t until I accidentally kicked a desk and let out a little scream that the office came alive.

First, it was the sound of scuffling. Then, it was hushed whispers coming from Malcolm’s office. A few seconds later, he emerged with haste, straightening his tie as he walked towards me. His smile seemed forced, and his eyes darted around nervously. But what caught my attention was the bright red fabric peeking out from under his desk as he swiftly closed the door behind him.

The devil reminds me that it’s dinner and drinks. My secret bidder may expect a little flirting, but he won’t get anything else.

I gaze down at the glittering 4-karat diamond ring on my hand, its facets shimmering in the light like a million tiny stars. The weight of it on my finger is both comforting and suffocating, a constant reminder of my responsibilities and Malcolm’s expectations. I nervously twist it between my fingers, trying to calm my racing thoughts.

Even if this stranger is interested in me, he’ll stop when he sees the ring. And if by some chance he doesn’t, when he discovers who I’m married to, any thoughts of crossing boundaries or pursuing anything further will be quickly dismissed.

Chapter 3

Jackson

She's even more breathtaking than when I saw her four years ago. Carrie descends the staircase with a smile on her lips that ties my stomach into knots.

Calm down. Stay cool. This isn't an actual date.

But the sound of the announcer raffling off another woman set to the staccato beat of my heart makes it hard to hear the whisper of reason coming from the little voice in my head.

"Hi," Carrie announces as she walks up to me. She's 5'6", give or take an inch, and her head comes up to my chest. She wears an anxious smile as she reaches out to shake my hand. Her eyes meet mine with a mix of excitement and apprehension, like a tightrope walker balancing between two poles. Despite her anxiety, there is an air of confidence in the way she carries herself. "I'm Carrie Pennington. And you are?"

The man that's going to ruin every good thing in your life. "Jackson Reid." I reach out to take her hand, feeling the softness of her skin against mine. "It's a pleasure to spend this evening in your company, Ms. Pennington."

Her teeth graze her bottom lip and for a second, I think she's about to correct me. I can feel the words dancing across the tip of her tongue. *I'm married; it's Mrs. McCade.* But when Carrie opens her mouth, her cheeks flush as she says, "Thank you for your contribution to Illuminate Hope. I can't tell you how much it'll mean to the children."

I reluctantly release her hand, my fingers hovering in the space where she once was. She pulls away, and a cold emptiness chills me to the bone. "I know how much it'll mean to them," I lower my voice. "I grew up with a single mother, and we straddled the poverty line a time or two. Every year I qualified for free or discounted hot lunch at school, we threw a party."

Half-truths wrapped up in pretty little lies. I did my research on Carrie Pennington before targeting her for my father's downfall. I know she doesn't have a wealthy background; she worked her ass off to provide for her daughter. My mother and I struggled every now and again, but Carrie and I will form a better connection if she thinks we come from the same roots.

"It's funny you say that." The corners of her lips pull taut, tightening the smile on her lips. "I have a very similar story, but *I* was the single mother," Carrie blushes prettily.

I know all about her daughter. Kaye Pennington recently started at Blackmore University, the same prestigious college that I'm working at. I lean in closer, creating a deeper sense of intimacy. "Then you probably know how my mother felt better than I did."

If she's embarrassed by her unfortunate upbringing, she seems to forget it when I offer her my arm. Carrie reaches out to tuck her hand into my elbow as I lead her to a table, leaving behind the auction. "So how does a guy who grew up with limited means wind up spending \$2,500 just to have dinner with little ol' me?"

I take a deep breath and remind myself not to blurt out the first thing that comes to mind. I must take extreme care with Carrie because this is a marathon, not a sprint. I won't ruin Malcolm's marriage overnight.

"Being in the right place at the right time, I guess," I tell her with a little shrug. "I attended Blackmore University right out of high school. I could barely afford the gas to get there every day, so I started working at the campus library. I shelved books, cleaned up after my peers, and took out overflowing, smelly trash cans when people snuck in food and couldn't be bothered to take it with them when they left. It wasn't a glamorous job, but it paid for my textbooks and put some food on the table for Mom

and me.”

Carrie’s grip on my arm tightens as she quietly directs me toward a table near the front of the room.

“But by my junior year, I pretty much lived at the library. It was my favorite place to be, and I couldn’t get enough of it. I decided to get my degree in Library Science, and after graduation, I was offered a position in their Acquisitions department.” I lean toward her, lowering my voice before admitting that this is the most money I’ve ever made. “It’s not much compared to the people here. Some of them are Friends of the Library, donors, that sort of thing, but \$65,000 for my first job out of college felt like a million bucks to me.”

I grab a chair and pull it out for Carrie, acting the gentleman my mom taught me to be. “What about you?” I ask. “You know what it’s like to be a single mom. I’m guessing if you have a similar story to mine, you didn’t grow up rich, either. How’d you get involved with one of the largest growing charities in Manhattan?”

A server comes around to ask for our beverage orders. Carrie asks for a glass of Chardonnay, and I follow her lead, ordering a Merlot.

“A little bit of luck,” she says with a wan smile. “And a lot of hard work.”

Interestingly enough, she doesn’t mention Malcolm. It is a good sign that she doesn’t proudly announce marrying into wealth. The same can’t be said for some of the men and women here tonight.

“You said you were working at the campus library?” She quizzes after a minute. “How’s that?”

I regale her with stories about the McCade Library while the other attendants begin to meander in and fill the tables around us. The auction must have ended because I see Carrie’s co-conspirator walking arm-in-arm with a handsome older man. She bats her eyelashes at him and laughs at his jokes like he’s the funniest man alive.

“So there I was, pushing a cart full of Victorian-era books on the third floor when I came across this couple doing it up against the stacks. I wasn’t a prude or anything, but seeing that girl’s bare ass on a first-edition Jane Eyre didn’t sit right with me. I felt like someone’s grandpa when I yelled at them to knock it off. I was halfway to calling campus security when they pulled up their pants and jetted off.” I shake my head, disgusted by the memory. “I know people have sex in the library, but my God, on a *first edition*?”

Carrie laughs so hard she snorts, which causes her to cover her mouth and laugh even harder. “Oh, my god,” she says when she has a chance to catch her breath. “You’re such a nerd.”

“*Moi*?” I ask, placing a hand against my chest in faux outrage. “Those are fighting words.”

She shakes her hands at me as if clearing the air in front of her. “That’s not a bad thing by any means. You take your job seriously, and you have an admiration for things like first-edition Jane Eyre books that the rest of us couldn’t care less about. But we all have things that drive us. The preservation of historical, literary masterpieces is what happens to drive you.”

I never thought of it that way. When it happened, I was appalled that someone would desecrate an expensive piece of literature.

I’m interrupted by a round of salads dropped off by the serving staff. A ramekin of raspberry vinaigrette sits neatly at the top of the plate, a dark red mix that colors the greens beautifully. “Who chose the menu?”

Carrie rolls her eyes and I suspect I wasn’t supposed to see it. “Sophie did. She touted onstage that I’m a minimalist, but in private, our styles clash. I wanted a classic salad, a roasted chicken dish, and tiramisu for dessert. Something simple and classy without breaking the budget. But like the ostentatious decorations,” Carrie announces as she looks around, “I was overruled. Sophie makes all the decisions, which is why there’s a soup course after this, and you can choose between steak, fish, or chicken for dinner. She said if we didn’t show people that we valued our donors, how could they know we valued the children we’re trying to help?”

I almost choke on the pecans topping my salad. “That doesn’t make any sense.”

“You’re telling me,” she says with an airy sing-song reply. “We spent over \$10,000 in catering for tonight’s event. We’ve raised nearly \$50,000 for the local schools, but we could have raised more if our budget was appropriately allocated.”

I’ve never met Malcolm’s first wife, Victoria Palmieri, face-to-face. I’ve seen her in passing and at events where her son, Xavier, is playing football. We’ve never spoken because I didn’t want her to know who I was. But from what I’ve gleaned during my research and what I’ve heard about her, Victoria doesn’t seem like the kind of woman who would concern herself

with catering budgets and pinching pennies to help needy children.

In a way, I can see why my father chose to leave his first wife for Carrie. She's utterly charismatic and charming, and she cares for people in need.

"You're beautiful, you know that?" The words slip from my lips unbidden.

Carrie turns to peek up at me, her eyelashes fluttering in surprise. "Wh-what?"

I clear my throat, reminding myself of my purpose here tonight. I'm supposed to be finding a way to get under Carrie's skin, not the other way around. "Your heart," I correct myself. "And your soul is beautiful. And you are, too, but I think you already know that."

She quickly turns away. I look at the table and see her hand next to mine, showing off the diamond engagement ring Malcolm bought for her years ago. If she's trying to signal me with it, she's flashing the wrong person.

After a long moment, Carrie says thank you. Then, the servers come by to clear our plates, replacing them with tiny cups of soup. The moment is lost but not forgotten.

I'm getting under her skin.

But I think she's getting under mine, too.

Chapter 4

Carrie

There's something captivating about Jackson, a sense of familiarity I can't quite place. Maybe it's the way his eyes crinkle at the corners when he laughs or the slight tilt of his head as he leans in to share a joke, his voice dropping to a hushed tone as if afraid of offending anyone else at our table. And his blue eyes hold a glint of recognition that tugs at my memory. Each time he turns to speak to me, his entire body follows suit, causing our knees to brush against each other, and a rose-colored blush spreads across my cheeks.

I remind myself that I'm married. Over and over again, I repeat the words in my head. *I'm happily married. I'm happily married. I'm happily married.* But then Jackson leans over to ask me which fork he's supposed to use for this course, and I giggle because I asked my husband the same question three years ago when we married. I stepped into Malcolm's world of wealth and was overwhelmed by everything from the social cues to the cutlery.

When dinner breaks for dancing and final bidding on the silent auction items, Jackson gets to his feet and offers me a hand. "Care to dance?"

He makes me feel young again. At thirty-two, I feel like I've lived a thousand lifetimes, but I can almost forget all of them when I take Jackson's hand and let him lead me to the dance floor. Every step I take feels weightless and carefree—as if floating on a cloud of joy.

"Don't make fun of me," he whispers as we make a space for ourselves in the center. "My dance experience is limited to Dance Dance Revolution, a square dancing class in PE, and awkwardly swaying back and forth with girls in high school."

"Wow. You're pretty much a professional." Chatting with him is easy. He brings out the playful side of me, a part I haven't seen in a long time.

As Jackson's arms encircle my waist, a spark of electricity races down my spine, igniting every nerve ending along the way. The warmth of his touch seeps through my skin and engulfs me. In this moment, I am acutely aware of his presence, the heat radiating from his body and the soft rhythm of his breath against my neck. Every inch of me is tingling with excitement.

"You smell like jasmine," he hums, his eyes finding mine.

I blame the intimacy of being pressed against an attractive man; it's the only explanation for forgetting the ring on my finger and the dozens of people dancing around us who might report my behavior to Malcolm. "You smell like clove and cinnamon."

The atmosphere is thick with anticipation and longing, a palpable energy that tugs at the limits of my self-control. Jackson's hands on my hips become firmer, drawing me closer until our bodies are crushed together.

Up close, a glint of silver mingling with the dark hairs in his beard catches my eye. It gives him a distinguished look that adds a touch of maturity to his appearance. And it makes me wonder... "How old are you?"

"Why?" He asks conspiratorially. "You tired of babysitting me?"

A smile pops up on my lips uninvited. "No. I'm just curious. I think I'm older than you, but only by what? Three, four years?"

With a shrug, Jackson tells me that he's twenty-five. I gulp, announcing that I'm seven years older than him; I'm practically ancient.

"Can I say something I probably have no business weighing in on?" He asks.

I nod my head slowly, my stomach churning with fear and insecurity.

My mind drifts to the stark 14-year age gap between Malcolm and me. I was twenty-eight when we first met, and I'm rapidly approaching his ex-wife's age. The thought lingers in my mind like a dark cloud, wondering if Malcolm will tire of me and find a younger replacement when I'm in my forties like Victoria was.

"You mentioned being a young mother, and I can only imagine the sacrifices and stress that you went through. I think it contributed to your premature aging because you seem like such an old soul for someone who is still so young and vibrant. You need to give yourself some space, relax, and let go of the weight you've been carrying. There's still time to reclaim the youth you never had."

I have to look away to keep him from seeing the tears well up in my eyes. I blink several times, quickly, and force my eyes toward the ceiling. I press my tongue to the roof of my mouth and jam the nail of my thumb into the skin on my palm, a familiar coping mechanism to stop myself from crying. Every muscle in my body tenses as I use each trick and habit I know to keep the emotions at bay, but it works.

Jackson continues. "Life is unpredictable. People find themselves in situations they never imagined they would be in. They make choices based on what's best for them at that moment, even if it may not benefit them in the future. And that's okay."

Our movements up until now have been minimal, a slight sway back and forth on the dance floor as the orchestra plays a classical song. But Jackson releases me momentarily so his free hand can touch my chin and force me to look at him. "You've made choices in your life based on the knowledge you had at the time. You did what you could to support yourself and your daughter. You said she's at college now?" He pauses for a second, and I nod yes in confirmation. "Then take a deep breath and let loose. You're allowed to take back your life, Carrie. You deserve to experience all the things that were once out of reach."

His face is inches away from mine. The angel on my shoulder tells me to back away, thank him for a wonderful night, and never see him again. But the devil tells me to stand on my tiptoes and press my lips to his. I want to taste his youth, taste the kisses I missed when I was his age. The ones I traded for marital bliss to my ex-husband, a man who hurt me and put his hands on my daughter.

But the song ends, and the mood changes. Our intimacy disappears, replaced with a song meant for more than casual swaying.

I pull away from Jackson and remind myself, yet again, that I'm married. Tonight was fun, but I love my husband. Malcolm is good to me. He has never put his hands on me, and he provides for Kaye and me. I'm a lucky woman, and I shouldn't throw my new life away for a young man with a flirtatious smile.

"I think I'll sit this next song out," I decide.

Jackson offers me his arm, ever sturdy and at ease. "Of course. Do you want me to get you another glass of wine?"

My head buzzes, and common sense tells me to switch to water. But I accept his offer because it'll make him walk to the bar. And while he's gone, maybe I can get my head straight.

The truth is Jackson is a stranger. If you had presented me with a line-up a few days ago, I wouldn't have picked him out. He's just a nice, good-looking man who caught me unaware tonight. Once I get home to my husband, I'll forget all about him.

Chapter 5

Jackson

I pushed her too hard. I told her to let loose and enjoy her life, and it scared her. I don't know what I was thinking. I *wasn't* thinking.

As the gala wraps up, I struggle to find another way to connect with her. Carrie plays on the surface of our newfound friendship, never delving into the deeper waters we waded through on the dance floor. She laughs at my jokes but then turns her head. She finds any excuse to make conversation with someone else at our table. I've lost her, and I didn't even have her to begin with.

Her co-organizer, Sophie, comes up to whisper in her ear as the night comes to a close. A blush spreads across Carrie's cheeks as she bats the woman away. They speak in pointed looks, half-hearted smiles, and a series of hushed sounds—a language all their own.

With a wider, much happier-to-see-me smile than Carrie's, Sophie thanks me for my contribution to Illuminate Hope. "I hope your evening with Carrie was everything you expected."

I can't tell if it's a backhanded compliment or if she truly means it. "I will always support a good cause."

The older man who won an evening with Sophie comes up behind her, holding a shawl. He touches her hip in a way that highlights the intimacy of their connection. "Mrs. Bellamy," he quietly interrupts. "Are you ready to go?"

As Carrie and I sit there, watching the two of them walk away, I feel a surge of emotions bubbling up inside me. The air is thick with tension, and we try to maintain our composure until they are out of sight. Suddenly, Carrie lets out a loud burst of laughter, and I can't help but join in.

"I don't know if you caught on to this, but your co-organizer is probably going home with that man."

She shakes her head disparagingly. "I know," she says with a groan. "I think Sophie and her husband have some kind of open marriage thing. I don't know for sure, but this isn't the first time I've seen her do something like this. Not to mention Andrew never comes to these events."

It seems absurd to me that two people would get married so they can spend time with other people, but it's not my relationship. Who am I to judge? "Since everyone is starting to clear out, can I walk you to your car?" A few minutes ago, she might have turned me down. But Sophie's brief interjection pushed the reset button on us.

"You don't have to do that," she begins.

I get to my feet and offer her my hand. "You're right. I don't *have* to do anything. But what kind of man would I be if I didn't make sure you got to your car safely?"

Carrie slips her hand into mine, and I ignore the tingly feelings it gives me. "Thank you," she says as she stands before me.

My blue eyes meet her green, and for a second, I wish we met under different circumstances. But the moment passes when she removes her hand from mine and starts leading me toward the exit.

"I think the event went well," she announces. "In light of how much the silent auction made, we probably didn't need to auction off the organizers."

There's a frown of disappointment on her face, but I pretend not to notice. "But if there were no auction, I wouldn't have met you."

Carrie pauses briefly, pinning me with a curious stare. "Jackson, I—" but she stops mid-stride, her face contorted with confusion.

I open the door to the hotel and gesture her through. "Where did you park?"

She stares at me, mouth agape, as I place my hand on the small of her back and lead her through the parking lot. "I know you," Carrie mumbles, realization dawning on her. "How do I know you?"

I was worried she'd figure it out the second she saw me. I thought she'd know who I was when I introduced myself. I could see the vague look of recollection on her face throughout the evening, but she never stumbled across my secret.

"This is me," she says as we approach her car.

I knew it was, but I had to pretend otherwise. "Nice Jag."

Carrie blinks, removed from the situation. "What?"

If she figures it out now, she'll have no reason to find me later. So I distract her by leaning in for a kiss, savoring the faint taste of wine on her lips. The world comes to a grinding halt, caught between one heartbeat and the next. My hand instinctively finds its way to the curve of her waist, pulling her closer.

Carrie responds with a tender urgency that sends my senses into overdrive. Her hand brushes against my cheek, feather-light yet filled with purpose, tracing the line of my jaw before curling around the back of my neck. She is everywhere all at once—her scent, her warmth, her breath syncing with mine.

I'm lost in the smell of jasmine and something uniquely Carrie—a scent of pure intoxication. For those few seconds, time ceases to exist. We are lost in an embrace that defies everything but the burning need to be closer. And in that moment, something within me irrevocably shifts. Like stars colliding in the vast canvas of space, I feel a burst of emotion so powerful it threatens to consume me.

"Jackson," she breathes out, pushing me away. "I'm married." Her words hit me with a sobering splash of reality. Carrie steps back, pulling up her hand to show off the impossibly large diamond sparkling on her finger.

"I know," I gulp, swallowing past the lump forming in my throat. "But I can't help it. When I saw you walk up on that stage tonight, something inside of me screamed that I had to have you. I had to be with you."

Even in the darkness, I can see Carrie's cheeks flush with embarrassment and desire. "It was a lovely night," she begins to protest, "but I love my husband. I'm sorry."

If she really loved Malcolm, she wouldn't apologize. She might like him; she might even be on the cusp of falling in love with him, but part of her enjoyed the attention I gave her tonight. Part of her still longs for something more. I have her right where I want her.

"I-I have to leave," Carrie stutters, walking around to the driver's side of the car. She looks back and forth from the car door to me. "Thank you for tonight. Really." She climbs inside, looking even more confused when she pulls the door shut behind her.

I watch her drive away, standing there like a lovesick puppy until she's out of view. I want her last memory of me to be the look of longing on my face. I want her to go to sleep tonight, remembering that someone looked at her in a way that her husband never has.

I don't know Malcolm and Carrie's relationship well, but I know my father. And there's no way he's ever looked at a woman the way I looked at Carrie.

And that will be his undoing.

Chapter 6

Carrie

I recognized Jackson as we were leaving the gala the other night. A fuzzy memory from long ago popped up unwelcome, and I struggled to bring it into focus. I flashed back to a time, years ago, just before Malcolm and I made things official.

I was sitting outside my now-husband's law office, trying to decide what to do about our relationship. I was lost and overwhelmed by the choice that lay before me. I knew Malcolm was married; I knew he had another family. But I couldn't decide whether to break things off or ask him to choose.

Then, a tall, handsome young man took a seat next to me. His friendly smile and kind eyes put me at ease as he asked if I wanted to talk. The gentle tone of his voice made it easy for me to open up to him. I told him everything, hoping that he would somehow be able to minimize my suffering.

All throughout the evening of the gala, I felt a fleeting sense of recognition every time Jackson smiled at me. I couldn't quite pinpoint who he reminded me of until we were on our way out. Then he kissed me, and recognition didn't seem to matter anymore.

I remember watching *The Princess Diaries* when I was a preteen. Mia talked about having her first foot-popping kiss, and I went into high school thinking that was the end-all, be-all of kisses. If I couldn't find a man who made my foot pop, I didn't even want him.

But reality is different than the movies. The first boy who kissed me was Franklin Pennington, and I enjoyed kissing him so much that I didn't even care if my foot popped. The next thing I knew, I was pregnant, and the only thing I was popping were Tums to control my acid reflux.

But when Jackson kissed me the other night, I was overwhelmed by a whirlwind of sensations. In that fleeting moment, every nerve in my body seemed to come alive—a tingling warmth spread from my lips, igniting a fire that coursed all the way through me. Time seemed to stand still as we shared that passionate, stolen kiss. It was as if the world had faded away, leaving only the intoxicating connection between us. My foot even popped just a second before I realized that the man making my insides turn to mush *wasn't* my husband.

I've never cheated before. I've looked at other men and fantasized, like all people do. There's nothing wrong with appreciating someone who's good-looking. I've always known to back away when I feel that way about someone. Don't engage, don't talk, don't become friends. I have never put myself in a position to get close to someone I find as attractive, or more attractive, than the man I'm with.

But with Jackson, I couldn't help myself. I don't know what it is about him. Maybe it's because I never expected to see him again, or maybe it's because I relate to him on a level that I can't relate to Malcolm. There's just something about Jackson that makes me want to know more about him.

I promised myself I wouldn't look him up on Facebook, but I did. I said I wouldn't check out all his pictures on Instagram, but I did. I swore I wouldn't Google his name and read his list of accomplishments, but I did.

I told myself that was enough, but it wasn't. I told myself I could live without seeing him again, but I couldn't.

When I called Sophie to ask her about Jackson, she giggled. She thought it was the funniest thing in the world that I would be interested in the man who won a date with me at a gala for under privileged youth.

“It isn’t like that, Soph. I love Malcolm.” But even as I said the words, they felt hollow. I told myself to shake it off and that I was only trying to track Jackson down to thank him for that talk four years ago.

“It’s fine if you liked spending the night with him, Care-bear.” She rattled off the information on his account, reminding me that he worked at the McCade Library on the Blackmore University campus. “Who would I tell, anyway?”

Sophie lives for a scandal. If she caught wind of my fears about Malcolm’s infidelity, she would revel in the opportunity to stir up chaos and destruction. The mere thought of me being unfaithful would send her into a frenzied state, spreading wild rumors throughout Manhattan’s high-society circles.

And who would she tell? Everyone. While relishing in their shocked reactions as she tears down my reputation with each whispered word.

“Thanks, Soph, but I just want to thank him for his contribution to Illuminate Hope.”

Which is the lie I tell myself on the half-hour drive to Rosedale. It’s the lie I repeat as I look for a parking place, keeping an eye out for Kaye while praying she doesn’t see me. It’s the lie that echoes in the chamber of my thoughts as I stand at the front desk and ask the librarian if she can call Jackson Reid and tell him he has a visitor.

I just want to say thank you. That’s all.

Chapter 7

Jackson

Your words make up your reality. For the last few days, I've had to keep repeating that to myself, interspersed with, *'You didn't scare Carrie off. You're giving her time to meditate on the kiss.'* It was all I could do to keep myself from showing up at her favorite coffee shop and *unexpectedly* running into her.

But persistence pays off. And your words really do make up your reality. Telling myself she would show up felt like I was manifesting her into existence. When Emily from the front desk called my office to say that Carrie Pennington was waiting in the lobby to see me, I almost shouted with glee.

"Be cool," I mumble in the elevator on the way to the ground floor. "Be suave. Be charming. This will all work out for your good."

As the elevator doors slide open, my eyes immediately land on Carrie. She stands with her back to me, her blonde hair cascading down her shoulders. I make my way over to her and gently tap her on the shoulder, startling her. Her emerald green eyes meet mine, filled with surprise and delight at my unexpected arrival.

"You scared me," she laughs nervously.

"Sorry about that. What brings you to the library today?" I'm all business, from the tone of my voice to the button-down shirt neatly tucked into my slacks. Every detail exudes competence and control, leaving no room for error or doubt.

Carrie shifts uncomfortably, wanting to say something but unsure how to phrase it. In the end, she settles for asking for a tour of the library. "My daughter is a student here, but Kaye didn't want me to help her move in. She and her best friend did that together. They're thick as thieves. Half the time, it feels like Kaye's replaced me with Christine."

She's talking about Christine Lucatello. The girl came up in my research, but I have no interest in her. She's a pretty little red-headed thing, but she doesn't serve my purposes. "I'm happy to give you a tour. This is one of my favorite places to be."

We start with the first floor, where the musty smell of decades-old carpet greets us and muffles the click-clack of her high heels. The once plush and vibrant color is now muted and worn. "This is where most of the undergraduate students come to study. We have some of the professors' textbooks, along with thousands of copies of reading materials students may need for any subject. I used to hang out here even when I wasn't working because it helped me focus. There's something about the ambiance of pages turning, low chatter, and dim lighting that gets me in a productive mood."

Carrie smiles as her eyes pan across a group of students clustered together with earbuds in and laptops splayed across their tables. "I've always admired academia. I was never a strong student, a very B-average kind of girl. I never saw myself going to college; I never really knew what I wanted to do with my life."

"I felt that way for a long time. My mom used to ask me every day what I wanted to do with my life, and I felt like a failure when I didn't have an answer. She's a nurse," I explain. "She always knew that she wanted to help people. But I didn't grow up wanting to be a teacher, or a doctor, or something."

"I get that. Some people seem to inherently know what they want—like my daughter, Kaye. Kaye has known for years that she wants to be a family law attorney. It's something engrained in her DNA. But I don't have that," she says with a sad downturn in her tone.

I guide her up the grand, sweeping staircase to the second floor. The cacophony of voices fades away, replaced by a tranquil

stillness and the gentle strains of a violin echoing through the speakers. Up here on the second and third floors, we fill the air with classical melodies—just loud enough to fill the space without overwhelming it, creating a peaceful ambiance that eases any discomfort of being alone in this lofty part of the building.

“This is the second floor. We keep a lot of master’s and graduate books up here. Most of the students who need these texts tend to check them out for extended periods of time. This floor is only ever really busy during Finals and leading up to graduation.”

I change the subject because it’s getting too personal again. Relating to Carrie on a deep, personal level needs to happen if I want my plan to succeed. But I’ll admit, I’m not the type to get involved in something half-heartedly. I can’t lie to myself and believe this doesn’t mean anything. I’m trying to separate myself from the lies I have to tell, but Carrie makes it hard.

She gracefully glides over to an aisle lined with dusty books. Stretching up onto her tiptoes, she carefully scans the titles with her fingers, tracing each one as if they are old friends. I can’t help but notice the rise and fall of her chest, the dramatic rhythm in tune with her movements. Her presence fills the small space, like a dancer performing on a stage. “I didn’t know libraries could be so peaceful,” Carrie says after a moment.

I walk up behind her, catching a whiff of her shampoo again. I force myself to stifle the feelings it brings up as I reach to place my hand on top of hers. “Libraries are the perfect blend of modern-day and history. We have books on our shelves that were published this year and books that were published centuries ago. I always feel at peace here because I know if I look hard enough, I can find the answers to whatever ails me.”

She lets my hand rest on hers briefly before pulling away. When Carrie twists, she finds herself standing face-to-face with me. Her cheeks fill with color as she meets my eyes, and she wrings her hands together as if trying to remove the memory of me. “Jackson, I wanted to tell you this the other night, but then... things happened.”

The rest of her sentence falls flat, lost under the crushing weight of what I did to her in the parking lot the night of the gala. To any onlooker, it might have been just a kiss. But to us, it was so much more.

Carrie takes a deep breath before continuing. “I knew I recognized you when I saw you that night. I just couldn’t remember from where. It took me ages to figure it out, but I finally did. We’ve met before. That day in Manhattan.”

I nod as she speaks, allowing her to put the pieces together. “Yeah, I remember. How could I forget?” I reach up to brush a strand of hair out of her face. “You were the most beautiful woman in the world four years ago, and you still are today, four years later.”

Her brow furrows as she cranes her neck to look up at me with a tilt of her head. “Jackson, when we spoke that day, I told you I was in love with a married man.”

“I remember.” She was in love with my father. She still is.

She swallows, and a lump bobs up and down in her throat. “I married him, Jackson. The man I told you about. Malcolm McCade. I married him.”

“Do you love him?”

Carrie nods, not daring to speak.

“Then why are you here?”

Chapter 8

Carrie

As I open my mouth to reply, a dryness spreads across my tongue. The words I want to say get caught in my throat, constricting it until it feels like I'm suffocating.

Why am I here? What do I want to accomplish?

I open my mouth to tell Jackson that I want to thank him for his advice all those years ago, but he cuts me off.

"McCade Library," he says, "is that the same McCade as your husband?"

"It was Malcolm's father, I think," I reply weakly. I can't remember what Malcolm told me about this place. Not when Jackson is staring at me like that.

His tongue darts out, moistening his bottom lip with a quick flick. My heart races as I imagine standing on my toes and reaching up to kiss him. The anticipation builds, and my lips tingle with the thought of touching his. I can almost taste the sweet warmth of his mouth against mine. "Is it going to be awkward then?"

He distracts me from my daydream. "What?" I frown. "Is what going to be awkward?"

"Explaining to your husband that you met the love of your life at the library his family donated to the school." And before I can argue, he's doing it again. He has his lips on mine as if he can read my mind.

I'm caught between the hard surface of the bookshelf and the tempting warmth of Jackson's body. Every fiber in my being is screaming at me, a chorus of conflicting voices that mimic the frantic beating of my heart. Some urge me to slap him for his audacity, while others cheer him on with wicked delight. Malcolm's voice echoes in the back of my mind, disappointment lacing his words. But I push away his memory and give in to the alluring sin of lust.

Jackson doesn't kiss me for long. He pulls away before I can push him. His teeth press an indentation into his bottom lip as he hovers only centimeters away. "I know you're married, Carrie. I know you love your husband. But if you were happy, why did you come here?"

My brain and mouth can't seem to connect. I feel like I'm wading through molasses to get to the answer. "I-I wanted to thank you for what you did for me all those years ago. And what you did for the kids at the gala," I stutter.

"You could have sent me an email. The Illuminate Hope Foundation has all my information." He says it so matter-of-factly that I am stunned to my core.

I know he's right. I know what he's hinting at. And I'm afraid to admit it. I'm afraid to say that all it took was one evening with a handsome man to make me question my loyalty to my husband. "Gratitude is best delivered in person."

His pupils dilate, growing as he looks at me with desire. "Sure. I'll accept that. But you should leave."

My heart falls, discouraged by the sudden change in his attitude. "What?"

"I think it's obvious that I like you, Carrie. And I appreciate you coming here to thank me for all I've done. But having you alone in a place I love makes me feel things I shouldn't. It makes me want to do things to you that might test your devotion to your husband."

I'm not prepared for the feeling of disappointment that crashes into my chest. His words feel like a criticism hurled right at my

stomach, and it takes my breath away.

Jackson reaches forward. I don't realize it until I feel his hand clutching mine at my waist, fingers entwining and holding me tight. "I would never ask you to do something you don't want to do. But I can keep a secret, Carrie."

I've always been a weak woman. I fall for men who are bad for me. I put myself in situations that will break my heart.

So I consider it strength when I pull my hand out of his and run from him. It's all I can do to break through the front doors of the library and take in the deep scent of late summer air. I let it fill my lungs, expanding until I swear I'm going to burst.

Agreeing to let Sophie auction me off was a mistake. Coming here to thank Jackson was a mistake. And I won't let either mistake ruin my life.

I'm married to a wonderful man. I get to volunteer at charities I previously had to accept handouts from. And my daughter is safe and sound at college, getting the degree I was never able to.

I'm not going to throw my whole life away for a passing fancy.

I'm not going to lose everything over a handful of silly mistakes.

Chapter 9

Carrie

Ensnared in the beautiful mansion that Malcolm bought for us when we got married, I busy myself with making dinner and doing the laundry. My husband will be home soon, and I want to surprise him with a new recipe.

The memory of kissing Jackson earlier lingers in my mind, but I try to drown it out with music and complicated cooking techniques. I have resolved to forget about the handsome young man. He threatens my marriage and my security; I no longer want to be around him.

“Hello,” comes Malcolm’s voice as he enters the kitchen from the garage. “That smells wonderful. What are you making?”

Seeing my husband makes me smile. When he’s in his suit, dressed head to toe in all black, he’s as handsome as the day I met him. “I’m making stuffed salmon, duchess potatoes, and asparagus wrapped in prosciutto.”

With a confident stride, he crosses the spacious kitchen, his feet barely making a sound on the polished marble floors. As he reaches me, he leans down and presses his lips against mine with practiced ease. His kiss is gentle yet possessive, conveying a sense of comfort and security I’ve come to rely on. With a lingering touch, he pulls away. The subtle scent of his cologne lingers in the air, mixing with the aroma of dinner. “That sounds delicious. I swear, if you keep cooking like this, I’m going to have to start going to the gym more often. I feel like I’ve gained twenty pounds since we got married.”

I place a loving hand on his hip, standing on my toes to give him a second, deeper kiss. I want to remove Jackson’s memory and replace it with something familiar. “You’re perfect just the way you are, Malcolm. If anyone needs to hit the gym more often, it’s me.”

Malcolm’s hand snakes around to give my backside a patronizing squeeze. “You know I prefer you with a little extra weight,” he says with a wink.

The comment puts me on edge, but I’m not sure why. I turn away from my husband and remind myself that he means well and that his comments express appreciation for my body, not disrespect.

“By the way,” Malcolm clears his throat. “Do you want to explain why you ditched Nora this afternoon?”

That bitch. I knew she was ratting me out to my husband. He always seems to have insider information about what goes on during my days.

I busy myself with peeling potatoes, eyeing the glass of wine on the counter a few feet away. “I didn’t need her this afternoon. That’s all. I didn’t want to waste her time on a quick trip to the university.”

“Oh?” I can hear his eyebrows raising. “Did you visit Kaye? How’s she doing?”

I should say yes, but I wouldn’t put it past him to fact-check my lies. Now that my daughter has a job at McCade & Manchester, it wouldn’t be hard for Malcolm to casually bring the visit up the next time she’s at the office. “I went to the library. One of their staff members was at the Illuminate Hope gala the other night,” I respond brightly. “I wanted to thank them for their contribution to the foundation.”

He moves through the kitchen like a predator on the prowl. His footsteps echo and stalk from left to right until suddenly, he appears behind me, his presence sending shivers down my spine. “This doesn’t have anything to do with that silly little auction you were involved with the other day, does it?”

Malcolm asked me how the event went when I got home that night. I told him it was fine, but I didn't share all the details. I'm sure I have Nora to thank for telling Malcolm what I wouldn't. "Yes, it did. The McCade Library staff member was the one I spent the evening with. We discussed the foundation and his position at the library."

"Fascinating," he replies dryly while reaching out to grab my waist. His fingers curl around my hip bone, securing me firmly in his grasp. "What is his position, Carrie?"

There's a subtle hint of frustration in his tone that makes me shift uncomfortably against him. "He's uh, he does Acquisitions for the library, I think. He seemed like a nice young man. I think he said he just finished college. I didn't really pay much attention to him."

Malcolm's grip tightens, and I bite my bottom lip to keep from gasping at the sharpness of the pain. "Don't ever do anything like that again, Carrie. You are my wife," he says in a low, menacing tone. "You are expected to act like my wife. I expect you to hold yourself to a high degree of professionalism at all times, especially where men are involved. Never, *ever* sell yourself like some common whore. And don't you ever speak to that librarian again. Do you hear me?"

"Yes, of course," I appease him. "I should have stood my ground against Sophie when she brought up the idea. This is all my fault."

Malcolm releases my hip, and I breathe a sigh of relief as the ache dissipates. "Yes, it is," he agrees. "But you can make it up to me." He walks into the dining room and I know I'm expected to follow.

I set down the potato I'm working on and quickly wash my hands. When I reach the dining room, Malcolm has already taken a seat at the head of the table. He's tugging on his belt and patting his thighs. "You used to love this game," he teases. "Now, get under the table and show me how sorry you are that you disappointed me."

We have a good sex life, and I enjoy having sex with my husband. But something about his tone doesn't sit right with me.

But I get on my knees and crawl under the table anyway. These are just the kind of games men and women play, right? I did a bad thing, and these are the consequences. My brain justifies that a forced blowjob is better than my ex-husband, beating me every time I didn't do what he wanted me to do."

Chapter 10

Jackson

It's time to visit daddy dearest.

It's been a few months since I last spoke to Malcolm. He was calling me a deranged piece of shit for showing up at his barber shop unannounced, but it was just a coincidence. After all, I needed a haircut, too. And if the place was good enough for my father, it was good enough for me.

So what if I called his office and pretended to be his son, Xavier? Who cares if I asked his receptionist when his appointment would be so we could get our hair cut together? Tuesday at 3:00 pm worked perfectly for me. Deranged? Hardly. Just a son wanting to spend time with his dear ol' dad.

The last time I saw Malcolm, I asked him to speak to the hiring committee for the Acquisitions position at the library. My father said I was under-qualified, but I told him he didn't need to mention that to the committee unless he wanted the entire town to find out about his indiscretions.

But this time, I want to visit him because I need money. Carrie might not have come from wealth, but she's probably gotten used to it since marrying my father. If I want to take her on a few nice dates and wine and dine her the way he has, I'm going to need some capital.

My face must be on file at McCade & Manchester, though, because the current secretary frowns when I walk through the door. "Sir," she begins, "you can't be here."

I blow past her. She barely has time to pick up the phone and dial Malcolm's office before I burst through the door. "Hey Mal," I smile, "it's me. Your baby boy."

He's on the phone, presumably with the secretary, and slams it down in anger. "What the fuck are you doing here? Francine," he yells, "call the police."

"Francine," I toss a look over my shoulder, "he doesn't mean that. Do you, Malcolm?" The tight look on my face indicates I'm not here to play games.

Malcolm grinds his teeth together in frustration before growling, "*Don't* call the police, Francine. It's fine."

I slam the door shut behind me, and the walls vibrate in response. "C'mon, Malcolm, you're not happy to see me?"

"You ever show up here and call yourself my baby boy in front of everyone again, I'll kill you where you stand." He doesn't bother getting up, which is a shame because it would be respectful to greet your son with a hug. But Malcolm's never been the respectable kind of guy. A real pity, if you ask me. "What do you want, Jackson?"

I plop down on the leather chair in front of his desk, relishing its softness and how it conforms to my body. I nonchalantly prop my feet on the edge of the pristine mahogany, taking in the intricate carvings and ornate details that scream wealth and success. "I hope I don't scuff the wood," I say as I drag the heel of my shoe across the edge vindictively.

Malcolm is more patient than I have ever given him credit for. If he treated me this way, I'd probably knock his head off. But he only crosses his arms and breathes a deep sigh of disappointment. "I hope I don't accidentally choke you to death."

"So cranky today," I cluck my tongue. "It's like you don't want to benevolently give your son \$20,000 to help him achieve his lifelong dream of getting his pilot license."

He snorts in amusement. Malcolm's arms come unfolded from his chest, falling by his sides as he shakes his head at me with a mixture of disbelief and humor on his face. "You know, if you were anyone else, I might like you. You're pretty plucky for a twenty-five-year-old. But for someone blackmailing me on a semi-annual basis, you're a prick."

"Awww," I give him a watery smile, "you keep track of all our visits? That's so sweet. I love you, too, Daddy."

"You love me so much that you spent \$2,500 to spend the night with my wife," he accuses.

I knew it was only a matter of time before he heard about the gala. I can't help but feel a sense of satisfaction, and a mischievous smirk plays on my lips as I revel in the fact that I've been caught. Like the cat who caught the canary, I can't contain my glee at being found out. "Someone had to spend the night with her, Mal. Might as well have been family, right?"

His jaw tightens, the muscles in his face visibly clenching as he leans forward. His hands grip the edge of the desk, knuckles turning white with the force of his hold. He leans in closer, his stomach pressing firmly against the cool surface of the wood. The tension radiating from him is palpable. "Listen here, Jackson. I'm only going to tell you this once. Stay away from my family. Stay away from my son. Stay away from my wife. Hell, stay away from my *ex-wife*."

I let him have his little rant because I know emotions are high. The air between us crackles with unspoken anger and betrayal, the tension thick enough to cut with a knife. When you find out that your wife spent the evening with a much younger, more charming man, it can put a guy on edge. Malcolm deserves to rant all he wants.

But I'm not going to stop. Carrie is the ultimate prize, the key to unlocking Malcolm's perfect little world. When I pry her away from him, everything else will crumble, and he will be left in ruins, broken beyond repair. His entire existence hinges on her, and I will tear them apart with savage glee.

"You can make all the demands you want, Malcolm, but I don't have to follow any of them when I'm the one holding all the cards." I force myself to stifle a yawn, showing my father how bored I am with this conversation. "I like Carrie. She's a nice girl. Much too nice for the likes of you. The twisted thing is, if you would just tell her the truth, she probably wouldn't even look twice at me. She seems like the kind of loyal, ride-or-die girl that'll always have your back. But you're lying to her. You're lying to everyone."

Malcolm's gaze narrows as he pins me with a withering glare. "Don't comment on my marriage. You know nothing about Carrie and me."

I match his pose, removing my feet from his desk and leaning forward to shorten the gap between us. "You're right. I know nothing about you and Carrie. I don't know why you chose to leave Victoria for her. I don't know what she sees in you. I don't know why you're cheating on her. And don't tell me you're not," I scoff before he can argue. "A man with your kind of *respect* for women probably got syphilis at his bachelor party. You're not a good guy, Malcolm, and I'm going to make your wife see that."

"I'm telling you," he begins, but I cut him off.

"And I'm telling you," I speak over him, "I'm going to take everything from you. Starting with your precious, innocent little wife. When I'm through with her, she's going to wonder why she ever settled for the likes of you."

Chapter 11

Carrie

The other night with my husband leaves a sour taste in my mouth.

As I crawled under the kitchen table and performed a degrading act that I used to enjoy, I could feel Malcolm's cold eyes on me, mocking my submission. Memories of my ex-husband flooded back as I recalled how he used to kick and slap me and then act as if nothing ever happened.

"But it was just a blowjob," I tell myself. "He didn't hurt me." I justify my inaction with reason. Malcolm probably meant the act to be sexy and fun, like all the other games we play. He didn't mean to hurt my feelings or make me feel dirty. Malcolm was trying to turn a heated, tense moment into something fun.

But something he said sticks in my head. *'And don't you ever speak to that librarian again.'*

Malcolm is a very detail-oriented man. In his line of work, it's practically a requirement. I told him moments before that Jackson's job at the McCade Library was in Acquisitions, but Malcolm purposefully got it wrong. Almost like he already knew the guy.

It occurs to me that Nora could have filled him in, and then Malcolm did the same thing as me. He probably looked Jackson up and got angry that I spent the evening with a younger, attractive man. Perhaps jealousy and insecurity drove him to get Jackson's position wrong on purpose.

I feel silly picking up the phone and calling the library. When someone answers, I almost hang up out of fear. But I stutter through asking her if she can redirect me to Jackson Reid's office. And though my hands are shaking, when I hear his sweet, warm voice come over the line, my nerves are instantly calmed.

"Jackson Reid, Acquisitions. How can I help you?"

I pat myself on the back for deciding to call him instead of showing up. It's easier to distance myself from him if I can't see him. Because I'm afraid if Jackson kisses me again, I won't be able to stop myself from kissing him back. "H-hey," I greet. "It's Carrie Pennington. I have a question for you."

He drops the professional veneer and slips into the comforting tone I've come to look forward to. "Carrie," I can hear him smiling through the phone, "it'll be my pleasure to answer any questions you may have."

The way he emphasizes the word *'pleasure'* makes my heart skip a beat. *I'm a married woman with a wonderful sex life*, I remind myself. "I, uh, well, it's about my husband." A blush heats my cheeks as if my subconscious is ashamed to admit I'm married. I try to shake it off, but the shame doesn't budge.

"What about him?" Jackson asks, his tone neutral.

How do I say what I want to say? Do I come right out and announce that my husband found out about our dinner the other night and seemed jealous that we'd spent time together?

I clear my throat, giving myself a few more seconds to think. "Do you know Malcolm, by any chance?"

A hush falls over the line, broken only by the gentle rustling of fabric gliding across leather as Jackson shifts in his seat. "Perhaps this is a discussion we should have in person."

My brain tells me *no*, but my mouth is faster. “Of course. Do you have time to meet today?” I realize what I’ve done a moment too late. Agreeing to meet with him puts me in the line of fire again.

But Jackson hops on my mistake almost as quickly as I make it. “Great. Do you want to grab coffee around 11:00? There’s a coffee shop on Poyntz, Flight Crew, that I’ve always wanted to try.”

That’s down the street and around the corner from my husband’s law office. I don’t think Malcolm would walk to Flight Crew and grab a drink when he could have one of his underlings do it for him, but what about lunch? What if he wants to go to the brewing company? Or what if he wants to grab a burger at Spark? He’ll see me in Flight Crew’s big, open windows with Jackson—a man he told me not to see again.

“It’ll be a quick conversation, right?” I bite the tip of my thumbnail, chipping the polish from my last trip to the manicurist.

Jackson chuckles on the other end of the line, but I’m not sure why. “As short or as long as you’d like, Carrie.”

The little voice in my head tells me this isn’t a good idea, but I’ve never been one for good ideas. “Alright. Flight Crew at 11:00.”

This might be another mistake, but it’s one worth making. Something about Malcolm’s attitude toward Jackson the other day felt off. Maybe it’s all in my head.

But what if it’s not?

Chapter 12

Jackson

I don't need to see Carrie in person to discuss my connection with Malcolm. For starters, I'm not going to tell her that he's my father, and I've been blackmailing him for the better part of the last four years. That information will come out in due time. However, the thought of seeing her face-to-face again ignites a thrill within me.

I know why she's nervous to meet at Flight Crew. The location is suspiciously close to McCade & Manchester. She's probably worried that someone will see her and report back to Malcolm. Frankly, I'd love it if they did.

I can vividly picture Malcolm in my mind, his usually composed features contorted with anger as he bursts into the coffee shop. His cheeks flush a deep shade of red, and his eyes glass over with fury as he attempts to approach his wife and demand that she leave with him. He wouldn't want to cause a scene, but he's dealing with the wrong person if he wants to keep things quiet.

Without hesitation, I would announce to Carrie and everyone else in the bustling coffee shop that I'm Malcolm McCade's abandoned love child. The satisfaction of exposing his secret would be enough for me, even if it didn't quite satisfy my desire for revenge.

Someone taps me on the shoulder, dragging me back to reality. And when I turn around and see Carrie standing behind me, what a beautiful reality it is.

"Hey," I smile down at her. "What do you want to drink? I think I'm going to try the Orville."

Carrie peers past me at the menu, squinting to read the tiny print. "That's just an almond milk hazelnut latte," she frowns. "Why is it called Orville?"

"It's their theme." I use my chin to gesture at the two baristas standing behind the counter. "See? They're dressed in flight attendant uniforms. All their drinks are flight-themed. It's kind of cute."

"Cute?" She doesn't sound like she agrees with me. "The Nose Dive has six shots of espresso. That could kill someone."

The exasperation in her tone is pretty cute, too. "I'll get that next time," I tell her with a wink.

Carrie orders the International, a French vanilla latte. "How often do you come to Manhattan?" She asks as we wait for our drinks.

"More often than you'd think. My mom lives near the city park, and I visit at least once a week. Sometimes, more often, if she's got a heavier work schedule. Ever since I moved out a few years ago, she's replaced me with three cats, a bird, and a fish tank. She's quite meticulous about keeping the house clean, but sometimes, when she's working double shifts, it helps to have someone around to feed her pets and tidy up." I also come back to Manhattan to keep tabs on my father, but that's immaterial.

The barista hands us our drinks and I allow Carrie to pick where she wants to sit. I'm not surprised when she chooses the darkest corner of the coffee shop, away from the windows overlooking Poyntz Avenue. "I hope this isn't too forward, but where's your father in this picture?"

Currently? Just down the street in a palatial office that Carrie and I are very familiar with. In the grand scheme of things? Across town in a mansion that I'll never come close to being able to afford. "My father was never in the picture. He left before I was born."

"I'm sorry," Carrie frowns. "I didn't mean to bring up bad memories."

I shake my head. “You didn’t. I’m twenty-five. I’ve had plenty of time to be angsty about not celebrating Father’s Day and not having a man in my life to teach me how to shave or talk to girls. Thank God for the internet, am I right?” I grin.

Carrie takes a delicate sip of her latte, and a content smile spreads across her face as she savors the rich and aromatic flavors dancing on her tongue. “So your mother isn’t seeing anyone?”

“No. Well, I don’t know.” I like to think that Elaine would tell me if she had someone special in her life, but she doesn’t have to. I don’t tell her when I’m seeing someone. “I’ve never known my mother to date much, frankly. I remember a couple of guys growing up, but they disappeared after a while. She never introduced me to a man she wasn’t serious about.”

The color fades from Carrie’s face. “I wish I would have had the same morals as your mother. My first husband died when our daughter was very young, and I was still a teenager. I brought a lot of guys home that I wasn’t serious about. I never meant to hurt Kaye by doing it, but I was a single mom, and it was tough to find free time between parenting and working two jobs.”

“Those are choices you made in the past. Maybe your daughter is upset about what you did, maybe not. But you can’t change it, so why keep beating yourself up over it?”

Carrie cocks her head. “You don’t have regrets? Things you think about when you’re lying in bed at night or when you wake up at 3:00 am and can’t go back to sleep?”

A flutter of agitation ripples through my chest, causing my heart to spasm. I quickly take a sip of my drink and hold it in my mouth, allowing the warm liquid to calm me before responding. “I have plenty of regrets. There are a hundred things I wish I had done differently. Like in high school, when I asked Misty Warren to prom with a huge prom-posal, and she turned me down in front of everyone. That scarred me for life,” I joke.

“What’s a prom-posal?” Carrie asks. “I didn’t attend high school in person after having Kaye.”

Sometimes, I forget I’m not talking to an average person who went high school, joined clubs, played sports, and attended Friday night football games. Carrie is different than any other woman I’ve ever met. Her life was marred by circumstances I’ll never be able to relate to.

“Prom-posals are really thought out, really planned events where someone asks someone else to prom. I tried recreating that moment from the Heath Ledger movie, where he serenaded the girl and danced through the bleachers. But apparently, Misty was only using me for help in math class. She was actually dating one of the linebackers on the football team, and she just laughed at me.” A wave of embarrassment washes over me as I remember that cringe-worthy event. I shake my head in disbelief, realizing how naive and foolish I was back then.

Carrie winces alongside me. “Maybe I should be glad that’s something I never had to go through.”

I clear my throat and change the subject, no longer wanting to relive my embarrassing high school memories. “So, you wanted to talk about something?”

“Oh, yes,” she nods quickly. “This might be awkward, given what’s happened. But do you know my husband?”

“Yes,” I admit. “I know Malcolm McCade.”

Chapter 13

Carrie

My heart plummets into the pit of my stomach, a feeling of overwhelming dread washing over me like a tidal wave. “Oh god,” I gasp, barely able to speak. “He...he sent you, didn’t he?” My mind races with wild thoughts, panic setting in and making me babble out a desperate theory. “He’s testing me...testing my loyalty. That’s how he found out about you.” The fear in my voice is palpable as I try to make sense of the situation, my hands shaking uncontrollably.

Jackson laughs at me; he doesn’t even try to hide it. “Wow. For starters, let me just say that I’m flattered you would think I’m good-looking enough to be hired to test your loyalty or whatever.”

My cheeks flush a bright crimson as my inner critic begins to berate me for my constant mistakes and poor choices.

“But no, that’s not how I know Malcolm.” As Jackson’s laughter slows, a smile remains on his lips. “I worked at McCade & Manchester for a few months in college. I think it was after we met, actually,” he explains. “I worked as a legal secretary for Douglas Manchester for a while. He was kind of a prick, but not like Malcolm was. I didn’t even work with the guy, but he was an asshole to me.”

As I try to form a response, I realize that I am torn between two conflicting opinions. On one hand, everyone speaks highly of my husband, and I have always believed them. On the other, Jackson is the first person to speak ill of him.

“That was just my experience,” Jackson adds quickly. “I’m sure other people enjoy working for him. But he and I never quite saw eye to eye. I left McCade & Manchester a few months later when the library offered me more hours. I forgot about him, really, until you mentioned that the two of you were married.”

I breathe a sigh of relief. He isn’t a hired gun to report to my husband about my infidelity. “That’s probably why he told me not to see you again.”

Jackson looks at me, surprised. “You talked to Malcolm about us?”

I rush to correct him. “No, not exactly. But it got brought up the other day, and he was upset. He didn’t know about the-the kissing or anything, but he told me to stay away from you. I think he was upset about the whole auction thing. He has a reputation in this town, and his wife being sold to the highest bidder doesn’t really jive with that reputation.”

“Well, that’s silly.” Jackson takes a sip of his drink. “It was another way for your team to raise money for Illuminate Hope. There was no reason for him to be upset.”

“That’s what I thought, but Malcolm can be touchy about things like that. He has a lot of redeeming qualities, but that’s not one of them,” I admit disrespectfully.

Jackson nods along. “I understand. A lot of people believe the sun shine’s out of their partner’s ass, but it’s refreshing to see someone who knows that their partner has good and bad qualities.”

“He’s a good man. He has a lot of good qualities.” I should have led with that. I never should have said that Malcolm’s possessiveness and reputation were bad.

“Hey, you don’t have to justify or explain yourself to me. I’m not going to tell anyone what we talk about.” Jackson reaches across the table to put his hand on mine. “I’m just a sounding board for your feelings, Carrie. What we talk about stays between us.”

I don't know if I believe him, but he hasn't said anything to anyone so far. "Can-can I ask you something?"

He nods in agreement. "Of course. You can ask me anything."

That's what I'm afraid of. "What do you want from me, Jackson? Because I don't get it."

"What don't you get?" He asks while cocking his head. "That I find you attractive? That I find you interesting? That I want to get to know you better?"

"That I'm married, and you aren't willing to back off." I look pointedly at his hand, which is still resting atop mine. "Most men would hear a woman saying *no thanks* and take that to mean *no thanks*."

Jackson's audacity is undeniable; I'll give him that much. Instead of quickly retracting his hand and offering an apology, he boldly squeezes my hand instead. The unexpected gesture makes my heart skip a beat in both surprise and appreciation. "If I thought you really wanted me to back off, I would. But when I was kissing you outside your car and in the library the other day, you were kissing me back."

I am completely taken aback, my mind thrown into disarray and unable to form a coherent response. My initial instinct is to place the blame squarely on him for all that has transpired, but deep down, I know he's right.

"It's okay, you know. Maybe it doesn't feel like it because we're told by society that we're supposed to be monogamous and happy with one person for the rest of our lives. But what happens when you're happy with one person for a while, and someone comes along that makes you even happier?"

His words speak to something inside me; they awaken a beast I didn't know existed. "I believe in monogamy," I whisper.

Jackson squeezes my hand again. "So do I, actually. But weren't you Malcolm's mistress? Isn't that what you told me all those years ago? Can you say, with complete certainty, that he's not cheating on you?"

I spring up from the table, my chair scraping loudly against the floor. In my haste, I knock over my latte. Espresso and steamed milk spill on the table and careen over the edge to the floor. "I-I'm sorry," I apologize. "I have to go. I'm so sorry."

Pushing past Jackson, I race out of Flight Crew and onto the street. Fresh air engulfs my lungs like fire, stretching and expanding them past their breaking point.

Why did he have to say that? Why did Jackson have to speak my fears into existence?

Chapter 14

Jackson

When things get complicated, I text the Brew Crew. The five of us have been friends for various lengths of time, but we all have one thing in common: when times get tough, we have a beer and talk it out.

JACKSON
Poker?

ETHAN

Beer?

DUSTIN

When?

PIERCE

I'll bring buffalo chicken dip.

RUSSELL

Strippers?

But sometimes, the group chat gets a little rowdy. Or, more accurately, *Russell* gets a little rowdy.

JACKSON
Beer? Yes. When? Tonight. Strippers? No.

RUSSELL

No strippers = I'm bringing tequila. Are you prepared for that?

PIERCE

I'll bring buffalo chicken dip and Tylenol. Someone's giving me a headache already.

RUSSELL

Someone's being a killjoy already***

Fixed it for ya, Pierce

PIERCE

Fuck you

Some days, it feels like we're masters of the universe and have it all figured out. On other days, it feels like we're a bunch of drunk toddlers. I might have been better off *not* proposing a poker night than trying to get five irresponsible fucks together to solve problems smarter men than us can't even comprehend.

Dustin texts me on the side to say that everyone will be at my place at 8:00. That makes me feel a little better, but only in the sense that someone else is volunteering to herd the cats.

I force myself to return to work, my mind racing with distractions. After cleaning up the mess Carrie left behind and apologizing to the Flight Crew staff, the realization set in that the woman I'm targeting for my father's downfall might be more skittish than I initially thought. It's an emotional blow on several levels.

For starters, it sets my progress back. I was hoping to have this all wrapped up by Christmas so I could present Malcolm with

a nice present: his tattered life in ruins. But if I have to slow down—or, God forbid, come up with a new idea entirely—my Christmas plans are ruined.

On the other hand, and I'm trying very hard to pretend this part doesn't exist, I kind of like Carrie. She's beautiful, there's no denying that. But when you crack her open and get to the heart of her fears and insecurities, there's something undeniably intriguing about her.

Carrie knows where she's gone wrong in life. She acknowledges and accepts fault for her wrongdoings. And I feel like she wants to change and be a better person.

In a sense, that makes me feel guilty. Instead of trying to help her, I'm the asshole making things worse. I'm giving her new regrets and wrongdoings to beat herself up about in a few more years.

"Don't think like that," I scold myself. "She made her choice when she started an affair with a married man." I have to remind myself that she might be innocent now, but she didn't start that way. Carrie broke up a marriage and a family. If I think of her as anything less than a pawn in Malcolm's game, I might crack and tell her everything too soon.

Someone knocks on my office door, disrupting the quiet. Then, after a long second, the doorknob twists, and the wood creaks. "Hey," Pierce greets with a wince as he pokes his head in, "figured I'd come up and apologize."

Of the five of us in the Brew Crew, Pierce is the newest addition. He's worked at the McCade Library for nearly as long as I have. But when I transitioned to Acquisitions after graduation, he went into Information Technology. I have no idea what he does besides sit behind a computer all day and keep our systems afloat.

"Hey. Come in," I usher him forward. "Don't apologize."

"No, I should," he says with a sigh. Pierce closes the door behind him before taking one of the two chairs in front of my desk. "I always let Russ rile me up."

Russell's personality is an acquired taste, one that takes time to fully appreciate. I first met him at a volunteer community clean-up event a few years ago, and my initial impression was not a positive one. But as I spent more time with him, Russell's eccentricities began to grow on me. Despite his reputation as a frat boy who only cared about beer pong and what girl wound up in his bed on a Saturday night, he has undergone a remarkable transformation to become a devoted Environmental Scientist.

I wave off Pierce's concerns with a dismissive gesture. "It's fine. Really. I think we're all pretty used to it by now. Dustin said you guys were coming over anyway, so it's fine."

"It's been a while since anyone last called a meeting of the minds. Is everything okay?" Pierce's analytical mind kicks into overdrive.

If there's anyone I'd trust with my plan, it's him. I've known Ethan all my life, and Dustin and I have been friends since high school. But if there's one person I could trust wholeheartedly, someone I know would never tell anyone my secrets, it's Pierce.

But plausible deniability is a hell of a drug. One of these days, if Malcolm comes after me, I don't want there to be people who have to lie on my behalf. But a hypothetical never hurt...

"Say you and I are sitting down to dinner, and I tell the server I'd like a bowl of soup. You say hey, that sounds good; I'd also like a bowl of soup. But the server tells us there's only one bowl of soup left."

Pierce's eyebrows furrow in confusion. "So, you can have the soup? I don't really like soup anyway."

"It's not about the soup," I interrupt him. "Pretend you really want the soup. Maybe I pissed you off or something, and you think having the soup would be a way to get back at me. A way to stick it to the man, per se. Would you pull the server aside and tell him to bring you the soup instead?"

"Me?" Pierce presses his hand to his chest. "Personally? No. I'm not that kind of guy. That sounds like a dick move, frankly."

And that's another reason I can't tell him about what's going on. Because, in the grand scheme of things, he wouldn't understand. I don't think any of my friends would.

My childhood was defined by the absence of a father figure. A fact that, while not uncommon, still left a deep and lasting impact on me. But it wasn't until I confronted Malcolm that I found out he never wanted me. He wanted my mother to have an abortion because it would have made his life easier if I didn't exist. And that knowledge makes me angry.

“Yeah, you’re right,” I echo Pierce’s last sentiments. “It’s a dick move.”

I should forgive and forget. Maybe try that Jesus thing where you turn the other cheek.

But that doesn’t feel like a satisfying conclusion.

Chapter 15

Carrie

The atmosphere at the dinner table is tense and oppressive, the only sounds coming from the clinking of silverware and the quiet hum of Malcolm's phone. I take a moment to study his face—lined with age yet still handsome. His features are etched with weariness and a hint of frustration as he scrolls through whatever holds his attention on the glowing screen.

My husband is aging like fine wine. There's no doubt that he's still going to be turning heads when he's sixty. Malcolm's muscular physique is a testament to his dedication to fitness, carefully watching his diet, and never overindulging in alcohol. He takes great care of himself, almost as if he knows he is preserving his body for the next woman who may catch his eye. His presence exudes confidence and vitality, making it hard not to be drawn to him.

I can admit that I'm insecure, and Malcolm's attention to his phone makes me uneasy. My previous relationships were marred by betrayal and emotional manipulation that left me questioning my worth. It leads me to ask, "Who are you texting?" I blurt out what's on my mind before I can stop myself, allowing my insecurities to rule over me.

Malcolm's fingers pause mid-swipe, and he slowly raises his head to meet my gaze. His eyebrows furrow in confusion as if wondering why I would interrupt him. "A client. Is there a problem?" The light from his phone screen casts a faint glow on his face, highlighting the sharp angles of his jawline and the slight crease between his eyebrows. He shifts in his seat, adjusting his posture to one that commands respect.

I should let it go. I can feel the warning in his tone, a subtle shift in pitch that conveys his growing impatience. The air around us vibrates with tension, like a coiled spring waiting to snap. But my stubborn frustration won't let me give in that easily, and my words spill out in a rambling stream fueled by emotion and desperation. "It's dinner time, Mal. We're supposed to be dining together. You and me. Not you, me, and your iPhone."

With a gentle clink, he sets the device on the polished wooden table next to his half-finished plate of food. I watch intently as Malcolm fidgets with his fingers, tapping them against the smooth surface in an attempt to mask his growing impatience. "Is there something you'd like to talk about? I'm all ears."

I part my lips, ready to speak, but the words catch in my throat and refuse to come out. My tongue feels heavy as I struggle to form a single syllable.

"Yes, that's what I thought," he replies irritably. "When you have something worth listening to, let me know. Otherwise, I have work to do." Malcolm picks his phone up and goes back to texting.

Phrasing is everything.

Four years ago, I told Malcolm he had to choose whether to stay married to Victoria or be with me. He tried to talk me down and make me accept less, but I was coming off an empowering conversation with Jackson. I stood my ground and gave him an ultimatum. He could have his wife, or he could have me.

My confidence that day led to our marriage a year later. It led to a diamond engagement ring worth 5 figures. It led to a beautiful home in a part of town that I never imagined being able to live in. It led to the life I'm living now.

In some ways, it was exactly what I needed. Malcolm's money allowed Kaye to take SAT prep courses and get a private tutor. He paid for her college tuition. He's even hired her to work in his law office in place of his son, Xavier. His kindness has opened so many doors for my daughter.

But phrasing is everything.

If he had apologized and said that he had a demanding client, I would have given him the benefit of the doubt.

But instead, he insinuated that I didn't have anything to say that he wanted to hear.

I clear my throat and get to my feet, pulling the napkin from my lap and dropping it on the table. "Excuse me. I've lost my appetite."

Malcolm doesn't even look up. A small smile plays on the corners of his lips, and I feel justified in my actions. He used to smile like that when he was texting me.

I leave the room without another word. I love my husband, but there are some things about him that I could live without. And right now, being ignored in favor of some girl on the other end of his phone is one of them.

I head upstairs, strip off my clothes, and climb into our oversized bathtub. The water fills around me, scented bubbles popping up with each passing second.

I go to the Facebook app on my phone and look up Jackson's profile again. Then, I tap on the *'add friend'* button.

I've pretended not to notice how Malcolm looks at other women when we're out together. I laugh when he flirts with them right in front of me. I'm a good wife. I cook and clean and do everything he asks of me. I bet Victoria did, too.

It's one thing to suspect that my husband is cheating on me. It's another thing entirely to make the decision to cheat on him, too.

I've spent my entire life playing by the rules, even when they changed in the middle of the game. And it's gotten me nowhere.

Fuck the rules.

Fuck my husband.

It's my turn to be happy.

Chapter 16

Jackson

“I’m not crushing a beer on a weeknight.” Dustin gives Russell a patronizing look. “*Some of us* have to work tomorrow.”

Russell lets out an exasperated sigh, rolling his eyes as he absentmindedly runs his fingers over the smooth surface of the playing cards in his hands. “Fighting fires can’t be that hard,” he scoffs. “Someone start a fire. I’ll show you how easy it is to grab the extinguisher from under the sink and put it out.”

Ethan snorts, and quickly tries to cover up his amusement with a cough, but the smirk on his face gives him away.

“Fire extinguisher is empty, actually,” I mumble. I stare at the cards in my hand, willing the nine to become an ace. “One of my neighbors had a fire a few weeks back. Left one of those little desk heater things on or something.”

Dustin’s jaw drops and he lays his cards down in shock. Everyone sees his hand, but it isn’t a good one anyway. “I swear to God. If I had a dollar for every space heater electrical fire I had to put out, I’d be rich enough to retire from being a firefighter. Those damn things should be illegal.”

“But my office is really cold,” Pierce frowns. “And I have a thyroid issue. Sometimes I get chilly.”

“I fold,” Dustin quickly says. “Would you rather burn down the building or be cold for a few minutes?”

Pierce tries to hold back a laugh, but he can’t. “Chill out, dude. I’m just kidding. Not about the thyroid part,” he says seriously, “but I can’t use a space heater. It has to stay cold in that room because that’s where our servers are. But I did bring one of those heated blankets to work last winter, and it’s been a game changer.”

“What the hell is a thyroid?” Russell asks as he lays down his cards.

Ethan, Pierce, and I are the only ones left in the game. I fold as well because I’ve got nothing.

As Pierce goes on an educational mission to inform Russell about the importance of getting your thyroid checked, I excuse myself to use the bathroom.

I love my friends. I’ve known Dustin for two decades, and he’s always been the more level-headed of the two of us. I met Ethan in high school when we tried out for soccer together. Russell keeps us adventurous, and Pierce keeps us on our toes. We work well within the dynamic we’ve formed, even if we do butt heads from time to time.

I thought they’d help me get my mind off Carrie, but so far, all they’re doing is driving me crazy. I use the bathroom break to take a few deep breaths and remind myself that it’s good to have friends, even if they won’t stop fighting over stupid shit.

When I leave the bathroom, I make a beeline straight for the kitchen. In my tiny apartment, there isn’t much difference between the kitchen, dining room, and living room. It has an open-concept floor plan, which blurs the lines between the functions of each space.

“Jackson,” Dustin snaps at me. “Tell Ethan that he’s not doing the one-chip challenge. He’ll burn his esophagus.”

“My god,” Ethan grumbles under his breath. “Can’t burn down the apartment. Can’t burn through your own esophagus. Who invited Smokey the Bear to poker night?”

Russell dissolves into laughter and slaps his knee. “I’m changing your name in my phone to Smokey the Bear.”

“I hate all of you.” Dustin’s eyes dart around the table, pinning each of us with a scowl.

“How about we don’t do the one-chip challenge because I don’t want to see Ethan throw up in my dining room?” I offer. “The last time someone threw up,” I give Russell a pointed look, “I had to get the carpet professionally cleaned because the fibers were stuck together and hard.”

Pressing a hand to his chest defensively, Russell shakes his head at my assertion. “I was not responsible for that. You were feeding me tequila jello shots.”

“Oh, god,” I groan. “That explains why the carpet was green and sticky. I thought you ruptured a kidney or something.”

Dustin clears his throat to add, “Medically, that isn’t what would happen if someone ruptured a kidney.”

Russell rounds on him with another eye roll. “This is why no one likes you. You always have to be right.”

“It’s easy when you’re always wrong,” Dustin replies matter-of-factly.

Russell flips Dustin the bird. Dustin tells Russell to fuck off. It’s the circle of life when the five of us get together.

Clearing his throat to speak over the bickering boys, Ethan asks how things are going. “No offense, but you usually don’t host poker night. You wait until one of us offers.”

“Yeah, because you guys are pigs,” I snort. “I’m going to have to vacuum when you leave.”

A flurry of eyes fall to the ground. Sure enough, a litter of chip crumbs and discarded packages surrounds them. “Oh,” Ethan purses his lips. “You should rip this carpet up. Much faster to sweep than pull out the vacuum.”

“It’s a rental, dumb ass. If I rip out the carpet, I’m not getting my deposit back when I move out.”

Ethan opens his mouth to respond but then thinks better of what he’s going to say and closes it. Instead, he nods his head in agreement.

“Besides, maybe I wanted you guys to come over, trash my place, and give me a good reason to clean up. Someone spilled queso on the counter. The floors need vacuuming. If someone could pee on the couch, we’d have a real party.”

Russell lowers his voice and whisper-yells behind his hand, “Someone got their man-period. Does anyone have any Midol?” His comment is welcomed with a lukewarm reception. Pierce throws a chip at him, which only serves to dirty my apartment further.

“Seriously though,” Dustin changes the subject. “What’s up? Ethan’s kind of right. You usually don’t invite us over.”

I have the smallest apartment of the five of us. Ethan works in advertising and can afford a lavish condo in Manhattan near the bar district. While Dustin isn’t making a fortune as a firefighter, Daddy’s money helped him buy a house right out of college, and the only debt he has is a car payment. Pierce’s job in tech pays well enough, and that doesn’t even include the side gigs he has so he can save up for early retirement. And Russell makes a boatload of money from the three rental properties he owns. I’m not close to poverty by any means, but I’m not buying season tickets to see the Chiefs at Arrowhead Stadium, either.

“Probably girl problems,” Russell adds his two cents. “You didn’t knock anyone up, right?”

I shudder at the thought. I don’t mind kids, but I am not ready to have my own. “God, no. I wear a condom every time.”

Russell tilts his head knowingly. “*Every* time?” He asks in disbelief. “Because there are times when she’s on birth control and—”

“Every time,” I cut him off. “Not that I don’t believe the women I’m with, but I feel safer when I bring my own protection. Hell, I came close to getting a vasectomy last year, but my mom talked me out of it. She said when I got older, I’d want kids of my own. But I’m not too sure about all that.”

Dustin frowns. “You can’t *not* have kids. Everyone wants to have kids.”

I pop the top on a cold Bud Light and shake my head. “I’m not everyone, Dusty. Kids are fine, but I think I’m too selfish to be a father.”

“Get un-selfish then,” Dustin glares. “Having kids is one of life’s greatest joys.”

“Aren’t you seeing a single mom or something?” Ethan mumbles.

The room erupts into chaos as every head swivels to look at Dustin. “You’re dating a MILF?” Russell exclaims, sticking his tongue out like a dog. The comment sets off another round of playful teasing, but this time, Dustin grins at the good-natured jabs being thrown his way.

I reach into my back pocket and pull out my phone. As the boys banter back and forth, I lean against the counter and check my notifications.

A text from Oliver with info about his computer. A couple of emails in my work inbox, some marked urgent and others just mundane office updates. A game notification for some word app I downloaded once when I was bored. And a Facebook notification.

Carrie Pennington wants to be friends.

I swipe right as fast as my fingers will let me. The app takes a few seconds to load, but it feels like a lifetime. “Come on,” I whisper, “faster.” Afraid that if I don’t see the notification soon enough, it’ll disappear.

But when it loads, Carrie’s smiling face stares back at me. I slam my finger down on the ‘*accept*’ button, and a new message appears: ‘*You are now friends with Carrie Pennington.*’

I thought after the coffee shop, I’d scared her off for good. But I should stop doubting myself because I couldn’t be any further from the truth.

Chapter 17

Carrie

The next morning, I am startled awake by the sudden sound of my husband flinging open the heavy velvet curtains that cover the window. The bright sunlight pours into the room, causing me to shrink away in protest. The sudden change from darkness to light is jarring, and I struggle to fully awaken from my sleep-induced haze.

“We’re having dinner tonight with Douglas and Jacqueline,” Malcolm announces.

I peek at him from behind the comforter, my eyes beginning to adjust. “Wh-what?” I ask groggily.

Malcolm stands in front of the full-length mirror, his reflection a perfect replica of his tall, lean stature. He fusses with his tie, adjusting it until it lays flat against his crisp white shirt. His eyes meet mine through the clear glass, full of determination and focus. “You heard me, Carrie. We’re having dinner with the Manchesters. I texted Nora last night. She is going to get you a hair and nail appointment this afternoon, and I told her to pick out a dress.”

With a gentle tug, I peel back the thick comforter to expose the rumpled bed sheets. As I sit up, my fingers instinctively reach for my tousled hair, attempting to smooth out any knots and tangles. The cool air of the room brushes against my bare skin, causing goosebumps to rise on my arms. “Hair and nails? What kind of dinner is this?”

He doesn’t take his eyes off of me. “Douglas holds special dinner parties where couples agree to entertain other partners for the evening.”

“This is a *wife swap* party?” I blanch. “Mal, honey.” But he cuts me off before I can finish.

“You don’t have to do anything with anyone,” he rolls his eyes, finally looking away from the reflection of me in the mirror. “But I’ve attended several of these get-togethers, and Douglas has begun to ask why you don’t attend.”

My jaw drops open in shock. “You’ve attended these parties since we’ve been married? You’re sleeping with other people?”

Malcolm looks annoyed that he has to explain this to me. “It’s just sex, Carrie. Frankly, I’d prefer it if you didn’t engage with anyone else tonight, but ultimately, that is your choice. I just want you to know how I would feel if you did happen to entertain another man.”

The pucker of his lips tells me exactly how he’d feel: displeased. I know I shouldn’t say anything, but I feel reckless. “So, *you* can have sex with someone else’s wife, but *I* can’t have sex with someone else’s husband?”

Malcolm’s exasperated sigh echoes through the room, making me feel small and insignificant. The condescending tone of his voice cuts through me like a knife as he carefully enunciates each word, treating me as if I am incapable of understanding. It’s as if I’m a child in his eyes, not worthy of being spoken to as an equal. “I want you to flirt with other men and be a credit to the McCade name. You’re very beautiful, Carrie, but I don’t want another man touching what’s mine. Are we clear?”

Inside, I’m screaming.

Do you realize that this is a double standard? Why didn’t you ask me if I wanted to go? This isn’t what I want to do. How dare you! How dare you have sex with other women and put my health at risk!

But outside, I’m holding it together the best I can. “I’m not feeling well, Malcolm.”

He gives me a sigh of disgust before walking into our adjoining bathroom. When he comes out a few moments later, the scent of

his cologne fills the room. “Feel better by tonight, Carrie. That’s an order. You’re attending this party even if I have to drag you kicking and screaming into Manchester’s mansion.” Malcolm’s tone is cold, even as he crosses the room to drop a warm kiss on my lips. “I love you. I’ll see you after work. Nora will let you know when your hair and nail appointments are.”

The sight of him walking out of the room makes my stomach lurch and twist into agonizing knots. I lay there, immobilized by fear, until the sound of the garage door opening and closing signals his departure.

Only then do I allow myself to make a sound—a guttural scream that tears at my throat and echoes through the empty house, a desperate release of pent-up emotions. I scream until my voice is raw, until there is nothing left but a hollow ache in my chest.

Chapter 18

Jackson

I've never been a Facebook Messenger guy; everybody who needs to talk to me has my number. But now, I find myself checking the damn app every two minutes to see if Carrie has responded.

Nothing happened after I accepted her friend request last night, but I felt better after seeing the request and managed to bro down with my friends once I was sure I had her back on the line. But I was awake half the night trying to figure out my next move.

By the time my alarm went off at 6:00 am, I'd already decided to send her a good morning message. It was painstaking to wait two hours until it was socially acceptable to text someone, but I had an image to protect. Unfortunately, that image took a nosedive once she replied immediately, and our conversation began. I felt like I was back in high school, waiting for the girl I like to text me back.

CARRIE

I'm sorry about yesterday. I didn't mean to rush out of the coffee place like that.

JACKSON

It's okay. I'm sorry if I said something that upset you.

Facebook tells me she's typing. Even though I'm supposed to be writing up a new preservation plan for our most delicate books, I find myself staring at my phone screen, willing her to hit send.

CARRIE

I wasn't upset with you, exactly. I was angry that you were right.

JACKSON

Right about what?

CARRIE

Right about my husband cheating on me. He pretty much told me to my face this morning that it's just sex, so it should be okay.

Malcolm sickens me with his entitled attitude. He exudes the type of arrogance that comes from having wealth and power, believing he can have any woman he desires. It disgusts me how men like him think their overflowing bank accounts give them a free pass to do whatever they please. They see themselves as untouchable, but in reality, they're just morally bankrupt.

JACKSON

I'm sorry about that. I didn't want to be right about it.

CARRIE

You want to hear the crazy thing?

JACKSON

Sure.

CARRIE

I still love him. Even though he's having sex with other women. Even though he wants me to go to some swinger's party tonight. Even though sometimes he's a complete asshole to me. I still love him.

Isn't that sick?

It's appalling when you think about it. It's probably why women stay with their husbands even when they've been beaten and bruised. But Carrie knows all about that; she's been through it before.

JACKSON

I'm not sure what you want me to say. Honestly, I can't sympathize with what you're feeling. If my spouse ever cheated on me, that would be the end of it: love or no love.

It takes her a while to respond, the silence stretching out like a taut rubber band ready to snap. While she ponders her reply, I take advantage of the moment and get a couple of paragraphs for my preservation plan written, my fingers flying across the keyboard with purpose. But before I can fully immerse myself in the project, my phone buzzes insistently on the desk. My train of thought is derailed as I pick up the device.

CARRIE

Do you think I should leave him?

JACKSON

I think you should make yourself a priority in this relationship. You said he wants you to go to a swinger's party? Is that something you're interested in?

CARRIE

Not really. But he told me this morning that I have to go. He's even having my assistant book me an appointment to get my hair and nails done.

My father is a disturbed man. I know all about swingers and their parties, but I thought those parties happened with consent from both husband and wife.

JACKSON

You know that he can't make you have sex with another man, right?

CARRIE

Well, that's the funny thing.

Even if I wanted to, I'm not allowed to have sex with anyone else at the party.

JACKSON

What?

CARRIE

Malcolm wants me there as eye candy to flirt with his law partner and friends, but not to have sex with anyone else.

JACKSON

But he gets to have sex with someone else?

CARRIE

Correct

The more I learn about Malcolm, the more my opinion of him dwindles. His actions and words paint a picture of an untrustworthy and selfish person. It's becoming clear that my mother was just another conquest for him, a pattern in his behavior. She was a disposable object, used for his pleasure and then discarded without a second thought. He deserves every bit of bad karma that comes his way.

JACKSON

I want to say something about your husband, but I don't want to upset you.

CARRIE

I'm already upset, Jackson. Just say it.

JACKSON

If you were my wife, I'd never let another man look at you, let alone flirt with you.

If you were mine, I'd show you every day and night for the rest of my life.

I'm laying it on a little thick, but I hope she understands she is worth more than a man like my father.

Carrie's response comes after a few agonizing minutes, during which I immerse myself in the technical language of my new book preservation plans. As I pour over the intricate details, my phone suddenly vibrates on the desk, jarring me from my focused state of mind.

CARRIE

What if I wanted to be yours, Jackson?

Then, just as swiftly as her message takes my breath away, it's followed by a second.

CARRIE

Only for a night, though. I love my husband...

Her ellipsis leaves much to be desired.

Relationships are complex and unpredictable. You can find yourself loving someone deeply yet no longer enjoying their company. It's a confusing and painful reality that many couples face, staying together out of a sense of duty and love, even as the spark and connection fade away.

JACKSON

I want to give you forever, Carrie, but I can settle for a night.

Falling for Carrie Pennington would be like stepping onto a tightrope without a safety net waiting below.

One of these days, I'm going to reveal myself to her in hopes of watching my father's life crumble to the ground. It would be much harder to do that if I were in love with her. It would be much harder to hurt her if I had feelings for her.

Chapter 19

Carrie

I pull up the top of my dress as far as it will go, but the deep V-neckline plunges halfway to my navel. The material is smooth against my skin, and the sheer fabric reveals just enough, leaving me feeling both exposed and alluring. “I can’t wear this, Nora. I-I can’t. I’m showing too much skin.”

Seated gracefully on the edge of the bed, she studies me with a critical gaze. Her expertly shaped eyebrows are furrowed in deep concentration as she takes in every detail of my appearance. “I don’t know. I think it’s a beautiful dress.”

I turn to stare at myself in the mirror. The bright red fabric is eye-catching, like a fire truck blazing through the streets with its siren on. “I think the word you’re looking for is sexy. *Too* sexy, if you ask me.”

“Malcolm didn’t ask you, though,” Nora adds quietly. “He asked me.”

“Yes,” I reply through gritted teeth, “I’m aware of that.”

I’ve long thought that Nora was working for Malcolm. Though she was gifted to me, my husband pays her wages. I bet in exchange for a position managing my days and a comfortable salary, she’s required to report back any wrongdoings.

Nora pushes off the bed and adjusts the fit of her skirt, smoothing out the material until it’s perfect. “Malcolm will be here to pick you up in a few minutes. I’ll leave you to finish getting ready. Have a good night, Mrs. McCade.”

I didn’t take Malcolm’s last name. As I stood at the altar, making my third trip down the aisle, it dawned on me that adding another last name to my collection probably wasn’t the wisest decision. I’ve tried to explain this to Nora numerous times, but she always seems to conveniently forget. I have a feeling my husband is to blame for her selective memory. He’s been trying to bully me into taking his last name for as long as I can remember.

As if on cue, the garage door opens, signaling Malcolm’s arrival. Nora told me earlier today that he’d be staying late and dressing at the office. I’m not surprised to find him suited up when I make my way downstairs.

“You look lovely,” he smiles, greeting me at the bottom of the staircase. As if donning a mask, Malcolm becomes the man that I fell in love with. He kisses me on the lips, gently at first, and then deepens the kiss until all I want to do is strip off this dress and slip under the covers with him.

“Let’s go upstairs,” I whisper hungrily. I brush off my husband’s erratic behavior these last few days, trying to find an explanation for his sudden change. Perhaps he was ill, his judgment clouded by a fever or sickness.

Malcolm brushes his thumb across my cheek, and for a moment, I think he might say yes. Then he briefly kisses my lips before saying, “We don’t have time for that, Carrie. We have Doug’s event.”

My heart sinks as Malcolm lets go of my hand and makes a beeline for the garage. I can’t help but feel hurt and betrayed, knowing that there are countless men who would give anything for a night of hot sex with their wives, yet here I am, watching mine rush off to be with someone else. Part of me is jealous, but another part is resentful. How can he prioritize someone else over his wife?

My heels click against the marble tile as I follow him to the garage. On the drive, Malcolm tells me about the idiosyncrasies of the men I will meet tonight. His words go in one ear and out the other. I barely remember their names, let alone the little details he gives me about each of them.

While I've been to the Manchesters for dinner on several occasions, tonight, the street is lined with cars. A lump forms in my throat as Malcolm parks the car a few doors down.

As the car comes to a stop with a soft hum, Malcolm turns off the engine, and the familiar tune playing through the speakers abruptly cuts off. "Don't embarrass me," he declares with a hint of annoyance in his tone. The lights inside the car flicker before shutting off completely as he extracts the key from the ignition. "You can go anywhere you want, as long as it isn't into a bedroom. Douglas has a beautiful estate. It's probably bigger than ours," he says in a begrudging tone. "Which means you'll have plenty of places to engage in conversation. But conversation is *all* you'll engage in. Do you hear me? I won't have my wife whoring herself out to my friends and colleagues."

"But it's okay for your friends and colleagues wives to whore themselves out to you," I say before I can stop myself.

"I would never raise my hand to a woman," Malcolm replies evenly. "But there are other ways to punish someone for petulance." His threat sends a shiver down my spine. "Be careful how you talk to me, Carrie. I might just make you sit in the corner and watch me bury my cock in some trophy wife's pussy."

For a second, I thought I had one-upped him. But I'd forgotten that Malcolm McCade isn't somebody you one-up. He's always one step ahead, ready to strike with a vengeance.

"Now, be a good little girl and entertain my friends." He gets out of the car, and I expect him to walk to my side to open the door and help me out, but he doesn't. Malcolm stands on the sidewalk and waits for me to slink out of the car and trail behind him subserviently.

Chapter 20

Carrie

My husband leaves me the second we're through the front door. With a frustrated sigh, he peels off his crisp suit jacket and rolls up his sleeves with quick, practiced movements. As he disappears into the bustling crowd of people, I can't help but feel a pang of sadness at our lack of connection.

"Carrie," Douglas' wife, Jacqueline, greets me more warmly than my husband did. "Thank you for coming! Can I get you a drink? Hors'd oeuvres?" She leans in close to hug me, a move uncharacteristic of the older woman. "I don't recommend eating if you're going to be with Theodore. He likes to stick it in the backdoor if you know what I mean," she whispers in my ear.

I give her a quick, tight hug before pulling away. Though she doesn't show any sign of being ashamed, I can feel my cheeks growing hot with embarrassment. I try to hide my blush by tucking my hair behind my ear and averting my gaze, but I can still feel the heat radiating from my face. "Thanks for that, uh, tip."

"You'll get more than the tip with Theodore," she says with a lascivious wink.

My stomach clenches and twists, threatening to expel the contents of my lunch in a violent upheaval. A sour taste fills my mouth, accompanied by an intense queasiness. "My husband seems to have disappeared." I change the topic with as much tact as I can muster.

Jacqueline wraps her fingers around mine, her warm touch grounding me in the bustling crowd. We weave through a sea of bodies, pressed together like sardines in a can. The air is thick with the buzz of conversation and laughter, mingling with the pulsing beat of music. Some couples are lost in intimate conversations, while others shamelessly make out in dark corners as if reliving their high school days. It's a chaotic mix of people and emotions; all caught up in the excitement and energy of the moment.

We make it to the kitchen, and there are significantly fewer people here. Everyone standing around wears perfectly pressed dark linens and white gloves. "Don't mind the help." Jacqueline waves absentmindedly at the people clustered together near the island. "They've all signed NDAs. It would bankrupt any of them if they discussed what they saw here with an outsider."

Just when I was starting to think I was familiar with the parts of my husband's wealthy lifestyle, I am proven wrong yet again. I'm sure middle and lower-class people have swinger parties, too, but I doubt there are waiters who've signed NDAs walking around offering crab cakes during the *'talking'* stage.

"This is all very new to me, Jacqueline. I was thinking—" then I'm caught off guard when I see my friend and fellow charity organizer, Sophie Bellamy, entwined with Jacqueline's husband. They're in the backyard, nestled together on a lawn chair, with Douglas gently pulling down the strap of Sophie's dress and trailing his lips along her collarbone.

Jacqueline's sharp gaze follows the direction of my line of sight, and she lets out a low huff of disapproval when her eyes land on the object of my attention. Her perfectly plucked eyebrows furrow in annoyance, adding to the intensity of her gaze. "Sophie," she grumbles under her breath. "That girl has fucked her way through half of Manhattan's elite, and she's on her way back to fuck the other half. She's been to a dozen parties, and I always see her with my husband. At the last party," Jacqueline lowers her voice, "she had a gang bang with Douglas and three other men. I walked in on her with her legs spread on my guest bed and the men lining up to run a train on her. She's a scandalous little thing."

I knew that Sophie and her husband had an open relationship, but I didn't realize how *open* it really was. "I work with her at the Illuminate Hope foundation," I frown, watching as Douglas makes Sophie giggle by whispering something in her ear.

“We’re both volunteers.”

“Well, I hope you’re nothing alike,” Jacqueline sniffs. “She’s a hussy, and I have no respect for her. If she weren’t constantly riding my husband’s dick, I’d have her removed from these parties.”

I shift awkwardly in place, trying to make myself smaller. I want to ask Jacqueline why she’s part of these swinger events if she doesn’t like her husband having sex with other women, but I imagine we’d have similar answers. In toxic relationships, power and wealth are used as a weapon by one partner to control the other. You become enslaved by their whims, constantly living in fear of what they will or won’t allow you to do. Your entire existence revolves around pleasing them and seeking their approval.

“Anyway,” she changes the topic while clearing her throat, “who are you trying to hook up with tonight? I wouldn’t mind being with Malcolm again. The last time we were together, he did this thing with his cock that made my eyes water.”

“I have to use the bathroom.” I can’t listen to this beautiful, vibrant woman talk about how good the sex is with my husband. I know how good it is. For the last few years, we’ve been having the best sex of my life. I am not emotionally capable of listening to someone else talk about how they’ve experienced the same thing.

I flee from the kitchen and push through the people; only one person shoots me a dirty look. As I make my way up the stairs, I tell myself over and over again that this is the only time I’ll do this. If Malcolm asks me to come here again, I’ll put my foot down. I won’t do it.

But as I’m walking to Jacqueline’s room to hide where no one dares to look for me, I catch sight of an open door. I see my husband lying on top of some woman, gazing into her eyes as he thrusts into her. She grabs his ass, hooks a leg around his waist, and tells him to fuck her harder.

I’ll admit that I don’t expect the lust that blooms in the pit of my stomach, even though it twists with anger and hurt.

I force myself to walk away before I do something I regret. And when I’m locked in Jacqueline’s bathroom, with the sound of the music dull and far away, I pull out my phone and text Jackson.

CARRIE

Say something that makes me feel better about being here.

H e responds immediately.

JACKSON

If I were there, I'd be inside you right now.

Chapter 21

Jackson

I don't want to sext Carrie on Facebook Messenger, but I don't have her number yet. I have to settle for sending her naughty texts that could be seen by anyone with access to our conversation.

CARRIE

I didn't expect the conversation to take this turn.

JACKSON

Just go with it. Consider it a primer for whoever you fuck next.

CARRIE

I told you already. I'm not allowed to have sex with anyone else tonight.

JACKSON

Even better. You're all mine.

I head to the bedroom and make myself comfortable. It's only 8:00 pm; it's far too early to go to sleep. But I put on some music and strip out of my jeans.

CARRIE

You should know that I'm hiding out right now. I'm in a bathroom, sitting on the floor, trying not to get caught.

JACKSON

Do you want to have a little fun? Or do you want me to be your friend? Tell me what you want, Carrie.

I can do whatever Carrie wants me to do, but right now, I'm doing what I want to do. I lay here, my mind consumed by my fantasies. I can see her luscious curves in all their naked glory. And her enchanting eyes, always seeming to hold a hint of mischief and promise—they widen in surprise and pleasure as I push myself inside her.

CARRIE:

I can't be loud...

JACKSON

Then take off your panties and shove them in your mouth.

The last time I had sex was with my ex-girlfriend six months ago. She broke up with me because she said I was distracted and not putting my *'all'* into the relationship; she wasn't wrong.

A few moments later, my phone rings. I have an incoming call from Facebook Messenger. I didn't know you could call people through the app.

"Hello?" I answer tentatively.

"You're being very naughty," Carrie whispers on the other end of the phone.

A smile pops up on my face as I grab the base of my cock and begin to lightly stroke it. "Now tell me I'm a bad, bad boy."

She giggles, and it makes me even harder. "Stop. We can't do this." But she doesn't sound like she means it.

“We’re already doing this, Carrie. I’ve got my dick in my hand, and hearing you laugh is enough to make me rock hard.”

Carrie’s intake of breath is sharp, catching quickly at the height of her inhale. “Jackson,” she says warily.

I stroke to the sound of my name on her lips. God, if she were underneath me calling out my name with a hint of pleading mixed with pleasure, I don’t think I could keep myself from blowing my load inside her. “We aren’t doing anything wrong. You’re over there, and I’m over here. We aren’t touching. We can’t see each other.”

“We *could* see each other,” she says after a moment. “This app has a video function. Maybe you turn yours on.” Carrie pauses for a moment, and the air vibrates with hesitation. “Maybe you can show me how hard you are.”

I almost drop the phone in my lap. “Yes, ma’am!”

I’m not naive. I don’t think dicks are aesthetically pleasing, even when they’re fully erect. But if Carrie wants to watch me stroke myself until I cum all over my hand, who am I to say no?

“Wow.” Carrie lets out a low whistle of appreciation when I turn on the camera and point it at my member. “All that just for me?”

I wish I could see her face. I want to see her eyes bug out of her head at the impressive length of my cock. I want to see her cute little tongue lick her bottom lip as she fantasizes about how I’m going to spread her legs and stuff all this meat inside her. “All for you, baby. Because you’re the only person I want to be with.”

Right now, my father is probably fucking some willing housewife. Maybe Carrie knows who the woman is; maybe she doesn’t. But she called me because she wanted me to make her feel better. She wants someone to make her feel wanted and desired.

“You haven’t seen the women here,” Carrie jokes lightheartedly. “Gorgeous gowns. Perfect bodies. It’s any man’s fantasy.”

“*You’re* my fantasy,” I cut her off. “I don’t care about any of those women. I only want you.”

I feather stroke my cock, hand gently traveling up and down. I can see myself on camera, and there’s nothing special about the way I touch myself that Carrie couldn’t find online if she wanted to. But the actions combined with my words are what she needs to hear.

“Prove it.” Her voice shakes, but that doesn’t change the message. “Show me how much you want me.”

My fingers pause, tingling with anticipation before they start to glide up and down my length in a tantalizing rhythm. I can’t help but let out exaggerated moans, each stroke eliciting a deeper response from my lips. “I’d rather have you here with me,” I tell her. “I’d rather be on my knees in between your legs, licking your pussy until you can’t see straight.”

There is shuffling on her end of the line. “Tell me more,” Carrie whispers.

“I’d lick every inch of you from your soft inner lips to your swollen clit.” My voice takes on a deep, husky tone as I tease her with my words. My cock twitches at the thought of being between her legs, and I swear she’s on the other end thinking the same thing.

The bed creaks with each movement as I sink into the mattress, my fingers wrapped tightly around my throbbing member. With each thrust of my hips, I imagine it’s Carrie’s tight warmth engulfing me. My body rocks with pleasure as I continue to fuck my hand, lost in the fantasy of her writhing beneath me. “I’d lick up every drop of your sweet nectar and make you beg for more,” I continue, stroking myself even harder now. My head bulges, leaking precum onto my fingers. “And then, when you think you can’t take any more pleasure, I’d slide inside you—smooth and slow.”

My hips jerk forward as if finally sinking into her depths. A guttural moan rises in my chest, twisting and tugging at my core. “Fuck, Carrie, you feel so good. Your body rocking against mine like that… your nails digging into my skin… your sweet taste still on my tongue.” My eyes roll back in pleasure as I visualize tasting her: salty, sweet, and all mine.

“Fuck,” Carrie moans on the other end of the phone.

“Yeah, Carrie,” I breathe into the receiver, savoring the desperation in her voice. “I want to be there with you, but this is the next best thing. My hand sliding up and down my cock, getting it all nice and hard for you. Imagining your body under mine, your hot wet pussy gripping me tight and squeezing me just right.”

I know she’s touching herself. I can hear her trying to muffle her moans, and it sends me to the edge. I tease the sensitive head of my dick, ready to burst. “Tell me you’re touching yourself, Carrie. Tell me you’re going to think of me while you cum.”

She gasps into the line, “I am. I wish you were here.”

“That’s it,” I encourage her. “Imagine my tongue swirling around your clit while my fingers work inside you, stretching you open and doing things your husband only wishes he could do.” It’s a gamble to mention Malcolm, but it’s precisely what sends us both over the edge.

Carrie drops the phone, clamping a hand over her mouth to muffle her screams. “Oh, god,” she groans, the words sounding far away.

As I listen to her stifled moans, it becomes clear that she’s met her climax. My heart races, and my cock throbs in response, leaking more and more precum with every passing second. My hips jerk upwards forcefully, driving my hand down onto my cock harder and faster, mimicking the deep thrusts I know she would enjoy if we were together. Each time my fist pistons up and down, another wave of pleasure washes over me, threatening to break me into a million pieces.

“Carrie,” I breathe into the phone, my head thrown back in bliss as my climax finally hits. Hot semen erupts from my cock, coating my hand in a warm rush of release. The scent of sex fills the room—a mix of arousal and anticipation that only fuels my desire for Carrie. It’s intoxicating, and addictive.

“Someone’s coming. I have to go,” Carrie says quickly. “Send me your number. We should do this again.”

My screen shows *‘call ended’*, and I’m left staring at our chat. I type my number into the text bar with one hand before tossing my phone on the bed and getting up. I need a shower and a beer. One’s to clean myself up; the other is to keep me from driving over to Carrie’s house and fucking her in front of my father.

This was the hottest masturbation session I’ve ever had. And I know the next time I see her, I’m going to show her how serious I was about everything I said tonight.

Chapter 22

Carrie

I emerge from Jacqueline's bathroom, feeling like a new woman. The disgusting feeling I had earlier is replaced with something dark and delicious because I have a secret.

I practically float down the stairs. My husband is nowhere to be found, not even in the room I just saw him in a few minutes ago. I grab a glass of wine, stand on the patio overlooking the Manchesters' sprawling estate, and enjoy the evening breeze as it washes over me.

Someone comes by to chat. I think I catch his name. Sam? Simon? Something like that. He's prematurely balding and barely 5'8", but he holds his own. He's self-deprecating and charming, and when he flashes me a smile, I know that a younger me would have fallen for him hook, line, and sinker.

But I'm not interested in flirting or having sex with him. When Sam/Simon figures that out, he casually announces that he's going to grab another drink, and I am left alone with my thoughts.

"Nice night," someone says behind me a few moments later. As I whirl around, I see my husband's partner, Douglas, standing in the doorway with a glass of amber liquid in his hand. His sharp features are set in a stoic expression, but his eyes betray a hint of amusement. "Mind if I join you?"

I take a step to the side and usher him forward. "It's your home, Doug. You're allowed to do whatever you'd like."

Douglas Manchester is a complex, unpredictable man. I've seen him act like an asshole to his wife and then turn around and play Santa for underprivileged kids. He doesn't donate money if he can help it, but he volunteers his time and resources to anyone who asks. He's kind but gruff. He's hot and cold. Sometimes, the Douglas Manchester you get is based on how much coffee he's had. Two cups are just right, but any more or any less, and you might lose a limb.

"How are you enjoying your first party?" His arm grazes mine as he comes to stand beside me. We gaze out into the distance together, two figures basking in the gentle glow of moonlight dancing across the grass blades beneath our feet. The night air is cool and crisp, carrying with it a hint of pine from the nearby trees.

I sip my wine slowly before responding. "There are some interesting people here," I tell him honestly. "It feels like a lot of people already know one another and seem to have their preferences. Almost like a clique, I suppose."

Doug mimics my gesture and sips on his bourbon. "You're probably right. The swinger community in Manhattan is very tight-knit. It's tough for newcomers, but in a good way. It keeps us safe. If newbies can't stand the pressure, we never see them again. They were probably never serious about this, or we weren't the ones for them. And that's okay. There's no one-size-fits-all in the community."

I never thought of it like that. The concept of swinging has rarely crossed my mind, but in movies and TV shows, they are often portrayed as married couples who prefer the company of someone else's spouse over their own. I'm sure that's a part of it, but it's not the only part. "Does it bother you that your wife is having sex with someone else?" I ask boldly.

"Honestly?" He takes a deep breath of the fresh night air. "Sometimes. When I see her with certain men, it ticks me off. But I don't think we would have stayed married this long without the lifestyle. It helps us appreciate one another, and it's strengthened our relationship."

I peek up at him to see if he's putting me on, but Doug's face remains impassive. He doesn't look like he's lying; he looks like a

man who believes what he says. “What if Jacqueline told you tomorrow that she never wants to do this again?”

Doug takes his time to formulate a response, his thoughts swirling like the bourbon in his glass. He savors another swig of the rich amber liquid, letting its complex flavors explode on his tongue as he swishes it in his mouth. “I love my wife, Carrie. When you see me at parties like this or hear about things I’ve done, you might not think so. But Jacqueline and I have known each other since we were kids. This part of our lives has been vital to our marriage and the relationship we have with one another. But if Jackie woke up tomorrow and decided she never wanted to do this again,” Doug pauses for a moment, “I would stop. Then I’d do everything in my power to make her happy in other ways.”

No one has ever felt that way about me. Franklin might have been able to, but he died too young.

Owen didn’t love me enough to keep his hands to himself. He gripped me with rough and calloused fingers until I begged him to stop; he enjoyed the sound of me crying out in pain. Owen was too consumed by his lust for violence to see the fear in my eyes.

My current husband doesn’t tell me things unless he deems them important enough for me to know. He loves me, but it’s in his own way. But his way doesn’t always feel like love.

I am thirty-two years old. I have an eighteen-year-old daughter. I’ve been married three times. Why do I always get it wrong?

Chapter 23

Jackson

I don't want to see Malcolm so I can extort him out of another 5-figure sum of money; I want to see him so I can rub it in his face that my plan is working.

But I can't go back to his office because I'm pretty sure his secretary will call the police this time.

The good news is that the sidewalk is public property. Leaning against my truck and waiting for Malcolm to arrive at his place of work is perfectly legal.

"For fucks sake," he swears when he gets out of his car. "It's either you or Xavier," Malcolm complains. "I never should have had kids. All of you are fucking annoying."

I don't know his son all that well, but if he's getting under his father's skin, maybe we should meet. "But I brought you coffee." I gesture to the cup sitting on the hood of the truck, picking it up and offering it to him. "I care about you, Dad."

Malcolm crosses the street with a determined stride and closes in on me. The intensity in his gaze is unmistakable as he looks at the cup of steaming coffee. In one swift motion, he snatches it from my grasp and hurls it forcefully at the ground. The impact sends hot liquid flying in all directions, drenching my slacks in a scalding mess of caffeine. "Then do me a favor and *stop* caring about me."

"I'll do you a favor," I offer brightly. "I'll take your wife out on a date. She seems lonely."

I've always assumed my father has a violent streak by the things he says to me, but today's the first time I witness it for myself. Suddenly, in the middle of the bustling street in broad daylight, he lunges at me, and his fingers wrap around my throat like a vice. I feel my airway constricting as he squeezes with all his might, cutting off my oxygen supply and leaving me gasping for breath. "It's like you don't have any self-preservation instincts," Malcolm snarls.

As the air slowly drains from my lungs, my survival instincts kick into overdrive, screaming at me to do something to break free from Malcolm's grasp. His grip tightens even more, and in a split-second decision, I deliver a swift and decisive knee to his groin. The sound of his pained grunt echoes through the street, mixing with the frantic gasps for breath that escape my lips. It's a dirty move. I wouldn't ordinarily kick a man in the dick, but desperate times call for desperate measures.

Malcolm releases me to grab himself. A deep flush spreads across his face, turning it a solid shade of crimson as he curls into a tight ball on the ground.

I instinctively bring my hand up to my throat, feeling a dull ache that echoes the bruises left by his tight grip. My fingers trace along the tender skin, still tingling from the pressure. "Fuck you, Malcolm," I manage to croak out. As he's writhing on the ground, I spit on him. "I wish you weren't my father."

Between gritted teeth, face the shade of cooked lobster, he agrees, "Me, too."

If we weren't in a public space, I'd start kicking him and never stop. I would make him regret brushing my mother and me to the side. I would cause him the same pain he caused us.

But I'm not the violent type.

I've dreamt about cutting the brakes on Malcolm's car. I've fantasized about running him over as he's walking through a parking lot late at night. I've imagined him begging for forgiveness just before I push him off a cliff.

But I am not strong enough to murder my father. I wish I were because it would make my life easier if he weren't around. I wouldn't be blackmailing him or trying to seduce his wife. But that's where my boundaries lie. I can throw a punch, but I can't kill a man.

I crouch down to get on Malcolm's level, meeting his suffering gaze with one of my own. "The day will come when you're so low, it'll feel like the ground opened up and swallowed you alive. And on that day, I will be there to hold your wife and tell her it will all be okay. When you're looking up at us from your lowest place, you'll know without a doubt that you fucked up twenty-four years ago when my mother told you she was pregnant."

"Fuck you," Malcolm wheezes. "If you touch my wife, I'll kill you both."

Flecks of spittle hit my cheek, and I flinch away. "Thank you for making this easier for me. I was beginning to feel guilty for falling in love with your wife. But I think I'll channel my inner Malcolm going forward. WWMD?" I smile. "Because I think Malcolm would blow up your fucking marriage. Don't you?"

He releases his dick, chewing on the inside of his cheek as he tries to get to his feet. "You'll regret this," Malcolm swears.

I stand up straight, adjusting my shirt in the process. "Probably. But not as much as you will."

Chapter 24

Carrie

I don't believe in fate, destiny, or the universe; I believe in myself.

"Can you tell me where Jackson Reid's office is?" I ask the lady standing behind the check-out desk at the library.

She flashes me a warm smile before picking up the phone and dialing Jackson's office. A few moments later, she hangs up and says he'll be right now.

"I thought I'd speak with him in his office," I frown.

"Yes, of course," the woman replies, her smile never wavering. "But it's a maze on the admin floor. I still get lost, and I've worked here for two months now."

My nerves settle and I thank the woman for her help. As I wait for Jackson, I scan the room for a familiar face, praying I see one and begging God that I don't.

"Carrie," Jackson calls my name when he's a few feet away and flashes me a boyish grin that makes my stomach do flip flops. "What are you doing here?"

I take a few more steps away from the checkout desk, cloaking us in privacy as I lower my voice to answer him. "I-I just wanted to thank you for the other night. I was feeling a little out of control by the situation and needed to talk to someone."

He offers me his hand. It's a simple gesture, but butterflies beat their wings against my stomach in protest. "I won't bite," Jackson says after a moment. "Unless you want me to."

Heat creeps across my body, filling my cheeks with a reddish hue. "No, of course," I rush to respond. "I'm just a little out of it today."

As Jackson reaches forward, his hand extends in a welcoming gesture toward me. I feel my fingers instinctively reach out to meet his, and as our hands intertwine, I can't help but notice the warmth of his touch. "Come on. Let's go." But he doesn't lead me to the elevator he just came from. Instead, Jackson leads me to the stairs.

As if reading my mind, he explains that we're finishing our tour. "When you were here last, you ran away before we could make it to the third floor. It's my favorite place here. In fact, I'm responsible for the third floor. I acquire all the new books shelved on the third floor and make sure the older, more delicate ones are preserved."

I bob my head as we climb the first set of stairs. There's a landing that leads to the second floor, and we walk about ten feet before another staircase appears. "About the last tour," I begin.

Jackson breezes past any arguments I try to start. "The preservation process for rare books is extensive. We have to have climate-controlled conditions for some editions, while others require regular dusting to prevent the acceleration of mold."

It catches me off guard, and for a minute, I'm intrigued. "Books can mold?"

"Oh, yeah," Jackson replies excitedly. "It's pretty gross. We had a pipe burst up here when I was in my sophomore year. We dried out books for three days straight with dehumidifiers spaced out every ten feet. We borrowed every fan on campus and had them running nonstop. This was before I cared too much about my job, so there were some books that I didn't give my full attention to." He shakes his head as he reminisces. "A few weeks later, we were all back up here, tasked with removing mold."

We lost a few books that year, and I always wonder if any of them are ones that I didn't care enough about to finish drying out."

His story surprisingly endears me to him. I squeeze his hand in mine and reach over to rub his arm. "Hey. Don't think like that. We all make mistakes."

He looks at me with a soft smile, his teeth scraping against his bottom lip as he stares. "This is the third floor, Carrie," Jackson gestures with his free hand, but I can't take my eyes off him. "No one ever really comes up here except staff. Sometimes, we get a pair of rambunctious college students that want to do it in the stacks, though."

My heart jackhammers in my chest at the unspoken insinuation. "Have you ever done *it* up here?"

"No," Jackson responds quickly. "But there's a first time for everything."

We're playing a dangerous game. I let the little voice in my head tell me all the ways I'm making a mistake before I stop listening. "This is a one-time thing," I whisper.

He reaches up to cup my cheek before replying, "I'll take whatever I can get. One time, a hundred times. I don't care. I want to be with you as much as you'll let me." Then Jackson kisses me, and my head threatens to pop off my shoulders, and for once, everything feels right.

Chapter 25

Jackson

I lied. I've had sex in the library before. But never on the third floor. Never with so many rare, expensive books surrounding me.

I press my lips against Carrie's with a fervor that has been simmering for weeks. The heat between us ignites as our tongues entwine, exploring each other with eager curiosity. Her mouth opens hungrily to mine, and I am lost in the taste of her, savoring every moment of our passionate exchange.

Our tongues tangle and dance, performing the most intimate Tango as Carrie slides her hands under my shirt. Her fingers trace feather-light patterns on my bare skin, sending shivers down my spine. As I pull her closer, her body molds perfectly against mine like two puzzle pieces finally fitting together.

The scent of old books mixed with the fresh fragrance of her perfume creates an intoxicating aroma that makes me want more of her. I break the kiss and tug her away from the staircase, desperate to veil ourselves among classic literature books that changed the course of history.

"Where are we going?" She asks, her tone as hungry as I feel.

I drag her past ten aisles of books, disappearing from the cameras and watchful eyes of my coworkers. "Here," I grumble a reply, pulling her into an aisle.

There are no windows on the third floor, at least not near the books. Sunlight could stain the covers, or the heat could ruin the delicate pages. I see Carrie under fluorescent lighting, highlighting her flawless skin.

"I wish we were in a bedroom," I tell her. She deserves candles and rose petals. She deserves a down comforter, a jetted tub filled with bubbles, and a glass of champagne. Carrie Pennington deserves the best, and all I can give her is a dusty library.

"Don't say that." Carrie looks away, her eyes sweeping over the bookshelf before her. "I need this to be hot and dirty. You can't make it emotional. I'm married, Jackson, and I need you to remember that."

I can fuck her hard and fast. I can call her a filthy bitch and cum all over her face. I can be the one-night stand she wants me to be.

But destruction doesn't happen overnight. Destruction is a process. And sometimes, in the process, people get hurt.

I wish Carrie didn't have to be one of them, but every war has casualties. The only thing I can do is try to make the blow I have to deal her more bearable.

I drop to my knees in front of Carrie and reach under her dress to hook my fingers into the waistband of her panties. My heart races with anticipation as I wait for her to stop me, but she only watches with a hunger that ignites my desire, her eyes dark and heavy with need. With a teasing tug, I slide the lacy black thong down her smooth legs.

"You're so fucking beautiful," I growl before burying my head beneath her dress. I feel her grab the hem, the sound of her hurried breath filling the air when I lean in to swipe my tongue across her glistening mound.

I wait for a beat, giving her every opportunity to back out, but she wants this as badly as I do.

I spread her legs further apart to give myself more access to her center; then, I slide my tongue through her folds. Heat radiates

from Carrie's core as she shivers and moans softly, leaning into the bookshelf for stability. Her scent is intoxicating, driving me wild as I part my lips and drag my tongue upwards to tease her most sensitive spot.

She tastes like heaven and hell, sweetness mixed with a tangy bite that makes me want more. The subtle sway of her hips begins to match the rhythm of my lapping tongue as I greedily devour her dripping desire. Her moans grow louder and more desperate, urging me on as I explore every inch of her with my mouth. She gasps for air and pulls me closer; I love that she already trusts me.

My chin glistens with the sticky, sweet nectar that flows from her core, and I eagerly lap it up, my tongue flicking against her sensitive flesh. A sense of urgency fills me as I suck and lick, desperate to bring her to the edge right here in the middle of the quiet library stacks. With every moan and whimper that escapes her lips, my desire grows stronger, matching the pounding rhythm of my heart. She writhes beneath me, her hands gripping the shelves for support as pleasure courses through her body. A visible reminder that I have succeeded in igniting a fire within her that will not be easily extinguished.

Carrie grips my hair tightly, using it as leverage to pull me closer while keeping herself upright on wobbly legs. Her fingers trace lightly along my scalp as if to urge me onward—a silent plea for release that echoes throughout the quiet space we've claimed for ourselves.

Her hips begin to buck against me as I slide two fingers inside her wet, waiting entrance, seeking out that sweet spot that will send her over the edge. Her pussy grips my digits like a vice as a plea dances on her lips, "Fuck me, Jackson," Carrie whimpers.

Her legs tremble as I drive my fingers in and out of her, my tongue swirling around her erect clit. She's so close, and I won't stop until she screams my name. With every stroke of my tongue and every thrust of my fingers, she gasps and moans louder, biting her bottom lip to stifle some of the sound but unable to stop it all. Carrie reaches out to hold onto the bookshelf for support, her tight grip hinting at her need for release. The friction and pressure build inside her as she nears climax, muscles tightening all across her body.

Finally, she cries out in ecstasy. "Jackson!" Carrie arches her back, pressing against me. "Oh, god!"

I grab onto her legs to hold her steady, her body quivering as a wave of pleasure crashes into her. I lap up every drop of her sweet juices, tasting her completely as she writhes against my tongue. As her breathing slows, I pull away, my fingers still buried in her pussy.

Carrie lets out a low moan of pleasure as she tries to catch her breath. "Fuck," she whispers. "That was..." but she trails off.

As I pull out my fingers, I make eye contact with her before shoving them both in my mouth. Carrie bites her bottom lip as I suck my digits clean. "If you thought that blew your mind, wait until I'm fucking you."

Chapter 26

Carrie

As Jackson stands up, his strong fingers deftly tug off his shirt and discard it with a casual flick of his wrist. The fabric flutters in the breeze before settling onto the ground, revealing the toned muscles of his chest and abs. He fumbles with his belt, unbuckling it and slowly sliding down his pants until he stands before me, completely naked. I admire his form, feeling a flutter in my stomach at the sight of him so vulnerable and exposed.

Jackson's pubic hair is meticulously groomed, framing his impressive length. He steps closer, his hands reaching to grip my thighs firmly. He doesn't say a word as he effortlessly lifts me off the ground, my body quivering with anticipation.

My ass lands precariously on the edge of the bookshelf, and I put the rest of my weight on Jackson. My dress falls prettily over the middle of us, but that wouldn't stop anyone walking by from realizing what the two of us are doing. With Jackson's clothes scattered around us and my panties on the floor, it's clear we aren't reading the Encyclopaedia Britannica.

I run my hands along the mountains and valleys of Jackson's body, admiring the hard youth of his pectorals and abs. He looks so different than any other man I've been with. He's all muscle and vigor, with his cock pressing into my thigh. Even my husband has never been this hard for me, and the sensation leaves me aroused and ready for what's coming next.

In one swift movement, Jackson hooks my leg around his waist, his firm grip pulling me closer. The heat of his skin against mine sends shivers down my spine as he slowly guides his throbbing cock into my eagerly waiting center. As he presses himself deeper inside me, he kisses a trail across my shoulder blade. "You feel so good," he mumbles against my skin.

The size of him takes my breath away. I drop my head back against the bookshelf and indulge in the sensation of him opening me up.

His fingers dance over my skin, settling on my hips. He caresses my collarbone with his teeth, grazing them gently across my delicate flesh. Then, with one powerful thrust, he buries himself to the hilt.

I bite my bottom lip and dig my nails into the back of his neck. "Take me hard, Jackson," I groan. "I want to feel you."

Jackson rolls his hips into mine, giving me exactly what I ask for. I grip onto his shoulders for leverage, leaving small crescents as we grind against one another. My dress inches further up my thigh, exposing his cock sliding in and out of me. I watch in surprise as he fills me over and over again, his girthy member disappearing into me.

The scent of sweat, cum, and musty pages from the books mingles in the air creating a unique aroma that makes me dizzy. His mouth travels up my neck, teeth nibbling love letters on my skin as he kisses his way to my earlobe. "You taste so fucking good," he whispers breathlessly.

I can feel every inch of him inside me, stretching me wider than I ever thought possible. It is a distinctive pain mixed with intense pleasure.

Jackson bites gently on my earlobe, and I gasp, arching my back in delight. He thrusts deeper and harder into me, hitting my sweet spot with every powerful stroke. My dress rides up higher, revealing more of our entangled limbs to anyone who might wander by. The frankness of what we're doing, the chance that we might get caught, is so exhilarating that it heightens my need for Jackson.

He allows a single hand to travel across my body, tracing patterns on my stomach and breasts while his lips find their way to mine in a passionate kiss that steals what little breath I have left. His tongue demands entrance into my mouth as he pounds into

me without mercy.

Our hips meet in perfect harmony as we grind against each other, animals possessed by heat and lust. I can feel myself getting closer to my climax as Jackson's fingers skate over my nipple, teasing it until it stands at attention beneath the thin fabric of my dress.

The kiss gets rougher. He bites my lower lip and sucks it into his mouth as he slams his hips into mine, fucking me harder. I run my hands through his hair, tangling my fingers in his messy black strands as he thrusts relentlessly.

We're both out of breath, panting into each other's mouths as we move together in a rhythm that is both primal and untamed. And then it happens, unexpectedly, like lightning striking a tree. I shatter into a thousand pieces, burying my cries into Jackson's mouth so the students on the first and second floors don't hear me.

As I ride out the waves of my orgasm, he follows suit. With half a dozen sharp thrusts, I am filled with his warmth. Sweat beads along our foreheads as we press together in a quiet moment of reverie.

My body aches from being slammed into the bookshelf repeatedly. Without Jackson fucking me, I feel a pronounced stitch of pain across my lower back. My thighs feel like I just spent the last hour at spin class. I am thoroughly exhausted and equally fulfilled.

"So," Jackson clears his throat, "this is the third floor."

It's the perfect thing to say to break the tension. We dissolve into giggles as Jackson tenderly pulls out of me. His semen makes my thighs sticky, but it's a welcome reprieve from my husband preferring to cum on my face, tits, or back.

He grabs my panties, handing them to me as I adjust my dress and hair. I watch as he redresses, his slacks now shot through with wrinkles. Classical piano music fills the void between us.

"Thank you," I tell him awkwardly. "This was good. Um, I don't know what to say right now."

Jackson buttons his slacks and steps toward me, grabbing my chin and capturing my lips with his. I savor the taste of him until he pulls away and says, "Go on a date with me."

My heart skips a beat as fear buries a knife in my chest. "Wh-what?" I laugh nervously. "I can't go on a date with you, Jackson. This was a one-time thing. *This*," I pause, "this was it."

But he kisses me again, making my knees weak with hunger and desire. Jackson stretches out the moment until I'm ready to peel off my dress and make love to him on the floor. "This isn't it, Carrie. You and I both know that. You're mine now."

Anger and anxiety disperse through my veins, chilling me to the core. "Jackson," I try to reply as level-headed as I can, "I'm married."

"Yeah, I know." He steps back to put on his shirt, tucking it into the waistline of his pants before he finishes his thought. "But your husband is having sex with other women, and you're unhappy. Don't try to tell me you're not," he talks over me, correctly deducing that I'm about to argue with him. "If you were happily married, you wouldn't be here right now."

I don't know what to say. He's right, but being right doesn't mean the circumstances have changed. I'm still married, whether I'm happy or not.

"I'll text you about the date, okay?" Jackson smiles ruefully at me as he laces his belt through the loops of his pants.

"I-I-I can't," I stutter. This was supposed to be a one-time thing." I feel like a broken record, repeating my words over and over.

But Jackson's smile never falters. "It's cute you think I've had enough of you after one time. Don't worry; we'll keep it discreet—at least until you're ready to leave your husband."

Chapter 27

Carrie

My mind is a swirling vortex, pulling me towards the edge of sanity. I'm teetering on the brink, unsure if I will slip back into my mundane reality or spiral into complete madness.

My memory is hazy, but somehow, I manage to make it back home. I recall stumbling into my car, but after that, everything is a blur. The next thing I know, I am sitting in my driveway, my car's engine still warm from the journey. My mind must have shut off during the drive, but somehow, my body navigated the familiar roads and brought me safely back to my doorstep.

As I go inside, my eyes scan across the elaborate furnishings in the house Malcolm and I share. The first time I stepped into this ostentatious mansion, I didn't feel like I fit in. The drapes cost more than my entire wardrobe, and there was more silverware on the table for a Tuesday night dinner than I knew the names of. We've been happy here; we've made a life here.

But now, among all the possessions my husband and I filled this home with, I feel like a stranger. I feel trapped by the weight and expense of all the pretty things I picked out with Malcolm. Smooth, marble countertops with soft-close drawers, a touch of luxury. A sitting area and living room with plush sofas and recliners beckoning invitingly with the promise of comfort. Gentle baseboard lighting illuminating the halls each night, providing navigation in the dark. Large televisions in every room. Soft throw blankets draped over furniture, adding cozy warmth to every cold surface Malcolm requested. The sweet scent of candles in the air, perfuming the mansion with lavender, lilac, and roses.

What were once displays of our love for one another now makes me feel like I'm suffocating.

My feet pound against the hardwood stairs as I sprint to the bathroom, frantically shedding each article of clothing in a frenzy. The memory of Jackson's strong, solid body pressed against mine still lingers as I turn on the shower. My back throbs from being pinned against the bookcase, and my legs feel like jelly as I climb over the lip of the tub.

I make the water as hot as I can stand and scrub away my indiscretions. My skin turns lobster red, an indication that I'm boiling alive, and I can't tell if the wetness on my face is water or tears. I cry out in anger, a deep, heart-wrenching sob. I don't know if I'm mad at Jackson, Malcolm, or myself. Maybe all of the above.

I can't believe I let myself get into this mess. I have always prided myself on being a woman who knows better than to fall for someone like Jackson. Yet, here I am in a situation that goes against everything I stand for. If the roles were reversed and Malcolm did something like this to me, I would leave him without hesitation. But now, I'm torn between my principles and my emotions.

He is doing something like this to you, the little voice in my head reminds me. Think of his secretary or whoever it was in his office all those weeks ago. Think of the wives he's slept with at Doug's parties. He's doing this to you, and he isn't feeling guilty about it. Why are you?

Because I have a conscience. Maybe my husband can go out and have meaningless sex, but not me. I have too many morals, too many self-doubts, and too many fears.

Slowly, I back out of the jets of steaming water and allow myself to slide to the ground. "It's okay," I mumble to myself. "Jackson will get tired of me."

The little voice replies, *Or maybe Malcolm will get tired of you first.*

If I had felt sure in my relationship, if I had thought my husband's love was unimpeachable, this would never have happened. I

would never have flirted with Jackson at the gala. I wouldn't have looked him up online. I wouldn't have shown up at his work. I wouldn't have gone to get coffee with him. I wouldn't have called him from Jacqueline's bathroom and begged him to take my mind off the situation.

It is selfish to blame my husband for my mistakes, but no matter how I look at it, I wouldn't be in this situation if it weren't for his choices.

Why am I not enough? Why does he need other women? Is this how Victoria felt when Malcolm told her about me? Because if so, I owe her an apology. I thought I wouldn't feel this way again after I married Malcolm; I bet Victoria thought that, too.

Men have a unique way of putting women in circumstances that they never thought they'd be in. And instead of standing up for ourselves, we cave to their demands. We allow ourselves to become their slaves, sure that our obedience and the change in our personality will make them love us again.

It's insecurity that makes us feel this way. I've known that for years, but I've never been able to push past it.

Jackson was a mistake, but so was Malcolm. Maybe they'll cancel each other out.

Chapter 28

Jackson

JACKSON

First date restaurants. Let's go.

RUSSELL

Take her to a bar. You need to know if she can keep up with you.

ETHAN

Invite her to poker night. If she's Paula-crazy, you have to hit it and quit it this time. My insurance won't cover my tires being slashed a second time.

JACKSON

Paula wasn't crazy. She was passionate.

DUSTIN

I know a guy at the police station. Give me her name, and I'll see if he can find any criminal cases.

ETHAN

That you think Paula was "passionate" and not crazy says all I need to know about this new girl. No dates, Jackie boy.

PIERCE

I like Nico's in Aggieville, but it has a very romantic vibe. Is she long-term?

I don't know how to explain Carrie. Should I tell them she's another man's wife? Or that the only reason we're going on a date is because I've mastered the art of blackmail? The weight of these truths hangs heavy in my mind as I struggle to find the right words.

ETHAN

Bro, don't give him ideas. This chick is crazy. The last thing we need is a crazy girlfriend around. Again.

RUSSELL

No kids either. Looking at you and your MILF, Dusty.

ETHAN

I disagree. I want to meet the MILF. I want to ask her what she sees in you.

JACKSON

In retrospect, I should have just looked up restaurants on Google. I've learned from my mistake.

PIERCE

I also really like La Fiesta. They have half-price margs on Monday.

RUSSELL

Oh shit. Really? We should go!

DUSTIN

He didn't invite you, dumb ass.

RUSSELL

This is what having kids does to a person. They get cranky.

DUSTIN

I hope I never see your address on the Manhattan Fire Department call log because I'll clock out and go to lunch. I hope your shit burns to the fucking ground.

ETHAN

I got some matches and a lot of free time if we want to see if Dusty's telling the truth.

A wide, toothy grin spreads across my face, breaking through the pensive expression I was wearing. Despite my doubts, asking the Brew Crew for restaurant recommendations turns out to be a stroke of genius. And it gives me an even better option: inviting Carrie to play poker with us.

Taking my stepmother out on a date is a power move. I'm determined to make it happen, but I can sense her hesitation. I know there's a breaking point somewhere inside of her, so I must tread these waters carefully.

JACKSON

Let's do poker. I'll see what day works for her.

PIERCE

For the record, I don't think this is a good idea. After she meets Russ, she will probably never go out with you again.

RUSSELL

Because she'll be dating me. Sorry, Jacks. I'm a charming fucker. All the ladies say so.

DUSTIN

If we're bringing dates to poker night, can I bring Harper?

ETHAN

Also known as Dustin's MILF, for those who don't know.

PIERCE

You're a real class act, Ethan.

ETHAN

Thank you. I try.

JACKSON

Bring whoever you want. It's just going to be a chill night.

RUSSELL

Hell yeah. I'm bringing my brother.

PIERCE

NO!

ETHAN

NO!

DUSTIN

NO!

JACKSON

NO!

RUSSELL

Bunch of haters in this chat

If Russell invites his brother to poker night, someone might go to jail. I've never been to an event with him where someone didn't wind up crying and bleeding. If Russell Drake is a different breed, then Raiden Drake is a different species. But I can't worry about that right now.

I exit the chat with the Brew Crew and switch to my text thread with Carrie.

JACKSON

Saturday, 8:00 pm, poker

CARRIE

What am I supposed to tell my husband?

JACKSON

Whatever you want, baby. You can lie and tell him you're out with the girls. You can tell him the truth for all I care.

CARRIE

You know I can't tell him the truth...

JACKSON

Then make something up. I want you to meet my friends. I promise you'll have a good time.

Her response comes after a long pause, the hesitation practically vibrating through the phone. I can imagine Carrie's hands trembling as she holds the device and tries to type a response, nervous about the conversation taking place. And with good reason—my father has never been one to make things easy, especially when it comes to letting go of those he cares about. His stubbornness and determination will be a roadblock for Carrie and me as well.

CARRIE

Should I bring anything? Food? Drinks?

JACKSON

Just your beautiful self.

We're playing with fire and bound to get burned, but going down in flames with Carrie would be one hell of a way to go.

Chapter 29

Carrie

“I’m planning to have dinner with Sophie,” I say, my voice laced with a hint of uncertainty.

“I have dinner plans with Sophie,” I repeat, trying to make the lie sound more convincing. But there’s still something about it that doesn’t feel quite right.

“I’m going to dinner with Sophie.” If I were *actually* going to dinner with Sophie, I wouldn’t practice saying it in the mirror over and over again. But this is a lie, and I’ve never been a good liar.

I clear my throat and swipe across the front of my shirt, smoothing out the fabric. My hands are shaking, and my heart throbs angrily in my chest cavity. I attempt to swallow back the fear bubbling up in my throat as I make my way downstairs.

Malcolm is watching television in the living room. His tie is tossed on the floor, the fabric wrinkling. He has his shirt casually unbuttoned and his feet propped up on the table. He arrived home an hour ago and announced a plan to drink his dinner. Two glasses of whiskey and an old rerun of Jerry Springer later, he seems less tense than when he came through the door.

“Mal,” I enter the living room, affectionately calling his name.

He sighs as if my very presence exhausts him. “Carrie, I told you, I just want to be alone. It’s been a long day,” Malcolm replies irritably.

I force myself to smile as I stand in front of him. “I know, honey. I just wanted to let you know that I’m going out. I’m having dinner with Sophie.”

With an exasperated sigh, he rolls his eyes and impatiently waves his hand, signaling for me to leave. “Fine. Whatever. Go. Be home by ten.”

My smile transforms into a frown. “I’m not a child, Malcolm,” I respond before I remember that I’m poking an angry bear.

Malcolm pulls his gaze away from the television, and his expression morphs into anger. “You irritate me like a child sometimes, Carrie.”

“Maybe if you treated me like an equal instead of your little plaything, you would respect what I say to you instead of seeing it as irritation.” A sudden wave of irrational anger washes over me, and I snap at Malcolm, my words sharp and cutting. The fluttering of anxiety in my chest dissipates, replaced by a sense of power and control.

He drags his feet off the coffee table, letting them fall to the floor with a thud. The sound echoes through the room. “What did you say to me?” His voice drops to a menacing growl, sending chills down my spine. He rises from his seat, towering over me with a look of pure malice in his eyes. Every muscle in my body tenses as I anticipate the worst.

But I stand my ground because Owen did this to me a hundred times. I lived through years of abuse; I made it out alive. I am a stronger woman because of what my second husband put me through, and I know damn well if Malcolm puts his hands on me, I’ll leave him a hell of a lot faster than I left Owen. “I’ll be back later,” I brazenly reply. “It might be before ten; it might be after.”

Malcolm reaches forward to grab the hem of my shirt, fidgeting the fabric between his thumb and forefinger. “This is a fetching top,” he comments, catching me off guard. “What kind of panties are you wearing?”

My face flushes in fear and embarrassment. I shift my weight from my right foot to my left, trying to steady the uneven pace of my pulse. “Um, I think they’re black.”

“Are they lacy?” He asks, meeting my gaze with a darkened version of his own.

The unbridled lust in his eyes makes my skin crawl instead of igniting desire. “Not-not really,” I stutter. “There’s a bit of lace across the front, but that’s all.”

“So it’s a thick fabric, then?”

I give a slight, uncertain nod, my mind racing to keep up with the unexpected turn this conversation has taken.

Malcolm uses my uncertainty to his advantage. He drops the hem of my shirt and grabs me around the throat. “Good. If you show up after ten pm, I’ll shove your panties in your mouth so I don’t have to hear you scream when I fuck you in the ass. Are we clear?”

A wave of dizziness washes over me, my vision blurring and my head spinning. I can’t tell if it’s from the pressure of his fingers gripping my windpipe or the sheer terror of his threat.

“Be a good girl,” Malcolm says as he releases me. “Be home by ten, or *else*.”

My legs tremble beneath me as I hold myself upright, barely able to squeak out a weak ‘*yes, sir*’. My mind is racing, and my heart is pounding as I make my way to the garage, my feet feeling heavier with each step. Finally reaching the front seat, I collapse onto it, the weight of my emotions hitting me like a tidal wave crashing against a rocky shore. Tears well up in my eyes as I try to catch my breath and make sense of what happened.

I am used to physical abuse. My ex-husband, Owen, used his fists to teach me lessons. But the way Malcolm psychologically and sexually threatens me hits differently. It makes me feel less. It makes me feel like I’m going crazy because sex with my husband has always been a joy.

Until it’s been forced on me.

Until it’s been used as a weapon.

Chapter 30

Jackson

Carrie shows up a few minutes early, looking frazzled when she walks through the door. “I wasn’t sure how long it would take me to get here,” she apologizes as she comes in. “GPS said thirty-five minutes, but I never get parking right on the first go-round.”

“No worries,” I flash her a warm smile. “The guys will probably be late. Dustin texted a few minutes ago to say he and Harper were running behind because of an incident with the babysitter.”

She nods, her eyes scanning the apartment. “So, this is your place?” Her gaze is curious and observant as if trying to get a sense of me from the colors and textures, from the plush carpet to the framed photos on the walls. Carrie’s eyes move from the cluttered bookshelf in the living room to the knick-knacks scattered on tables and cabinets.

For the briefest of moments, I feel embarrassed by what I have to offer her. Or, more accurately, what I *don’t* have to offer. “It’s not much,” I flush, “but it’s home.”

“I didn’t mean it like that.” Carrie turns to look up at me, concern creasing her brow as she studies my face. There is genuine empathy in her gaze, making me feel both vulnerable and comforted. “Kaye and I used to live in a place like this. Before I married Malcolm, we had this little row house in a poor subdivision of Manhattan. They were these beanpole houses, built barely big enough for you to spread your arms out from one wall to another in any room. There’s nothing wrong with living within your means, Jackson.”

It’s hard to keep track of where my loyalties lie. At times, I see Carrie as a mere pawn in the never-ending game against my father. Yet, there are moments when I can’t help but feel a special pull towards her. It’s a constant inner battle between what my head tells me and what my heart feels. “I’ve accepted that I’m never going to be rich. But I figure if I stay here for another couple of years, I’ll be able to save up enough for a downpayment on a house.” I could never ask Carrie to leave her million-dollar mansion to be with me. It wouldn’t be fair to ask a woman who climbed out of poverty to slip back into the slums just to be with me.

I change the subject before I can dwell on the future between Carrie and me, or the lack thereof. “So, where did you tell Malcolm you would be tonight?”

Carrie turns away from me. Instead of responding, she asks for a tour of my apartment. “Is it a one-bedroom or two?”

Her behavior strikes me as odd, but I show her around. “It’s two bedrooms, if you can really call it that. They’re pathetic little 8-by-8s that can barely fit a queen-sized bed, let alone a dresser, nightstand, and anything else you might need in a bedroom. I thought about getting a roommate when I first moved in but realized I needed the extra bedroom for my clothes, among other things.” I don’t have an extensive wardrobe, but the size of the closet leaves much to be desired.

“I may have to leave a little early,” Carrie announces as we enter my bedroom, then quickly changes the subject. “This isn’t bad! I expected something smaller.”

The whiplash catches me off guard. “What?”

“The size of the room,” she explains. “It’s very cozy! My home is overly spacious, almost cavernous sometimes. This is a comfortable size.”

I blink several times in adjustment to what she said. “Call me crazy, but did you say you have to leave early?”

A deep furrow appears between Carrie's brows, a sign of her struggle to remember what I'm referring to. Her eyes dart back and forth, searching for a memory that seems just out of reach. A few seconds pass before recognition dawns on her face, and she nods slowly. "Oh. Yes. I have something in the morning. I have to leave around 9:30. It's a half-hour drive back."

That's in under two hours. That's barely enough time to ease her into my group, let alone play poker. "Tomorrow is Sunday, Carrie. What do you have in the morning?"

Her lips form the word '*church*' with swift precision, but I can sense the lie in her voice. Despite all my research on Carrie, there was no mention of any religious beliefs or affiliations. The corner of her mouth twitches slightly, betraying her deceit as she tries to steer the conversation away from the truth. A flicker of mistrust crosses my mind, wondering what else she may be hiding from me.

"I don't want to overstep my boundaries, but you know you can tell me the truth," I say gently.

She rounds on me like a cat scalded with hot water. "Can I?" Carrie glares. "Because the last time I trusted you, you finished inside me and told me this was more than a one-night stand, regardless of the husband I told you was waiting for me at home. So forgive me if I'm feeling frustrated by this so-called '*trust*' I can have in you."

That's fair, but she doesn't know all the facts. And we aren't at a place where I can share them just yet. "Don't pretend you don't want to fuck me again, Carrie," I return her energy.

"That isn't the point."

"That's exactly the damn point," I yell. "You let your husband go out and get his fill of other women, but when it comes to you, you only get one opportunity?"

Carrie forcefully jabs her index finger into my chest, causing me to stumble backward. "I never *let* my husband do anything. He just did it. How do you stop something when you don't even know it's happening?"

"You can't. But you know now. And I'm giving you the chance to get even and do to him what he's doing to you." I'm so close to touching on the real reason I targeted Carrie. My bones ache with the intensity of my pent-up rage, and my fingers twitch with the desire to blurt it out on impulse. Carrie provokes me and pushes me to the edge until the words threaten to spill from my lips. But I know the truth is too raw, and it is too soon to expose it.

Silence stretches between us, and I refuse to be the first to break. I can feel the pressure of her worries and fears butting up against the unspoken words between us. Then she admits in a small, tiny voice, "He threatened me. He said if I didn't come home by 10:00, he would—"

But she's cut off by the front door being flung open and Russell's voice echoing through the apartment. "Ayyy, Jackie boy!" He yells. "The Drake brothers are here. Let's get this party started!"

And though I want nothing more than for Carrie to go on, to tell me what Malcolm threatened her with, I grab her hand and bring it to my lips. "Later," I nod my head at her.

Seething rage bubbles up inside me as I lead Carrie to the living room. I swear to God, if my father puts his hands on Carrie, I'll kill him.

Chapter 31

Carrie

I wasn't sure I'd fit in with Jackson's friends. Most of them are in their 20s, like him. There's only a seven-year age gap between us, but that's a world of difference at this age. As the sun sets on their college years, men in their mid-20s are often consumed with thoughts of post-graduate jobs and securing a place to call home. Meanwhile, women in their 30s are juggling family responsibilities while also grappling with the daunting task of advancing their careers to the next level.

But Jackson isn't the only one branching out of his age bracket. Dustin brings Harper, a single mom of two kids who turned thirty this summer. She's as delicate as an angel with the mouth of a sailor. I think we could be best friends.

"Just fold." Harper leans into the table, narrowing her eyes at her boyfriend and trying to read his face like a textbook. "You don't have anything anyway, baby. Just give up."

"Low-key, your girlfriend is trash-talking you," Russell snorts. I'm liking her more and more."

I sit next to Jackson, feeling shy among his friends. I catch all their names and bank them in my memory for later, but I've never been an extrovert. Harper fits in with these boys like she grew up with them, whereas I'm afraid to incur Raiden Drake's wrath if I say the wrong thing. He lost his mind after the first hand when his brother beat him, and I haven't felt comfortable since.

"You okay?" Jackson lowers his voice to ask, nudging me gently in the arm.

I nod slowly, fingering the frayed edges of the well-used cards in my hands. "Of course. There's just a lot going on. I'm not used to so many people yelling."

"You'll get used to it," Ethan adds from his corner of the table. "Wait until you get a few drinks in Jackson. He turns into a 'woo' girl and starts dancing on bars."

Jackson shoots his friend a glare. "That happened twice."

Pierce clears his throat, quietly looking away from Jackson to make eye contact with me. "I've seen him 'woo' on plenty of occasions. And how loosely is the definition of the word 'bar'? Because he got on a table at El Tapatio once, took off his shirt, and—"

"Whoa, buddy!" Jackson yells over his friend, laughing. "Save some stories for the next time, will ya?"

But Pierce keeps going as if he was never interrupted. "—he started smacking his ass. They had some cowboy Olympics on or something, and after three tequila shots, Jackson was convinced he could be a cowboy. But I think he confused himself with the horse because he was galloping across the table until the manager came out and made him get down." Jackson groans, but no one can hear it over the cacophony of laughter that ensues.

"Jackson," I grin at him, "you didn't tell me you were a horse girl."

The peals of laughter keep coming. Despite himself, Jackson is smiling. "I'll get you back for that one," he threatens Pierce.

Russell waits for a moment of silence before casually asking, "How did you meet Jackie, anyway?" His eyes drift up from his cards, a sliver of brown meeting mine. "Or is he paying you to be here? Because whatever he offered wasn't enough to put up with these clowns."

"Usually, when someone stops being friends with us, it's because of Russell," Dustin adds quickly. "Something about his loud

mouth is off-putting to everyone but us. I think it's because we've been subjected to it for so long that we've learned to tune him out."

With a snort of derision, Russell lays his cards flat on the table. "Dusty, you couldn't ignore me if you tried." When Dustin doesn't reply, Russell turns up the heat. Literally. He reaches into his pocket and pulls out a lighter. "Who wants to see how fast these cards go up in flames?"

"Alright," Dustin rolls his eyes. "That doesn't count because you're appealing to my inner firefighter."

Russell lowers his voice into a dramatic whisper. "Dusty has a savior complex."

"And you have an asshole complex. At least mine will help us out if there's a fire or you choke on your own stupidity."

I miss friendships like this. I don't feel like the people I've met since marrying Malcolm have been this free and open with one another. It always seems like I have to modulate my tone and think twice before saying something in case I offend someone. I miss the authenticity of saying what's on my mind regardless of who's in the room.

"Since we're the only girls here, tell me about yourself, Carrie." Harper interrupts the boys' jabbing at one another to try and bring me out of my shell. "How'd you get mixed up with them?"

Every eye turns my way, even Jackson's. I took off my wedding ring before I came inside, nestling it in my glovebox so I wouldn't have to explain. "I met Jackson at a gala a few weeks ago."

"Fancy," Raiden grunts.

I go on. "I was a volunteer for the planning committee. If I hadn't been, I wouldn't have gone." Jackson gives me a pointed look, and I know what he's thinking: Malcolm could have paid for this entire table to go to the Illuminate Hope event, and he wouldn't have lost a wink of sleep.

But I grew up poor, and sometimes I still feel like I'm in that mindset. I feel uncomfortable when people talk about money because I don't feel wealthy. I have access to a bank card with 7+ figures in the account, but the money isn't mine, and I didn't earn it.

"That's cute, though!" Harper interjects. "I wish we had a '*meet cute*'," she says to Dustin.

He returns her statement with an exasperated look. "You don't think it's cute that we met because your daughter tried to straighten her Barbie's hair and lit it on fire?"

Harper cracks a smile while shaking her head. "That's the story I tell people. What's yours? '*I was at work one day when I got a call, and this mom was in her undies trying to put out the curtain fire her daughter's Barbie started.*' Romantic, Dustin."

Harper paints a vivid picture, and I'm not the only person who roars with laughter trying to imagine it. I lean in close to Jackson and squeeze his thigh. "I like your friends," I whisper.

"That's only because they're on their best behavior."

"I heard that." Russell snaps his fingers at the two of us. "I want that stricken from the record. I have never been on my best behavior, and I don't want anyone to think it gets better than this."

Everyone collectively sighs, and I feel perfectly comfortable. It's so natural being with Jackson and his friends that I almost forget the clock ticking down to when I turn back into a pumpkin.

Chapter 32

Jackson

After Carrie leaves, I settle down with the guys to continue playing. The more time I spend with Carrie, the stronger my feelings for her become. My attraction to her is unsettling, given she's meant to be a pillar in my scheme for revenge. It's a dangerous game that could jeopardize everything I've worked for, but I can't resist her.

"Your girl left early," Pierce comments.

"I think we all saw that," Russell adds a second later. "She got a curfew or something?"

Or something. I still don't know what Malcolm threatened to do to her if she was late, but it was bad enough that she left at 9:25 to give herself a five-minute buffer. "She has something to do in the morning."

Raiden wrinkles his nose in disbelief. "On a *Sunday*?"

I nod my head, not wanting to engage Raiden. I like his brother, but Raiden rides in a motorcycle gang and is as rough around the edges as a piece of bark. Where Russell is an acquired taste, you never come around to liking Raiden.

"Your girl," Raiden's nose crinkles even more, "is fucking some other dude."

His words jab at the exposed nerves of my insecurity. Strings of jealousy tighten in my chest, constricting my heart until it feels like it might burst from the pressure. "Shut up, Raiden."

"It *is* a little weird that she had to leave so early," Harper says with a wince. "I'm not saying Carrie is cheating on you or anything, but a single woman in her thirties with a kid in college? It isn't like she's rushing back to let the babysitter go or anything."

I grip the cards so tight the cardboard crumples, and my knuckles turn white under the strain. "It's complicated."

Raiden snorts. "Complicated because her other man is probably rich. She can't leave her sugar daddy for a broke bitch. But you're probably a better lay than him, so she can't give that up, either."

He hits so close to home that every fiber of my being bristles with fury. "Shut the fuck up, Raiden," I snarl. "This isn't any of your business."

"Tell me to shut up again." Raiden throws his cards down and stands up. His powerful thighs slam into the table, precariously shaking every drink. Rising to his full height, he looms over the table like a tower of strength, his muscles rippling beneath his shirt. "I fucking dare you, Jackson. Tell me to shut up again."

I refuse to cower in fear of Raiden Drake. Russell tells me that he's not the kind of guy you fuck with, but I'm not afraid of a few tattoos and a leather jacket. I mimic his actions, getting to my feet and glowering up at him. "You don't know Carrie. Keep her name out of your fucking mouth."

"I know girls like Carrie." He crosses his arms over his chest in a display of dominance. "I've dated girls like Carrie. I was the other man, the one that fucked them real good. I took care of them when their big bad boyfriend was being mean to them, and I was the shoulder to cry on when their husbands got violent with them. That girl is dragging you into her drama, and you're letting her."

For a second, it occurs to me that I can correct him and the other this isn't what it looks like. But it's a fleeting, passing thought

that comes and goes like the speed of light. Looking back, it would have been the better option. But hindsight is 20/20.

I lunge at Raiden with a primal roar, my fist aimed directly at his jaw. The satisfying sound of bones crunching against each other fills the air as my knuckles make contact with his unyielding face. Pain shoots through my hand, but it's nothing compared to the satisfaction of hitting him square in the jaw.

Raiden's body jerks backward, caught off guard by my unexpected assault. He touches his face gingerly for a fleeting moment before a cocky grin spreads across his face, and he hits me right back.

My head feels like it was split open by a sledgehammer. Agony shoots through my skull, blinding me with pain. The room becomes a blur as tables and chairs fly in all directions, accompanied by deafening shouts and screams. Dustin springs into action, snatching Harper from the chaos before it consumes her. Meanwhile, Russell rushes to his brother's side, frantically imploring him to cease the violence before someone gets hurt.

"He started it," Raiden roars, spitting on the carpet a second later. "I didn't take you for the violent type, Jackson." He rubs his jaw, a bruise already appearing from the swiftness of my blow. "I like it. We have more in common than I thought."

I reach up to massage my throbbing head. Pierce and Ethan stand behind me, both asking if I need anything. "I need you to get this fucker out of my house," I glare at Russell. "Or else I'll kill him."

Russell sighs and turns to his brother. "Come on, Raiden. Let's go before you make things worse." Raiden scoffs but follows his brother out of the apartment without another word. Poker night is officially over.

Once they're gone, Pierce gets an ice pack for my head, and Ethan starts cleaning up the spilled drinks. "I'm sorry, guys," I apologize awkwardly as I realize I'm the reason our poker night devolved into chaos.

"Don't apologize." Dustin steps forward to squeeze my shoulder, reassuring me that everything is okay. "He had no right to talk about Carrie like that."

Usually, I would agree, but I didn't hit Raiden because he was wrong. I hit him because he was right. "Still. I should have asked him to leave. I shouldn't have thrown the first punch."

Ethan pulls up a chair and plops down in front of me. His eyes meet mine with a mischievous glint as he leans forward, resting his elbows on his knees. "Listen, Jackson. We've all wanted to beat the shit out of Raiden Drake before. He had it coming."

"If you say Carrie has something going on tomorrow, she has something going on. Raiden doesn't know you well enough to question that," Pierce adds.

I let them baby me for a few more minutes, soaking up the attention and validation. Dustin and Harper say their goodbyes, bowing out under the guise of letting the babysitter leave early. I'm left with Ethan and Pierce, who manage to clean up and put away everything while I nurse a headache.

"Guys, I need your help." I decide to tell them the truth. Keeping all these secrets is eating me alive.

"What's up, dude?" Ethan asks. "Did that fucker give you a concussion? Do we need to take you to the emergency room?"

God, no. I'd rather die where I sit than go to the ER. "No. My head is fine." The room is spinning slightly, but not enough for me to worry. "Carrie is married."

Ethan's eyes widen in shock and his mouth hangs open. His eyebrows raise as he takes in the information, his expression a mix of surprise and concern. "Oh, shit. I didn't have Jackson being a homewrecker on my 2023 bingo card."

"She's married to my father," I add, ignoring him. "And I'm going to break them up."

"She's the soup." Pierce strides confidently to the fridge. With a swift motion, he reaches for a cold beer, the red and white label gleaming in the light. As he pops the top with a satisfying hiss, he tosses it effortlessly into the trash can nearby before returning to the table.

Ethan has no idea what we're talking about. "Like, chicken noodle?"

It's all so absurd that it makes me laugh. If I were to tell Ethan and Pierce everything, they'd have me committed. "She's the soup," I assure Pierce, confirming his suspicions. My previous attempt at explaining myself may have fallen short, but Pierce remembers the soup metaphor. And understanding dawns on him. After a long moment of silence, he asks, "Does she know you're technically her stepson?"

I shake my head no; it's a fact that plagues me. And, I admit, a fact that turns me on.

"Step-MILF," Ethan nods. "I can get behind that." He has no idea what's going on, but he plays along. "I thought you didn't know your dad, though."

"Mom told me a few years ago. I found him when I was in college. He, uh, he helped pay for my degree, and he helped me get the library job, too." I refrain from telling them who he is. I'm not sure why, but it feels like saying his name would add an element of danger I'm not ready for.

Pierce sits quietly on the opposite end of the table, sipping his beer and thinking.

Ethan speaks up. "Pretty decent guy then, huh?"

I lay the ice pack on the table, never taking my eyes off Pierce. I can see his mind working to connect the dots. I take the mystery out of the story by announcing, "He left my mother when she got pregnant with me because he was already married. And I'm blackmailing him with this information. He's a prominent figure in the community, and this would damage his reputation. But I want him to pay for what he did to Elaine and me."

"It's a dick move," Pierce repeats what he said about the soup during our last chat.

"Maybe, but he's a rich asshole who thinks he can do anything. And I want to be the one who shows him he can't."

Ethan clears his throat, drawing attention to himself. "Are we still talking about chicken noodle soup, or are we past that?"

Chapter 33

Carrie

Some people stumble headfirst into danger. Others see it clear as day and continue on their path with reckless abandon.



“This isn’t a good idea.” Every fiber of my being is tingling with excitement and dread.

Jackson’s breathy laughter comes over the phone, causing my stomach to twist with a mix of excitement and nervousness. My senses are heightened, my body tingling in anticipation. “You said Malcolm was at work. What could possibly go wrong?”

Nora could show up unannounced. I told her I wasn’t leaving the house today, but what if Malcolm insists that she drop by to check on me? He’s done it before.

My husband could come home early. It’s a rarity, but it happens. Sometimes, he texts me when he’s on his way, and other times, he just arrives.

“It feels dangerous, Jackson.” I nervously gnaw on my bottom lip, teeth dragging across the soft flesh as nervousness washes over me. I take a deep breath and try to calm myself, grateful that he can’t see me over the phone.

His voice is a steady anchor amidst the tumultuous sea of my emotions. While I am reeling, he remains calm and collected, a rock standing strong against the crashing waves of anxiety. “If there weren’t a hint of danger, it wouldn’t be fun. Relax, Carrie,” he says soothingly into the receiver. “It’ll be fine.”

I regret telling him about the garden maze my husband had carefully designed for the ultimate game of hide and seek. I regret starting this whole affair. The guilt weighs heavily on my conscience, and yet, I can’t bring myself to stop. My heart and mind are at war, torn between remorse and satisfaction.

“I’m getting off the highway now. You should hide,” he warns with a warm chuckle.

My cheeks flush in response, and I’m doubly glad he isn’t here yet. “But you’ve never been here before, Jackson. Don’t you want me to give you a tour? Show you around the house and—”

“I think I can handle it,” he cuts me off. “It’s just a game, Carrie. Hang up. Go hide. I’ll be there in a few minutes.” Jackson delivers the instructions with a calm and measured tone, which highlights my frazzled nerves. His words linger in the air like a thick fog, heavy with unspoken implication.

“Okay,” I reply. “But for the record, this is a bad idea.”

Jackson chuckles again, “So you’ve mentioned. I’ll see you soon.”

The moment I end the call, a buzzing sensation erupts between my breasts. It’s as if a hive of bees has taken up residence under my collarbone, their wings vibrating against my chest. The sensation pulses and hums, radiating through every inch of my body. Each breath feels heavier and more labored as the buzzing intensifies, making me feel like I am about to burst from the inside out. “Hide,” I mumble to myself. “I have to hide.”

After poker night, I felt comfortable sharing more of myself with him. He wanted to know what Malcolm's threat was if I didn't get home in time, but I was afraid to tell him. I didn't want to hear the inevitable speech that I needed to leave Malcolm before he got violent. Instead, I told Jackson more about myself.

I told him about Kaye and Christine and how I've always wanted a friendship like theirs. I told him about my wedding day, all three of them, and how I wished I had skipped the second. I told him about the foundations and charities I volunteer for, and how I love being able to give back now that I am no longer the recipient of their handouts. I told him about the garden maze and how my husband loves to hunt.

Jackson jumped on the chance to see the garden. And I'll admit, I'm nervous for him to come over. Not because it's the house I share with my husband but because it's another step in the wrong direction. Everything I do with Jackson—every text message I send him, every photo we send on Snapchat, every time we meet—is like playing with a match. Each form of communication strikes the sulfuric head against an igniting surface, and we pray it doesn't burn us down.

I haven't told Jackson that my husband and I have played the same game he wants to play now. Malcolm has chased me through the hedges in a sexual version of the most dangerous game. We've fallen beneath the weeping willows and made love under the stars. I have a dozen memories of the maze, and my disloyalty to Malcolm feels worse because this place was meant to be ours.

As I step outside and walk toward the garden, I know I'm making an irreversible decision. I am choosing Jackson over Malcolm. I am choosing fun over faithfulness. I am choosing danger over safety.

And though my heart is pounding and a frisson of electricity echoes through my fingertips and toes, I step into the maze and let the danger pull me under.

Chapter 34

Jackson

I don't run in the same circles as my father, and our styles are very different. I would never, in a million years, think of having a garden maze constructed in my backyard. But Carrie says this isn't even the first of its kind; Malcolm had one designed at the home of his first wife.

I can imagine what he uses it for. He's a predator, fueled by the thrill of the hunt, always seeking his next prey. The spoils of victory are just a temporary satisfaction for him, nothing compared to the rush of adrenaline coursing through his veins as he stalks and captures his target. Malcolm is disgusting, but today, I'll profit off his disturbing nature.

The picture in my head doesn't do the garden justice. As I pull into the McCade family's sprawling estate and leave my truck in front of the house, I make my way around to the backyard. I'm caught off guard by the size of the maze. It isn't a cute little walking path that an older couple might stroll through after dinner; it's an expansive labyrinth of greenery and blooming fall flowers.

"Carrie," I announce my presence at the entrance, "do you want to play a game?" A rush of adrenaline courses through my veins, setting a lively rhythm in my body. My muscles tense and quiver, ready to spring into action at any moment—it's a feeling of pure exhilaration.

A hush falls over the surroundings, a pregnant pause lingering in the air. Suddenly, from the depths of the maze, a voice seems to drift back to me. "Don't get lost, Jackson."

The hedges, meticulously trimmed and shaped with an obsessive hand, loom over me like towering walls of emerald. Their glossy leaves rustle and murmur secrets in the gentle breeze, adding to the sense of enchantment surrounding me. I inhale deeply, the air thick and heady with the intoxicating scent of honeysuckle and roses. The delicate flowers twine intricately around trellises, their vibrant colors standing out against the muted green foliage. Then, I begin the hunt.

The thought of Carrie—her laughing eyes, the curve of her smile, the way she's beginning to lean on me as a lover and friend—drives me forward. In the warmth of the early autumn afternoon sun, I shed my jacket on a waiting bench near the entrance.

"It isn't fair that you're more familiar with the maze than me," I announce to the silence. "For instance, you probably know what to do when you come across this horse statue. It's very beautiful, by the way." I run my fingers along the curve of the horse's back. It's raring up in excitement, hooves pointed to the right.

I don't know much about mazes, but if it's telling me to go right, I'll go right. I pass a willow tree that sheds its color-changing leaves all over the cobblestone. I'm not watching where I'm going, and I trip over a raised edge in the sidewalk and fall forward. Luckily, I catch myself before I scuff up the knees of my slacks. And off to my left, I hear a giggle.

While dusting myself off, I look in the direction of the laugh. Trees sway in the breeze, keeping silent about where my lady love is hiding. "Carrie," I call out, testing her name on my tongue. My voice is low and playful, a tease against the rustling backdrop of the maze. No response follows, but she's close; I can feel it in the quickening of my pulse, anticipating the chase to come.

I round another corner and find myself face to face with a statue of Aphrodite, her marble skin polished by time and her eyes set in a knowing gaze. "Have you seen the woman I love?" I whisper conspiratorially to the goddess. She gives nothing away.

I follow the maze until there's a break in the hedges, and then I head back toward the sound of Carrie's earlier giggle. The path twists and turns, leading me through archways of roses wrapped around wrought iron. A flash of color catches my eye—the edge of her dress disappearing behind a corner. "I'm coming for you, Carrie!" I announce with a grin.

Another giggle reaches my ears, this time from another direction. The foliage around me seems to pulse with life as I follow after my blonde beauty. There is no hint of fatigue in Carrie's steps, only playful mischief as I hear her dart through a hedge, her body rustling the leaves.

I quicken my pace, shoes clipping against the cobblestone path that weaves back and forth, revealing openings and dead ends. As I round a bend, I allow myself to be entranced by the sight of golden rays dancing through a sun catcher. Blues, purples, and reds splatter the ground before me in fractured form. Then Carrie's laughter rings out, teasing me with its nearness, and I surge with excitement at the prospect of catching her.

I follow the sound, darting down a path only to find it's a dead end. I swear under my breath as I turn around, undeterred. My desire now mixes with thrill. It isn't just about reaching her anymore—it's about the chase itself. Suddenly, I understand why my father enjoys this so much.

Finally, as I round another twist in the path, I see her—a vision standing in an open circle where the ivy has been trimmed back to reveal a hidden glen. Sunbeams cascade around her like a spotlight. Carrie is staring at the other exit of the glen, oblivious to my presence.

With deft silence, I close the distance between us. My breath is shallow from exertion, and just as Carrie turns to look over her shoulder with an impish smile playing on her lips, I reach out to grab her. My hands find her waist, and with assertive tenderness, I pull her close against me. She screams from fright and excitement, laughing all the while. And in the midday sun, her chest heaving from running, hair askew from the wind, she looks more beautiful than I have ever seen her before.

“Gotcha, gorgeous,” I smile down at her.

Her gaze is coy and inviting as she wraps her arms around my neck. “And what are you going to do with me now that you have me?”

Chapter 35

Carrie

It's like every game I've played with my husband, but less predatory. Whenever Malcolm catches me, he likes to bend me at the waist to mount and fuck me from behind like a victor claiming his prize. But Jackson is tender and sweet.

He leans down to press his lips to my shoulder, a gesture that brings goosebumps to the surface of my arms. "I'm going to lay you down among the trees and make love to you. Strip off this dress," Jackson murmurs in a throaty whisper as he slides the silky sleeve of my gown languidly down my arm, "and I'll worship every inch of your breathtaking body."

His hands venture beneath the hem of my dress, traveling across the expanse of my abdomen before dipping teasingly below the swell of my hips. My nerves hum with anticipation and desire, my eyes fluttering closed as I allow myself to give in to the sensations.

"You're wet already," Jackson teases as he slips his hand into my panties. His fingers slide through my center, forcing me to widen my stance to feel more of his touch. His gaze locks onto mine—drinking up every silent pant and shuddering gasp that comes from my lips as he drags his digits back and forth through my wetness.

"Wet for you," I groan, holding on to him to keep from falling over. My knees grow weak, and my thighs twitch in eager anticipation. I toss my head back and grind my hips against his fingers, trying desperately to get more friction. But Jackson withholds, keeping me on the edge of madness.

"I can't wait to be inside you," he whispers in my ear. "I want to feel your warmth wrapped around me, your muscles tightening as I make you cum all over my cock like a good little girl."

I whimper, his words sending shockwaves of desire coursing through my body. I didn't think I'd feel this way about anyone but my husband, but Jackson touches a part of me more deeply than I could have ever imagined.

As he continues to tease me, I find myself growing increasingly needy for his touch, arching my back in invitation. Jackson's fingers glide smoothly across my sensitive folds, finding a sweet spot that makes me shudder with pleasure. His other hand is wrapped around my back, holding me in place as he presses soft kisses to my neck and nips at my jawline.

"You're so beautiful," he whispers against my skin.

My body, feverish from the chase, desires more than gentle caresses. "This isn't enough," I pant, reaching up to unbutton his shirt. "I need more of you, Jackson. I need *all* of you."

With great reluctance, he withdraws his fingers and pulls away to begin undressing. As he takes off his shirt and unzips his pants, his hard-length springs free, thick, and ready for action. I gasp as I see him fully naked for the first time. His muscular chest ripples with each movement, and he looks perfectly at home among the trees and flowers. He's the Adam to my Eve, and we're in our very own Garden of Eden.

"Take off your dress," Jackson orders.

I'm less confident than he is. My body is thirty-two years old, with cellulite and stretch marks from having a child. I avert his gaze as I slip the dress over my head, discarding it beside us. I cover my stomach with my arms, willing it to look flat and perfect in Jackson's eyes. I feel as if I should apologize; I'm not the woman I portray myself to be. I am expertly styled in clothes tailored to my body. But outside the fabric, I'm like any person with fat and wrinkles.

But Jackson is not my husband. He doesn't see my belly fat as a reason to chastise me about going to the gym more often. He doesn't see my stretch marks as reminders that I'm a used woman. Jackson sees every mar on my skin as something worth kissing.

"Don't," he says as he steps forward to pull my arms away from my body. "You are beautiful, Carrie."

I'm afraid to believe him. Men will say anything to get what they want; that's always been my experience. But Jackson quickly realizes that I don't trust his words and he reinforces them with actions.

He stands before me, kissing his way down my body. Every time he places his lips on me, it's on another body part I deem unacceptable. He traces the contours of my body with a tenderness akin to reverence. He moves down my body gently and unhurried, his lips dancing across the silver tendrils that have always made me self-conscious. "Your body is perfect. Not perfect *for me*. Not perfect *in my eyes*. It is simply perfect," he whispers against the stretch marks.

Tears well up in my eyes as he worships every inch of me. He even deigns to kiss the scar on my knee from when I was six.

"Ride me," he whispers from his kneeling position. "I want to see your body on top of mine."

Jackson sprawls out on the soft grass, his chest rising and falling with each steady breath. I straddle his lap, feeling the warmth of his body against mine. The hard length of his cock brushes against me, igniting a fire that only he can quell. He grabs my ass cheeks, guiding me down gently onto his hard, waiting member.

I bite my lip and close my eyes, feeling every inch of him stretch me out slowly. My hips move involuntarily, grinding against his, desperate for more friction. Jackson's fingers dig into my skin as he growls low, "That's a good girl." The feel of his rough hands on my smooth skin sends shivers of pleasure through me.

I move slowly at first, savoring the sensation of being filled by this man who sees all of me and loves every inch. His grip tightens, urging me to move faster. Jackson's eyes never leave my body, burning fiery little holes of desire through every part of me.

Leaning forward to kiss him, I'm enveloped by the scent of sweet nectar from the flowers, freshly cut grass, and warm earth. Jackson groans deeply into the kiss as he thrusts harder into me, pressing his lower body against mine with an animalistic urgency. The sound of leaves rustling under our bodies creates a cacophony around us; our moans and gasps blending seamlessly into nature's music.

Jackson's hips rise to meet mine as he bites my lower lip. The pain and pleasure are exquisite, an erotic tango of sensations that fuels the need burning inside me. My lips taste faintly metallic as he nips me again, drawing a hint of blood this time. "You're all mine now," he whispers against my mouth with a smile.

With a fierce intensity burning in his eyes, he seizes me around the waist and swiftly flips us over. My back hits the ground with a thud, but before I can even catch my breath, Jackson is driving himself inside of me. Our bodies move together in a dance as old as time, lost in the heat and passion of the moment. "Mark me," he growls. "Drag your pretty nails against my skin until every other woman knows I belong to you."

I obey his order, pressing my nails into his shoulder blades until crimson lines form in their wake. Each scratch leaves a mark, a reminder of this intense moment between us, and Jackson groans approvingly at the sting before biting down on my neck just as hard. He leaves a mark but doesn't break the skin. Another souvenir that says I am his.

Jackson's hips pump faster now, his muscles flexing underneath my hands. My breath hitches in my throat, consumed by the pleasure of our bodies pressed against one another. And before I know it, we're coming together. His cock throbs inside me, and I wrap my legs around his hips, pulling him in deeper.

"Fuck," he swears, and the invective echoes through the maze. His hips jerk hard and fast one last time before he stills inside me, pouring every last ounce of his juices into my womb.

"Are you okay?" Jackson whispers hoarsely, his forehead resting on mine. I nod weak, still trying to catch my breath. "Good," he smiles and plants a chaste kiss on my lips before pulling out.

I feel empty without him, but I don't have the energy to protest as he helps me to my feet. "We're like Adam and Eve in here," I tell him, echoing the quiet sentiment I only voiced to myself.

Jackson grabs my dress and hands it back to me, a small smile playing on his lips. "I think I'm falling in love with you, Carrie Pennington."

My diamond engagement ring twinkles in the sunlight, but it's not enough to remind me of my husband. It doesn't stop me from trying to utter the words back. "I think I'm—"

But a roar cuts me off. Somewhere behind us, I hear Malcolm's voice. "Whose fucking jacket is this!"

The color drains from my face.

My husband has come home early, and my greatest fear has come to life.

Chapter 36

Carrie

Jackson lets out a string of frustrated curses, his breath quickening as he hurriedly pulls on his clothes. The fabric rustles against his skin, and his fingers fumble with buttons and zippers in his haste. Time is of the essence, and every second counts. “I should have brought the fucking jacket with me,” he swears.

Everyone has a fight-or-flight instinct, and in the face of danger, I usually freeze. But not today. I don’t know if it’s courage or stupidity that drives me to push Jackson toward the other end of the glen. “Go that way and stay to the left. When you see a bush of white roses, turn right.” I can picture the maze in my head as I rattle off the directions to find his way out. “When you come across the wheel, take the third spoke and stay right. You’ll be free after that. Go!” I shoo him away. “I’ll take care of Malcolm.”

I feel like I’m in a trance as I call my husband’s name. “Mal,” I feign innocence, “is that you?”

“Who the fuck else would it be?” I hear him, closer now, storming through this place of serenity. “Whose fucking jacket is this, Carrie? And why is there a fucking truck in our driveway?”

I can no longer hear Jackson’s footsteps, and I hope that means he’s going to get away unscathed. If Malcolm finds him here, he’ll call the police. Or worse.

“I’m trying to figure that out, too,” I lie. “I saw the truck earlier and thought it was one of the gardeners.” I brush my fingers through my hair to smooth the flyaways. There’s dirt on my knees, and I swipe it away. There’s nothing I can do about the grass being trampled where Jackson and I were. Instead, I move away from the glen. I put distance between myself and the place where he and I made love.

I run into Malcolm a few turns away. He has Jackson’s jacket crumpled in one hand and a furious look on his face. “I found you,” I smile.

“*I found you,*” he returns with a glare. “Whose jacket is this? Who are you fucking, Carrie?”

My face crumples with hurt, and it’s almost genuine. I know that my husband is having sex with other women, but God forbid I do the same. “Mal, please, don’t jump to conclusions. When the truck didn’t move after a while, I came looking for its owner. I saw someone come in here, and I followed them. But they disappeared. I don’t know who it was.”

“Liar,” Malcolm growls. “Tell me the truth, Carrie. I’ll be easier on you if you do.”

The threat transforms the Garden of Eden into my personal hell. Malcolm could do whatever he wanted to me in here, and no one would ever find my body. There are plenty of dead ends that could be dug up and replanted if a body were to be buried. “That is the truth, Malcolm. I swear.”

He reaches forward, and I flinch away from him, inciting his anger. Malcolm’s fingers encircle my throat, pressing against the delicate skin with a force that sends shivers of fear down my spine.

The possessive grip that used to ignite desire in me now fills me with dread as I struggle to stand still under his suffocating hold. My pulse races and my thoughts spin as I wonder if, this time, he might actually choke the life out of me. “If you’re fucking someone behind my back, now’s the time to tell me. I’ll make him pay, and I’ll punish you, too, but it’ll all be forgiven. However, if I find out you’ve been hiding an affair from me, you will wish you’d never been born. I’ll ruin you, Carrie. I’ll make sure that you never fuck another man again. And just so you know I’m not kidding, I’ll ruin your daughter, too. She wants

to be a lawyer one day, but if I find out you're lying to me, I'll bankrupt that little bitch until she can't even afford to get up in the morning. Do you hear me?"

The truth dances on the tip of my tongue, nearly ready to come out. Kaye means everything to me, and I can't have my husband ruining her life because of the choices *I've* made. I suffered through Owen and his abuse until the day he put his hands on my daughter, and then I finally left him. I can handle Malcolm's obsessive nature. I can survive any physical or mental pain he inflicts upon me. But threatening my daughter is where I draw the line.

"I promise, Malcolm. There's no one for me but you." The lies slip from my lips, lubricated by fear.

I'll find a way out of this. I don't care if I lose Jackson *and* Malcolm. I'll do whatever it takes to keep Kaye safe.

I'm the one who's made every choice that got me here. I have to live with the consequences of my actions, not my daughter. And I don't care if I'm unhappy as long as she is safe.

Chapter 37

Jackson

If she loved me, she wouldn't tell me to leave her alone.
If she loved me, she would want to replace her husband with me.
If she loved me, she would take poverty with *me* over a life of riches with *him*.



I rock back and forth, eyes fixed in the distance on nothing at all. I'm lucky I can still breathe because fire feels like it's tearing through my body and burning me up from the inside out.

CARRIE

I can't see you anymore. It's too dangerous. I have to protect my family.

I know they're all words. On their own, I know each of their definitions. But pieced together and formulated the way Carrie has them, I can't make sense of their meaning.

We had a perfect afternoon. Carrie and I made love in the maze, our romance blossoming among the honeysuckle. And now she wants to end it.

JACKSON

What did Malcolm do to you?

I shouldn't have run off. I should have stood there in the center of the maze and waited for my father's arrival. I should have brazenly held Carrie's hand, kissed every knuckle and joint, and told her I'd take care of her. I should have had the courage to stand up to the man who's haunted every day of my life. I should have told him that I am head over heels in love with his wife.

But I ran. I followed her instructions to a T. I made it back to my truck before they emerged from the maze, and I drove off. My heart pounded the entire drive back to Rosedale. I made it back to my office before I got her text, and I've been numb ever since.

JACKSON

Tell me you're okay, Carrie.

I remember when she came over for poker night. Malcolm gave her a curfew; he made her come home early. She said if she didn't, he would... but she got cut off before she could tell me. I never found out what he was going to do to her. What if he hurt her? What if he threatened her? What if my father put his hands on the woman I love?

JACKSON

If you don't tell me you're okay, I'll show up at your door.

CARRIE

I'm fine, Jackson. Don't text me anymore.

I throw my phone across the room, and it sails directly into the wall before falling to the ground. "I can't do that," I growl, even though she can't hear me.

Carrie is my lifeline, my reason for existing. Without her, I am a hollow shell, slowly wilting and decaying until there is nothing left but a lifeless husk. She is the sun that fuels my every breath, and without her, I am doomed to wither away and die in the darkness.

I slam my fists down on the desk and swear. This was never supposed to be about Carrie Pennington. The plan was always to hurt my father. I was supposed to ruin *his* life, not my own.

Someone knocks on my door before tentatively opening it. It's Lauren from the office next door. She pokes her pretty blonde head inside and asks if everything is okay. I watch her eyes survey the room, falling to my smashed phone on the floor.

"Bad news," I mumble an apology. "I didn't mean to startle anyone."

Lauren doesn't move. "If you need to talk, I'm happy to listen. Or I can get your IT friend. Is it Peter? Pierre?"

"Pierce," I correct, feeling the fight go out of me. "But I'm okay. Thanks for checking, Lauren."

She remains for a moment longer, her head cocked slightly to the side before finally giving a subtle nod. "If you need anything, you know where I am."

In another lifetime, I thought about asking Lauren on a date. She's only a couple of years older than me and is as passionate about the McCade Library as I am. But I've never been free long enough to form a relationship with her, and now, I'm uninterested. She's very pretty, but she isn't Carrie.

Carrie.

The object of my affections and frustrations. I don't know whether to be mad at her or my father. Maybe they both deserve my ire.

The little voice in the back of my head reminds me that I'm the one who started all of this. And maybe the only person I can be mad at is myself.

Chapter 38

Carrie

There's a knock on the door midday, which is uncharacteristic. Solicitors don't frequent this community, and neighbors don't come over unannounced. There are unwritten rules in wealthy neighborhoods, and showing up in the middle of the day unexpectedly is one that you don't break.

As I peer through the crystal clear glass of the windows flanking the front door, my heart sinks. Jackson stands there with his hands in his pocket, a forlorn look on his face.

At first, I'm afraid. His appearance is sure to incite my husband. Malcolm is still reeling from yesterday's incident in the garden. I tried to reassure him that I had no part in it, but he wouldn't listen. Malcolm came inside and ignored me for the rest of the night. I made dinner, and when I announced it was ready, he deliberately ordered takeout right in front of me. It hurt, but I told myself that he was reasonably upset. I was doing exactly what he accused me of doing; I had no reason to be upset at him for lashing out.

But my fear of Jackson's arrival quickly turns to anger.

I texted him last night to let him know we can't see or talk to each other anymore. Why can't he follow directions? He's like a child who keeps running through the house after you tell him to stop.

With a swift, powerful motion, I fling the door open. My arms instinctively cross over my chest, a protective gesture against the handsome man standing before me. "What do you want, Jackson? I told you this needs to stop, and I meant it."

He doesn't waste any time. Without warning, Jackson lunges forward, grabs me by the shoulders, and pulls me into him. His lips meet mine with a sense of urgency and longing. His tongue fights its way inside my mouth, and the first caress almost makes me melt, but then I remember I'm ending this.

I forcefully push Jackson away, my anger boiling over. With a sharp sting, my open palm connects with his cheek. The skin-on-skin contact makes a ringing sound that echoes through the foyer of the mansion. His head snaps to the side, and I can see the hurt and shock in his eyes. "I'm serious, Jackson. Stay away from me."

But he doesn't. He reaches up to touch his face, briefly rubbing the sore spot before attacking again. This time, he catches me off guard. As Jackson pursues, he pins me against the wall and forces his tongue between my lips. His hands roam across the curves of my body, taking my pleasure against my will. It steals the breath from my lungs; it takes the wind from my sails.

Jackson dares to break the kiss a few moments later. "No," he says forcefully. "I can't stay away from you. I love you, Carrie."

I try to push him away, but he holds my arms tight at my waist. "I'm married, Jackson. Please. You have to stop."

"I can't." He pauses for a moment before adding, "And even if I could, I'm not going to. You're not happy with Malcolm, but I promise if you leave him and be with me, I'll make you happy. I can be everything you need, Carrie. I can make you happier than you've ever been in your entire life."

I want to believe him because the words sound so good coming from his lips, but I can't make this choice. If I leave Malcolm, he will systematically destroy the person I love most. So, I tell a little white lie. "I'm happy, Jackson."

He reaches up and wipes a tear off my cheek. "If you're so happy, then why are you crying?"

Because I've made a thousand mistakes these last few months. I betrayed my marriage vows by choosing another man over my

husband. I allowed Malcolm to openly stray from our marriage. I let myself accept his twisted version of abuse. And mostly, I'm crying because I'm responsible for all of this. I'm torn between guilt and anger, regret and longing.

A stronger woman would have remained faithful to her husband regardless of the man who presented himself.

A stronger woman would have told her husband that if he wanted to stay married, he'd stop going to swinger parties and disrespecting her.

A stronger woman would have let her husband get away with a single threat before packing up her bags and leaving.

But I am not a stronger woman. "You have to go, Jackson. Whatever my marriage is, *I'm* the one who has to fix it."

Jackson grabs my chin, forcing me to look up at him. "You don't have to fix anything, Carrie. You can leave Malcolm. You don't have to work to fix a marriage that's broken beyond repair."

I fix him with a glare. "Even if I'm one of the reasons it's like this?"

"He cheated first," Jackson returns my look of indignation with one of his own.

"And I cheated second. It doesn't matter the order. We both fucked up. We both made mistakes." My phone starts ringing in the living room, briefly distracting us from our conversation. "I should get that," I frown. It could be Malcolm or Nora.

Reluctantly releasing me, Jackson steps back. "We aren't finished here, Carrie. We need to talk about this." He follows me into the living room, eyes scanning every inch of the place Malcolm and I call home.

"Victoria's calling me." I hold my phone, staring at her name with uncertainty.

"Who's Victoria?" Jackson asks.

My finger hovers over the *'answer'* button. She's never called me before; it has to be important. "Victoria is Malcolm's first wife." I click the green button and bring the phone to my ear. "Hello, Carrie speaking."

Jackson picks up a book that Malcolm discarded on the table last night. I watch him finger the pages as I listen to the woman whose position I took.

"Carrie, it's Victoria McCade." This is a woman who was brought so low by my appearance in her life that I heard rumors from my daughter that she'd slipped into alcoholism. Yet, she speaks with a confidence that I'll never achieve. "We need to talk. Can you be here in an hour?"

Something in her tone makes me nervous. "S-sure," I hesitate. "Is everything okay?"

She pauses for a long moment before replying, "There was an incident between Xavier and Malcolm at the office today. I would appreciate it if you came over as soon as possible." Victoria hangs up before I can say anything else.

"What was that about?" Jackson asks when I let my arm fall to my side.

"I don't know, but I have to go. I think something happened to my husband." Chaos breeds more chaos. Jackson and I still have to settle things between us, but I have a feeling that whatever happened between Malcolm and Xavier is more important at the moment. I'll shelve my Jackson problem for later.

I expect Jackson to argue, but he doesn't. His eyes widen as he steps backward toward the door. "I'll call you later, Carrie."

"I wish you wouldn't," I sigh.

He flashes me a half smile that says everything and nothing at the same time. "I know, but I'm still going to call you."

I forget him as soon as he leaves and busy myself with a new thought. What happened between Malcolm and Xavier that made Victoria disregard her longstanding tradition of ignoring me to invite me to her home?

Chapter 39

Jackson

I parked down the street from Carrie's. After Malcolm came home early yesterday, I didn't want a repeat of the previous day's events. I am no sooner out the door before I am grabbing my phone and calling Dustin.

He doesn't answer after the first three rings, and I remember that he has today off from his last twenty-four-hour shift. I curse under my breath, and I'm about to hang up when he finally answers.

"Hey," Dustin answers groggily. "What's up, man?"

I feel like an asshole. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have called. I forgot you're off and probably need your sleep."

He yawns loudly on the other end of the phone. "Don't worry about it. I was going to get up in an hour anyway. Gotta work out today."

"Keep that firefighter's body in shape for the calendar," I joke with a grin.

"Shut up," he laughs. "You want an in-shape firefighter when your apartment burns down, Jackson. You don't want some wimpy kid who can't toss you over their shoulder and haul your heavy ass out because you inhaled too much smoke."

I snort at the picture he paints. "Romantic, Dusty. A big, strong firefighter lugging me over his shoulder like a damsel in distress."

"You'd be surprised how often I carry full-grown men out of burning buildings. Fire is a destructive medium, bringing even the strongest people to their knees. Anyway, what's up?"

I reach my truck and climb inside. "Do you still have contacts within the police department?" I can't hear him physically tense up in response, but the atmosphere shifts. I scramble to fill him in before he outright rejects to help. "Something happened to a friend. Malcolm McCade. Can you find out if he's okay?"

Dustin pauses so long that I check my phone to see if he hung up, but it says we're still connected. "Jackson, I don't know what happened with this Malcolm guy, but I don't know if I should—"

I cut him off before he can finish. "He's my father, Dustin, and his wife thinks something happened to him. Can you please look into this? If it's a criminal case, I get it. Don't tell me any details. But can you check and see if he's alright?"

Ordinarily, I wouldn't ask Dustin to do something like this for me. When he became a firefighter, he told us not to expect special favors. At the time, we all joked that it meant if our house were on fire, he wouldn't piss on it to put it out. But we knew what he meant. We knew if a restaurant had a fire, he wouldn't tell us if it was arson or an accident. We knew if he was called to a medical emergency at the university football coach's house, he wouldn't tell us if he performed CPR on the guy or if he had to take down a dead body. Our firefighters have dual roles, acting as both EMTs in certain areas of the county and firefighters across the whole region. They show up at every major accident in case someone needs the jaws of life to pull them from their car. They have an all-encompassing position that is vital to our community.

But I'm breaking the only rule he ever gave us because I need to know if something happened to Malcolm. He's my father. I don't have any great love for him because of how he dismissed my mother and neglected me my entire life, but he's still my blood. If something happens to him, I want to know.

"I didn't realize, Jackson. I'm sorry," Dustin apologizes after a minute. "I'll make some calls and see what I can find out." His

warm voice calms my nerves.

I call into work and let them know I won't be coming back today. I explain to my boss in as little detail as possible that there's a family emergency. I'm never late, and I always go above and beyond my job description; she tells me to take care of myself and let her know if I'll need tomorrow off, too.

I drive around Manhattan in a daze, creating new scenarios to explain what happened to my father. I dangle my arm out the window. I pass by the Target three times. I run into post-school traffic and slow to a crawl. Time passes in a strange fashion, speeding up and slowing down until I don't know if an hour has passed or ten minutes. But my phone eventually rings, and my friend's name flashes across the screen.

"Hey, Dustin," I answer, feeling the tight band around my chest return. "What'd you find out?"

He sounds weary as he replies. "I don't know, but the officer I spoke to said they responded to an anonymous tip to go to the McCade & Manchester law office a few minutes ago. When they arrived, they found someone bloody and bruised on the floor of Malcolm McCade's office. They were taking the victim to St. Francis."

My thoughts scatter like a flock of startled birds. I sit at a red light, the sound of wind and idling cars adding to the chaos in my mind. My mouth feels dry, and my throat constricts, leaving me mute. As the light changes, I am still lost in thought, oblivious to the world around me. Suddenly, a loud horn blasts from the car behind me, jolting me back to reality. I panic and fumble with the gear shift before accelerating through the intersection, flustered and embarrassed by my momentary lapse in awareness.

"Jackson?" Dustin asks. "Is everything okay? You shouldn't be on the phone while driving."

I tell him to hold on as I pull into the nearest parking lot. It takes me a minute to settle my nerves before I finally ask, "What happened?"

Dustin quickly responds, repeating what he said a few moments before. "I don't know. The guy didn't give me any details, and I didn't ask for them. There are rules, Jackson," his voice trails off.

Fuck the rules. I want to know everything. Was it Malcolm who was taken to the hospital? Who beat him up? How severe are his injuries?

"If he's your father, you can go to the hospital," Dustin says gently on the other end of the line. "They'll let you see him when he's stable."

I hang up the phone and put my foot on the gas, wheeling the truck around sharply until I'm at the parking lot's entrance.

I have spent the last four years planning my father's demise. I wanted to see him humiliated and ruined, but someone beat me to it. I need to know what happened. I need to know who beat me to the punch.

Chapter 40

Carrie

Victoria has considered me her arch-nemesis since the day Malcolm packed his bags and told her he wanted a divorce. I was spared the indignity of meeting her at their divorce proceedings, but we've seen each other around town. She kept the McCade name out of spite, and she attends the same fundraisers as I do, but we've made it our mission to stay out of each other's way. Neither of us wants to be in the same room when someone asks for Mrs. McCade.

That's what makes her phone call even more concerning.

I'm torn between fear and intrigue as I drive to the former McCade mansion. I pass by it on occasion, wondering if Malcolm's relationship with his ex-wife was as contentious as he made it out to be. In recent days, I can believe it. But Victoria McCade was the wife he married for love, and I'm the one he married for lust. So maybe what they had was different.

As I slowly pull my car into the long, winding driveway, the hairs on my arms stand up in anticipation. The late afternoon sun casts a golden glow over the lush green trees and grass. I shift my car into park and take a moment to check my phone. My heart skips a beat when I see an unread text message from Jackson; my stomach churns with anticipation and anxiety.

JACKSON

I love you, Carrie. I won't let your husband come between us.

I quickly dismiss the message. Part of me wants to respond, but another part resists, unsure how to handle this situation. My mind is a battlefield, torn between wanting closure and fearing the unknown consequences. "This isn't important," I mumble as I get out of the car. "Jackson and I are through. It's over."

But I knock on Victoria's front door with him on my mind.

"Come in," someone shouts impatiently from inside.

I let myself in, recognizing many of the features of Victoria's home. The open foyer, with its grand double doors and sparkling chandelier, bears a striking resemblance to my own. The impeccable design and attention to detail are unmistakably Malcolm's handiwork. From the sleek dark baseboards to the plush velvet couches in the living room, every element exudes luxury and sophistication. I see my husband in all the little details.

Victoria stands near the living room window with a glass of amber liquid in her hand. I don't know whether to look at her or Xavier, who lies on the couch covered in blood and fresh bruises. Someone hovers beside him, a doctor by the looks of it. He wears a white coat paired with jeans, but he's cleaning Xavier's wounds with a washcloth.

"Don't mind him," Victoria announces. "Xave will be fine."

A bitter, metallic taste fills my mouth, and bile rises in the back of my throat. I try to recall the details from our call. She said there had been an incident between my husband and his son—did Malcolm unleash his rage on Xavier until he was a bloody mess? My mind spins with possibilities, trying to decipher what could have sparked the violent outrage. "Is everything okay?" I tentatively ask.

Her head twists like the petals of a flower in the breeze. "He has a concussion."

The doctor clears his throat as if to draw our attention. "A grade 2 concussion, Ms. McCade." It's hard to tell who he's talking

to when we're *both* Ms. McCade.

"He has a grade 2 concussion," she repeats with a roll of her eyes. "Some cuts and scrapes from the fight. Swelling and bruising, mostly."

"A couple of broken fingers," the doctor adds as though they're an afterthought. "We can buddy-tape them. The break isn't too bad."

Victoria closes her eyes in annoyance. "Yes, *that*," she replies impatiently. "But Malcolm is worse off."

For a minute, I thought Malcolm had done this to his son and emerged unscathed. But if he had, why would Victoria have called me? "Where *is* Malcolm?" I ask after a few moments.

"Not dead," she confirms. "I had someone go to the office. One of his little secretaries was standing over him screaming. She called the cops while my friend took pictures. Malcolm looks terrible," Victoria adds with a cheerful smile.

"Wh-what?"

She turns away from the window, her steps soundless on the plush carpet. Making her way over to the couch where her son lays, she takes in his pale complexion and the gentle rise and fall of his chest as he breathes. Her gaze is filled with concern, and there is a faint furrow between her brows as she watches the doctor work, his nimble hands carefully tending to her son's injuries.

"I loved Malcolm, you know," Victoria begins nostalgically. "Not because he was young and handsome when we met but because he stood up to my father. I was supposed to marry someone within the family. I was a gift meant to unite two warring households."

Victoria Palmieri was born to be mob royalty, or at least that's what the legends say. Her father was a rising star in the Castiglione family, known for his brutal tactics and fierce loyalty. As she confirms for me now, he had high aspirations for his daughter.

"Days after my father arranged my marriage, Malcolm showed up and offered him wealth beyond measure, which is funny because my father didn't come from poverty. He'd already made his fortune in luxury goods. He didn't need Malcolm's money." Victoria's smile is odd—part reminiscent, part irritation. "But you know as well as I do that Malcolm doesn't take no for an answer."

I cautiously interrupt her, my mind racing to piece together the puzzle of why I was summoned here today. My eyes dart around the room, searching for any clues or hints that could shed light on the situation. "Did you say Malcolm was at the hospital? I should go. I need to check on him."

Victoria's eyes narrow, and her nostrils flare as she stubbornly continues forward, ignoring me altogether. "It took him less than a week to change my father's mind. I'm not sure what he said or did; neither of them would ever tell me, but I suspect threats and manipulation were involved. Something sinister enough that my father was willing to pay restitution for breaking a betrothal to the family I was supposed to marry into. I was sure the rest of my life would be a fairytale with Malcolm."

I realize I'll have to listen to her entire story before she gets to the point, but I suppose it's the least I could do after stealing the man she loved.

"There were low points, don't get me wrong," Victoria looks up to make eye contact with me. "Moments when Malcolm and I fought like cats and dogs. He wanted to control me," she explains, "but I was never meant to be controlled. I wouldn't cave to his demands, and he respected me for it. We butted heads, but at the end of the day, we always went to bed as deeply in love as the day we married."

In the first year of our marriage, I could have said the same. But the passage of time eroded the love Malcolm and I had for one another.

"I knew my husband had affairs. He was discreet, but I always kept tabs on him. I went to see the first one or two women I knew about. I threatened them. If they didn't want me to claw their pretty little eyes out, they'd leave Malcolm alone." She pauses for a minute as if trying to recall the next part of the story before carrying on. "But my mother pulled me aside one day and told me that men have their wives and they have their mistresses. They may fuck a woman for pleasure and beauty, but their devotion is to their wives. I stopped railing at the women after that. And my mother turned out to be right. After every affair, Malcolm returned to me. He showered me with flowers and gifts, and we were happy again."

Victoria steps away from her son and walks around the living room until she's standing right in front of me. Her face tightens as she looks me up and down, sizing me up and determining that I am not fit to be in the same room as her. "Then he met you. I thought you were another passing fling, but he left me. And I never recovered from the loss. I've wished every manner of torment and despair on him since the day he packed his bags and said he was leaving. It took years for God to answer my prayers, but I was patient. I was on my knees every day, asking for something terrible to befall Malcolm for what he did to our family. Little did I know the *terrible thing* would be our son."

"Xavier will be fine," the doctor announces. "If you wanted to take him to St. Francis for observation, you could. However, there will be questions. I think it's best if you keep him home."

With great effort, Xavier slowly peels himself off the couch, his movements sluggish and uncoordinated. His words are slurred and heavy, weighed down by whatever pain meds the doctor gave him. "I don't want to stay here. Take me to Kaye."

I whip my head around so fast that I nearly break my neck. "Stay away from my daughter," I glare at him. "Don't get her involved in your mess. She wants nothing to do with you."

"Oh, yeah?" Xavier places his head in his hands, cradling his bruises. He closes his eyes and takes a deep breath, trying to find solace in the darkness behind his eyelids. "She didn't say that when I was fu—"

"Enough," Victoria cuts her son off. "Carrie, do not distress my son when he's in this condition. Xavier, do not taunt Carrie with your indiscretions."

"What did you do to my daughter?" If I had sleeves, I'd roll them up. If I find out he hurt her... "If you laid a finger on Kaye, I'll kill you myself."

Victoria snaps at me, drawing my attention from Xavier. "Enough, Carrie. Malcolm is in the hospital. He and Xavier fought and—"

"I kicked his ass," Xavier mumbles. "And I'd do it again. He better not fuck with me anymore."

His mother looks done with his drugged interjections. Victoria tosses back the remainder of her glass of whiskey before using it as a pointer. "It is out of courtesy that I'm telling you this. Go home. Act as normal until the hospital calls you. If needed, sway Malcolm against calling the police."

"Calling them about what?" I ask, feeling exasperated. I still don't understand what happened.

"You may find that your husband is disfigured and wants revenge. He loves his son, but he may be willing to put him behind bars to pay for his crimes. Don't allow that to happen, Carrie."

Why am I responsible for what happens to Victoria's son? Xavier has never liked me. He's spent the last three years making my life miserable. "I can't control what Malcolm does. He doesn't listen to me."

Victoria narrows her eyes, "*Make* him listen to you. I will not see my son behind bars for your daughter."

"Kaye?" I frown, still consumed by confusion. "What does Kaye have to do with any of this?"

Xavier and Victoria exchange a look. Despite his altered state, he still has his wits about him. When Victoria opens her mouth to speak, he holds up his hand to stop her. "We should talk about all the things your daughter is keeping from you."

My heart plummets into my stomach. First Jackson, now this. My life is imploding, and instead of taking cover, I'm being pelted with shrapnel.

Chapter 41

Jackson

It's hours before they lead me back to see Malcolm.

When I arrive at St. Francis, the woman at the front desk scrambles to find Malcolm's paperwork. After ten minutes of searching, she looks up at me with a defeated expression. "I'm sorry," she says, "if he's here, his information isn't in the system yet." I take a seat in the sparsely decorated waiting area and stare at the clock on the wall, willing time to move faster. The fluorescent lights hum above me, filling the otherwise quiet room with a dull buzz. An hour passes before I finally muster up the courage to approach the front desk again.

This time, she tells me Malcolm's been admitted, but I can't see him because he's in surgery. My chest flutters with excitement and nervousness, a heady mixture of emotions that makes it nearly impossible to sit and wait.

I grab an early dinner in the cafeteria and lament with another couple about hospital food. But secretly, I've never had a better Salisbury steak. It's the taste of victory sprinkled on top that does it for me. Even the dry potatoes taste rich when I think about Malcolm getting his just desserts.

Back in the waiting room, hands have changed. A middle-aged man sits at the front desk and clicks mindlessly on the computer between him and incoming guests. I can see the glare from the screen on his glasses; he's playing solitaire.

I sit patiently in the waiting room for my father to be allowed visitors. In the hours between arriving and being allowed upstairs, I think about Carrie. She's had to have heard what happened by now. I'm surprised she isn't in the waiting room with me. But every time I think about her being here, I get anxious. If she were to show up, I'd have some explaining to do. And even though I am ready to tell her everything, her husband is lying in a hospital bed, and that makes this a bad time to break the news.

A nurse appears every once in a while to call people back—visitors of guests who are awake and functioning. When the nurse finally calls my name, I shudder. "Jackson Reid?" She reads the paperwork I filled out for the former receptionist.

I bounce up from my well-worn seat, suddenly feeling more awake. "That's me!"

She smiles politely and ushers me toward the elevator. "Good evening, Mr. McCade. We apologize for the delay. Your father underwent a lengthy surgery to repair his injured hand and reconstruct his fractured cheekbone. The doctor also discovered a severe concussion, multiple contusions, fractures, and extensive bruising. Despite these injuries, he is currently in stable condition. When we told Malcolm his son was here, he seemed surprised."

The nurse leads me from one corridor to another until we reach my father's door. Even though she told me what to expect regarding his injuries, I am not prepared for the broken and battered man lying on the bed before me. He has the shoulders of a proud lion and the build of a linebacker, but now he looks small and fragile. It takes everything inside me not to bust out laughing.

"We called his wife, but it seems Mrs. McCade was unable to get here in time for visiting hours. They ended half an hour ago, but since you've been waiting for so long, we thought we'd give you ten minutes with your father. Unfortunately, we can't do any longer than that," she says with an apologetic smile.

Malcolm opens his eyes. Upon recognizing me, what little skin on his face that isn't bruised turns an angry shade of red.

The nurse quietly departs, mentioning that she'll return shortly to escort me out. The door barely shuts before I burst into laughter. "You look good, Dad."

“Fuck. You.” The words come out in a raspy, breathless sort of way.

“I was with Carrie when she got the call that something had happened. Your ex-wife called her. I didn’t realize your wives were congregating behind your back. Did you know that?”

His eyes are bloodshot, the whites almost entirely overtaken by an ugly shade of crimson. “It was you the other day,” Malcolm chokes out.

I nod my head, knowing precisely what he’s talking about. “What gave it away?”

“License plate,” he mumbles.

I cluck my tongue and acknowledge my fault. “Got me there. You almost catching us in the maze nearly ruined my relationship with Carrie. She was ready to end things with me to save her marriage.”

“Fuck Carrie.”

I don’t think he’ll be doing any fucking any time soon. “Don’t worry, Malcolm, I’ll take care of your wife from now on. I’m going to tell her who I am soon. After she grieves the loss of her marriage—and believe me, she won’t grieve long, you’re not very kind to her—I’m going to tell Carrie who I am and why I did what I had to do.”

He opens his mouth to speak but says nothing. I see his eyes following me as I walk around the room, thumbing through the chart hanging off the side of his bed.

“My only regret is that I’m not the one who did this to you. Hats off to Xavier, by the way. That’s who did it, right?” That’s all the information I have. “How’d you piss off your son so badly that he put you in the hospital?”

Malcolm glares at me from the bed.

“Okay, fine, don’t tell me. I’m sure when Carrie finds out what happened, she’ll tell me all about it. We’ve become good friends over these last few months. You know,” I stop and stare at him, “ever since the gala where I kissed your wife in the parking lot. Or did we start getting closer when I kissed her in the library?” I frown. “Wait, no, it was probably after I fucked her in the McCade library.”

Talking about Carrie in these crude terms makes me uncomfortable, but it also raises Malcolm’s blood pressure. He doesn’t say anything, but the numbers on the screen increase with every word I speak.

“It costs nothing to be a good man, Malcolm, but you decided that price was too high. So now the choices you’ve made will cost you everything.” I place my hands on the end of his bed, squeezing the hard plastic until the joints in my fingers hurt. “Xavier put you in the hospital, but I’m going put you in the grave.”

One of the machines starts beeping, and a few seconds later, another nurse enters the room. She looks from me to Malcolm, studying the tension in the room. “You have to go,” she points at me angrily, correctly guessing that I’m the cause of Malcolm’s distress.

I snort in derision. “Gladly. I’m done with him anyway. Everyone is. Toodle-oo, pops.”

I walk out of his hospital room without a care in the world. Xavier’s attack just sped up the timeline of my and Carrie’s relationship in the best possible way. I was tired of her wishy-washy feelings and society-ingrained dedication to her husband and their marital vows. It’s time to remove him from the picture and start living the life I deserve.

Chapter 42

Carrie

“She’s taking me home,” Xavier slurs. “And I’m going to tell her everything.” Even though he’s been cleaned up and his wounds have been bandaged, my stepson looks like he’s been through a war. His handsome, angular face is marred with bruises and cuts.

Victoria threatens Xavier with the wrath of Dr. Harris. “I’ll have him anesthetize you if you don’t sit down this instant.”

The doctor clears his throat and mumbles something along the lines of, “Legally, I can’t do that without a valid medical reason.”

Victoria turns to face him, her eyes narrowing with anger. “I don’t care about legalities. I won’t let my son die because he wants to sleep in his own bed.”

“Don’t be dramatic. I’m not going to die,” Xavier rolls his eyes. But I remember getting a concussion when I was five years old, and my dad swore if I fell asleep, I’d never wake up.

I understand Victoria wanting to keep him home and awake if that’s the doctor’s order. But I stand at the entry of the living room with my keys in hand, trying to figure out if I’m taking Xavier home or not. His mother fights him at every turn, and I’m not sure if I’m supposed to say something or wait for instruction.

“I will not stay here and be babied all night, Mother. I’d rather die.”

Victoria bares her teeth when she replies, “Good, because if you don’t stop arguing, I may have to kill you.”

“Wow. It’s getting late,” I change the subject before the two of them start brawling. I don’t think Xavier would hit his mother, but I have no doubt that Victoria would smash a glass over her son’s head if it meant keeping him safe. “I should probably head home and—”

“No,” Xavier roars, getting to his feet. He sways for a moment, looking unsteady, and it’s a small point for Victoria. However, he gives himself a second before confidently continuing. “It’s bad enough that I’m injured. If Father calls the cops and they find me here, it isn’t going to be hard to put two and two together. They may even implicate you,” he implores Victoria. “Let me go home. If need be, Carrie can stay and make sure I stay awake.”

I frown at his logic. “So you don’t want to implicate *your mother* in your fight with Malcolm, but it’s fine to implicate *me*?”

Xavier and Victoria’s eyes lock onto mine, both sets filled with a mix of curiosity and amusement. Slowly, Xavier shrugs his broad shoulders nonchalantly as if to reply ‘yes’ to my question. Victoria’s lips curve into a small smile, another victory. “They’re not going to believe his wife had anything to do with his accident. His ex-wife? Sure, especially because it wasn’t an amicable divorce. But his current wife? No. You’re in love with the man.”

I feel the familiar heat of a blush spreading across my cheeks, and I quickly turn away from them in an attempt to hide it. But Xavier’s curiosity is only further ignited, and he turns on me.

“You love my father, *right*?” He asks with a glare.

I want to tell him that it’s complicated. I fell in love with Malcolm over depositions and legal documents. He promised to take care of my divorce proceedings the way some men utter promises of love. He brought flowers to all of our meetings and took the time to call me afterward just to check-in. His actions made me feel like someone out there cared for me during a period in

my life when it felt like I was all alone.

But the Malcolm I'm married to now bears a stark resemblance to the lawyer I met all those years ago. He looks the same, but his words and actions are harsher. He is no longer the man I fell in love with, but a darker version more likely to kill me in my sleep than love me for the rest of my life.

Xavier grows impatient with my non-response and snaps at the doctor. "Can I go now?"

Dr. Harris hesitates, shifting his weight from one foot to the other before finally reaching into his pocket. With a soft rustle, he pulls out a crisp prescription pad, its pages pristine and untouched. He swiftly scribbles down a couple of medications and dosage amounts, the scratch of his pen on paper echoing in the still room. With a satisfied nod, he hands them over. "I'd fill these as soon as possible. One is for pain, the other is for inflammation. They'll reduce your recovery time and keep you comfortable. You should ice your knuckles and face to reduce swelling. Rest, compress your wrists," he rattles off a list of instructions. "But ultimately, yes. You're in no immediate danger."

Victoria starts to argue, but Xavier slowly approaches her and places his hands on her shoulders. "I'll be fine, Mom. Trust me. I can't be here if Father wakes up and decides to call the police. This is the first place they'll look for me, and I don't want him to get any ideas."

This seems to satisfy Victoria. She leans forward to kiss her son on the forehead—gently, of course, because his face is variegated with purple and black bruises. "You're a good boy. I love you."

It's a tender moment, and it makes me feel like I'm intruding. Watching the two of them makes me miss my daughter.

But Xavier pulls away and snaps at me. "We're taking my car."

"But how will I get home?" I panic.

He sighs like his father does—as if everything I do annoys him. "Uber, Lyft, a taxi. I don't know. But my car needs to be at my house if the police show up." Xavier's words drip with accusation and resentment, but I don't care if he gets in trouble with the cops. He claims to have brutally beaten his father to the point where Malcolm has to be hospitalized. If this is true, he deserves to be locked up behind bars.

Xavier walks toward me, a gleam of anger in his eyes. "Let's go, Carrie. We need to talk about your daughter."

And I follow behind him the same way I've followed behind his father. These McCade men are bad for my health.

Chapter 43

Carrie

I despise driving Teslas. Malcolm insisted on getting one after our wedding, citing its reputation as the safest car on the market. But every time I slide into the driver's seat, something feels slightly askew, and it sends a shiver of anxiety down my spine. The sleek, futuristic design and advanced technology may be impressive to others, but for me, it only added to my unease behind the wheel. It is like trying to control a spacecraft instead of a car.

"What do you know about my daughter?" I ask, trying to distract myself from the drive. If Xavier didn't have a concussion, he'd be behind the wheel instead of me.

My stepson slumps in his seat, leaning it back as far as it will go. He closes his eyes, shutting out the world and any responsibilities he may have had moments before. His head rests against the leather, his breathing slow and even. "I know she's been keeping secrets about your husband from you. Probably the same way I know you're keeping secrets from your husband."

My mouth pops open in surprise. "H-how do you know?"

Xavier's nostrils flare, a deep rumble of amusement escaping his closed lips, but his eyes remain closed. "Come on, Carrie. I'm not stupid. You couldn't even say you loved my father back there. And sure, maybe it's because you were in front of Victoria, and she's an intimidating presence. I don't know. But I'm inclined to believe the apple doesn't fall far from the tree. Kaye is a whiz at keeping secrets, and I suspect you are, too." I struggle to form a reply, but Xavier silences my efforts with a dismissive flick of his hand. "It's fine. But whatever it is, keep it to yourself. My father is not the kind of man you double cross. Just look at me if you need an example of what he's capable of."

I tear my eyes from the road for a second to follow his command. His beautiful face is swollen and mottled in vivid hues, a stark contrast to his usual healthy complexion. "Do we need to swing by the pharmacy?" The doctor wrote out a couple of prescriptions for Xavier, but he haphazardly shoved them in his pocket.

Xavier's lips twist into a scowl as he grumbles, "I'd prefer not to." His usual air of cockiness is replaced with stubborn resistance. "I don't believe in getting doped up on pain meds unless it's absolutely necessary. And frankly, I'd rather feel this pain. I earned it; I deserve it. And I bet it isn't even half as bad as the pain my father's feeling right now."

I make a mental note to stop by CVS on my way into town. Xavier might be pleased with himself now, but he'll be singing a different tune when the adrenaline wears off.

"What's going on between Malcolm and Kaye?" I ask, changing the subject.

Xavier settles back into his seat, adjusting and shifting until he finds the perfect position. "He's been making moves on her. It was just flirting at the start, but he took it too far. When she told me what he did this afternoon, I lost it. I was going to kill him. But your daughter is a bewitching woman. She made me spare his life, and that's probably why I'm not in jail right now. If it were up to me, I'd have killed the bastard."

I try to reconcile the image of Xavier I have in my head—a man who teases and bullies my daughter, who hates me with every fiber of his being—with the one sitting beside me. He speaks with such sincerity about protecting Kaye from my husband, yet I can't shake off the doubts planted by my daughter's words. Is there another side to Xavier that I'm not seeing? Or is this all a façade to gain my trust? "What do you mean? What did Mal do to her?" My mind feels muddled as I struggle to make sense of it all.

Out of the corner of my eye, I can see Xavier reach down to adjust his chair. Slowly but surely, he comes to a sitting position and turns in his seat to face me. “Whatever we talk about here is between you and me. When the time comes, when we’re called to the hospital, you can’t let on what we discussed. It’s crucial to act as if this conversation never took place because if Kaye knows I told you, it will destroy everything I’ve been working toward.”

I feel like I’m trying to put together a puzzle with half the pieces missing. “Sure, okay. I promise I won’t say anything.” The words turn to ash on my tongue, filling my mouth with a foul taste.

“Malcolm threatened her career and livelihood if she didn’t have sex with him.”

My world crumbles and collapses in on itself, like a black hole devouring everything it touches. The street ahead of me stretches on endlessly, each mile feeling longer than the last. The pavement seems to ripple and twist under my tires, creating an optical illusion that only adds to the overwhelming sense of chaos swirling in my head. The oxygen is sucked from the car, forcing my lungs to shrivel and shrink until I think they’ll turn to dust. *Breathe*, I counsel myself, *in and out. Here and now. Breathe in air, breathe out fear.*

“I’ve been telling my father for weeks to knock it off,” Xavier continues, “but when Kaye called me this afternoon and told me what happened, I knew he would never stop. My father has the tunnel vision a hunter has for prey. I knew if I didn’t do something, he would either get what he wanted or burn down Kaye’s life in the process. And I couldn’t let that happen.”

All this time, I’ve been playing around the edges of an affair and dipping my toes in adultery, feeling guilty about my actions, and my husband has been pursuing my daughter. He’s been threatening her the same way he threatens me.

My grip on the steering wheel tightens as I white knuckle my way onto K18 towards Rosedale. It’s a bright, beautiful day, but all I see is red. Anger and fury cloud my judgment.

“Carrie,” Xavier calls sternly, “don’t do anything rash.”

“Says the man that put his father in the hospital,” I return.

He smiles in spite of himself. “Touché.”

Chapter 44

Jackson

With a shaky hand, I dial Carrie's number. The phone rings once, twice, and then she answers, her voice filling my ear and washing me in a wave of relief.

"Wait a second," she whispers into the receiver. Then I hear her talking to someone else. "It's not the hospital. Just go to sleep."

I hear a male voice in the background reply, "Don't tell me what to do." Then, a door slams, and there's silence.

Carrie returns to the line with a pitch of annoyance and an exasperated huff. "Sorry," she apologizes.

"Where are you?" My nerves are suddenly on high alert. The nurse told me Carrie couldn't make it to the hospital in time for visiting hours. I didn't think much of it, but now it comes back to me. What was Carrie doing when she couldn't see her husband at St. Francis?

"My stepson's," she replies quietly. I hear a door creak in the background before Carrie clears her throat and speaks louder. "My husband and his son got into a fight today."

I owe Xavier a beer. "So you're visiting your stepson instead of your husband?" I'm her stepson, too. But she doesn't know that.

"It's complicated," Carrie breathes. "He needed someone to take him home and watch him for a few hours. He has a concussion, but the doctor said he'd probably be fine. I'm in Rosedale, actually, just down the street from the university. I thought about calling my daughter to see if she wanted to drop by and keep me company, but she and Xavier have never been on good terms."

I'm learning more about this family every day. I wonder if Carrie knows her daughter and stepson are closer than she thinks. "Do you know why your husband and stepson got in a fight?"

Carrie lets out a heavy, weary sigh, the sound lingering between us like a thick fog. It fills the space with tension and unspoken words. "That's also complicated, Jackson."

My hand curls into a fist at my side. She can trust me; she knows that. So what is she hiding? "If you don't want to tell me, Carrie, just say so."

"It isn't that," she groans. "I'm sorry if I'm being cagey. I just found out some horrifying news tonight, and I'm still trying to figure out what to do next."

"What happened?" I soften my tone. "Tell me. I can help you."

Carrie hesitates for a minute before responding. "Malcolm has been making sexual advances toward Kaye and-and threatening her."

I don't know what to say. Everything inside me is screaming to go back to the hospital and give Malcolm a repeat of what Xavier did to him. I've always known that my father was a monster, but this goes beyond comprehension. Kaye is barely eighteen. Everything I've heard about her makes her seem like a docile kitten. And Malcolm took advantage of that by threatening her.

“I was okay when he threatened me,” Carrie goes on. “I know he does it to keep me in line. He has expectations for his wife and his life, and I understand. I am a formidable woman,” she clears her throat again, “I can change who I am to make Malcolm happy. But my daughter.” Carrie’s voice cracks and splinters, the raw emotion tearing through her words and searing into my heart.

“It’s okay.” I clutch the phone with desperate intensity; it is my only lifeline to the woman I love. I wish I could be there by her side instead of miles apart. I want to comfort her with the warmth of my presence instead of placating words whispered through cold plastic. “It’s all going to be okay, Carrie. We’re going to take care of it. *I’m* going to take care of it.”

“You can’t,” she breathes into the phone, her voice thick with emotion. Her words are accompanied by a shaky inhale as if she’s struggling to catch her breath. “I have to do this myself. I’m going to leave him, Jackson.”

The raw ache and bitterness in her tone tug at the strings of my heart, threatening to snap me in two.

I know Carrie still loves her husband despite everything he’s put her through. It’s hard to forget the way Malcolm used to make her feel like she was the center of his world. But now, every time she looks at him, she sees pain and betrayal. It must be hard to reconcile her conflicting emotions—love and hate, desire and betrayal. “You can do it, Carrie. You are the strongest woman I’ve ever met.”

She lets out a wild, unhinged cry that is equal parts madness and anguish. “That’s the thing. I’m not afraid of leaving him. I’m just—I don’t know how to explain it,” Carrie stumbles over her words. “When Xavier told me what Malcolm had done, I was angry but also relieved. These last few months with Malcolm have been a steady downward spiral. Just yesterday, I thought I’d have to give you up. And I made myself believe I was okay with giving up the last thing that made me happy.”

Her voice radiates with warmth and hope like someone seeing God after a near-death experience. “But then today happened, and it was like the universe had heard my unspoken prayers. In a matter of hours, I went from resigned to rejoicing. What kind of person is happy in a situation like this?”

“A person who needed it,” I reply. “I know you don’t feel like you deserve to get everything you want because you’ve made mistakes and you’ve done things you regret. But the universe has something better in store for you. Carrie, I know this feels wrong, but this is how it was meant to happen.”

“Why did my daughter have to be involved?” She breaks. “I could have lived by his rules for the rest of my life. Why did he have to bring Kaye into it? Why did he have to hurt my daughter?”

Carrie’s sobs echo through the phone, each one a sharp ache in my chest. I long to be by her side, to envelope her in a tight embrace and reassure her that everything will be alright.

My father’s sins have been stacking up like a tower of jagged bricks, and now it’s finally time for them to come crashing down. Karma, twisted and vengeful, has waited patiently for this moment to strike—and now it sinks its teeth into my father’s flesh with a merciless grip.

Karma is his son, stealing his wife away like a thief in the night...

Karma is a relentless beating that left him in a hospital bed...

Karma is his wife, realizing she can do better than him...

Karma has been biding its time, but now it descends upon Malcolm with the force of a battering ram. There will be no escaping its wrath as it crushes him under its weight.

And here I am, sitting front row to the downfall of my greatest rival.

Chapter 45

Carrie

It is one of those endless nights where the darkness seems to swallow everything in its path. I can't shake off the feeling of unease that settles deep in my bones, indicating something terrible looming on the horizon. I lie in bed, the hours dragging on, each minute feeling longer than the last. The more I think about tomorrow, the harder it is to fall asleep.

But the sun finally begins to rise, and the colors in my bedroom have become hues of gold and amber. I stretch from my restless sleep and prepare myself for the day. I look at the diamond engagement ring Malcolm proposed with and take it off for the last time. It glitters on the side table, twinkling at me with disdain, and I shove it into the drawer so I don't have to look at it.

I took a long, hot shower before bed a few hours ago, but I take another now. I let the heat turn my alabaster skin a deep shade of red, hoping that it will burn away my sins. But as I step out of the glass-encased shower into the steam-filled bathroom, I still feel every ounce of the weight of the world on my shoulders.

I breathe in deeply and begin the process of getting ready for the day. I brush and curl my hair, pulling it into a beautiful updo with not a strand out of place. I carefully apply my makeup, my lips a shade of red that Malcolm says is too ostentatious for a McCade. I pull on a dress that shows a little more leg than my husband would like, putting on a padded bra to make my breasts look fuller. Everything I do is an insult to the man I once loved. I do it intentionally; I want him to hate me when he looks at me because I hate him.

I left Xavier's just before midnight. He convinced me not to call Kaye until later today. He said I should see Malcolm first, then call my daughter and let her know there's been an accident. In his delirium, Xavier gripped my hand and said, "I don't want her to think this is her fault. She did nothing wrong. She's *never* done anything wrong."

I can tell he's in love with her. It doesn't take a rocket scientist to see that the way Xavier feels about my daughter is a love I've never experienced.

Before Jackson, you mean? The little voice in my head asks.

A warm smile curls around my lips. Jackson, a man who swept me off my feet even though I begged him not to. I wish he could be with me today. But alas, I must face Malcolm alone, with nothing but the memories of Jackson to keep me company.

Visiting hours at St. Francis begin at 10:00 am. The wait feels like forever. I watch the clock silently tick down to 9:45 before I get in my car and drive to the hospital. My heart quickens with every mile, and a fluttering of nervous butterflies beat their wings against my chest.

The woman at the front desk hums to herself as she looks up my husband's name on the computer before she makes a phone call and tells me to have a seat. A few moments later, another nurse in teal scrubs comes out of the elevator and offers to escort me to Malcolm's room.

She's quiet, and when I ask her if my husband is okay, she apologizes and says she just got on shift and isn't aware of his status. The sterile smell of disinfectant lingers in the air, making my nose wrinkle in discomfort. I can't help the knot that forms in my stomach as the elevator takes us to Malcolm's floor.

After navigating through a maze of hallways and corridors, the nurse finally leads me to my husband's hospital room. The door is adorned with a simple wooden sign labeled with his name and room number. "Visiting hours are over at 7:00 pm," she says quietly. "If you need anything, please let me know. Nurses will be by every couple of hours to check Mr. McCade's vitals."

I'm left staring at the off-white paint and wondering if he can see me through the window. My palms are slick with sweat, and my mind is a jumbled mess as I stand frozen outside the door. I don't know if I should walk in or walk away. But the last tendrils of loyalty to my marriage wrap around my body like a boa constrictor, squeezing the life out of me and forcing me to enter Malcolm's hospital room.

My heart aches at the sight of him, shrouded in bandages and bruised all over. I can't help but feel a strong sense of compassion for him, even though I know what he did to my daughter. But then his eyes flutter open, and despite the busted blood vessels, I can see a flash of fury in his gaze. Malcolm's eyebrows furrow, and his jaw clenches, veins pulsing in his temples. It's as if a fire has ignited within him, fueled by pain and betrayal. "About fucking time," he grumbles. "Where have you been?"

Any hope I may have had of staying with him is dashed in an instant. His angry tone sweeps away any chance we had at reconciliation.

Instead, I set forth to baby him, walking over to press my hand to his forehead and check his temperature. "The doctor didn't call until late in the evening. By the time I was able to make it here, visiting hours were over. I asked the doctor if you were alright, and he said you were stable and I could visit in the morning."

Malcolm swats me away. "Where's my son?"

The edges of my mouth turn downwards into a deep crease, mirroring the concern in my eyes. A small wrinkle forms between my eyebrows as my expression changes from anticipation to confusion. "I don't know where Xavier is at. Did you call him?" I doubt it. Victoria texted me this morning to say that Xavier was going to class today. Besides, I don't think he would have answered the phone if Malcolm had called anyway.

"No," he snarls, "but I want him here. *Now*. He's the shithead that did this to me."

My jaw drops as I feign shock and disbelief. "I can't believe he would do something like this."

Malcolm's sharp blue eyes narrow with irritation. "Get him here. And your bitch of a daughter."

My soft, worried expression hardens at his words. "Don't, Malcolm," the corners of my eyes tighten as the muscles in my jaw clench with anger. "Don't call my daughter a bitch."

With a groan of effort, he shifts his weight and rolls over onto his back. "Get them here. I don't care how you do it. They need to see what they've done."

With trembling hands, I force myself to leave the room. A part of me wants to do something drastic, like cut the tube that's delivering pain medication into his veins. But I walk away.

Outside the room, I lean against the cool, smooth wall and take a moment to gather my thoughts. "It's almost over, Carrie," I whisper to myself, trying to calm the racing beat of my heart. "I just have to get through today."

Once I tell Malcolm I'm leaving him, the rest will come easy. I just have to say the words and then face the music.

Chapter 46

Carrie

It's a couple of hours before Kaye and Xavier arrive. I spend a few minutes with Malcolm but realize I can't stand being in the same room with him, knowing what I know. I excuse myself to get lunch and only return when my daughter says she's on her way.

When Kaye walks through the door, her eyes nearly bulge out of her head before she races to envelope me in a hug. I hold her tight, trying to remember the last time she let me hold her like this. I want her to know I'm sorry for every bad thing that happened to her, but that's a lot to ask for from a hug.

Xavier looks unhinged as he stares at me, and I realize that the concussion has muddled his thoughts. "Did you know?" He questions, the boom of his voice causing me to jump.

"Did I know about what?" Kaye asks, looking as confused as me.

He shakes his head. "No, not you. *Her*." Xavier points at me, ignoring his father lying in bed. "Did you know about Victoria?"

Last night, he told me not to bring up what he had confided in me. I promised I wouldn't let on that I knew the truth, but at this point, I don't know where this is going. I chew nervously on my bottom lip before responding with what I think is a safe answer. "I knew Malcolm was married when he was working on my case. There were pictures of you and Victoria in his office."

The first time I met Malcolm, I complimented his beautiful family, and he glowed with pride. "But day after day, they started to disappear. By the time we got together, he'd been feeding me all the usual lines. He had a bad home life. He'd fallen out of love with Victoria. He was getting a divorce. I just-I fell for them because I was in a desperate place."

The truth spills from my lips in a torrent of raw emotion and unfiltered thoughts. Xavier's stoic silence only spurs me on, my words tumbling out in a frantic rush. "My ex-husband and I didn't have a good marriage. So when your father came around, I would have believed anything. He was nice and handsome, and he treated me right. He never looked at Kaye like she was a piece of meat. He was a good man, Xavier." I pause to purse my lips, forcing myself to remain calm even though I know what I'm saying is no longer true. "I'm sorry I didn't try harder to make sure he was telling the truth. I would never have intentionally broken up your family if I'd known."

"You don't owe him an apology," my daughter defends me. Her eyes snap toward Xavier, a storm brewing in their depths. "You could have asked her this when you first met, but instead, you decided to hate her because of what your father did. You blamed her; you still do." They speak to one another on a level I don't understand, as if there have been discussions I was never involved in.

Xavier snarls at Kaye, "I'm allowed to blame her. Do you know what it's like to find out that your parents, who—for all intents and purposes—love one another, are suddenly getting a divorce because your father fell for one of his clients?"

Malcolm sleeps through it all, the narcotics sheltering him in a cocoon away from our yelling and anger. My daughter squeezes my hand in reassurance before fighting Xavier for me. "No, actually, I don't know what that's like because my father died when I was five. And the next man to call himself my dad was an abuser. And the man after that," she looks toward Malcolm's bed, "you and I both know that he isn't any better."

This is it, the moment she'll tell us what happened and I can stop pretending I don't know. "Kaye, honey, what are you talking about?" I gently prod.

“You haven’t told her?” Xavier stares at my daughter expectantly.

“Told me what?” I look from Xavier to Kaye and back again. “What’s going on?”

“Don’t play dumb, Carrie,” he says, spit flying from his mouth in tiny droplets.

“Don’t call my mother dumb!”

Xavier shakes his head, sneering at Kaye. “You know, the *dumb* apple doesn’t fall far from the *dumb* tree. You thought you’d figure out how to make Malcolm stop what he was doing when you should have known all along that your efforts were futile. He’s a wealthy piece of shit.” Once again, I feel out of the loop. They have their own language, and I don’t understand it.

Kaye huffs at Xavier in frustration. “And you’re his son. What does that make you?”

“Smarter than you. Because I knew what needed to be done, and I was willing to do it.” Xavier’s eyes are wild, his demeanor as rabid as a feral dog.

“What did you do?” I ask, begging someone to tell me so I can stop pretending I don’t know why Xavier got in a fight with his father.

“Come off it, Carrie. You think he just wound up like this by accident?” He points at his father’s bruised and beaten body. “You’re looking at him and me, and you’re telling me you can’t surmise what happened?”

I blush a furious shade of red before finally responding. “I know what happened between *you two*,” I state, gesturing toward Malcolm and Xavier. “But what does that have to do with my daughter?”

Xavier, who told me the night before not to say anything, is the one that rats her out. “Malcolm has been trying to force himself on Kaye since she started working at McCade & Manchester a month ago.”

“I thought that was you,” I say wildly, trying to change the subject when I see Kaye’s jaw drop and her eyes sparkle with tears. “She’s told me in the past that *you* were the one harassing her. I thought it was sibling bickering. I didn’t think it was that serious.”

“So you tattle on *me* but not *him*?” Xavier scoffs at Kaye.

My daughter rolls her eyes. “That was a long time ago. I stopped telling her when she stopped taking it seriously. I decided to handle it on my own.”

Xavier throws his hands in the air, exasperation coloring his tone. “That’s it. Right there. That attitude is the problem.” He begins to pace the hospital floor like a caged animal. “You thought you could handle me, and look what happened. Maze. Then you thought you could handle Malcolm, and you put yourself in the *same* position. Tell me. If I hadn’t stepped in, how long would it have taken for you to bow to his demands?”

“You’re an asshole.” Despite the tension and hostility in the room, my daughter stands strong. She crosses her arms over her chest and pins her stepbrother with a glare full of defiance.

“And you’re stupid,” he matches her body language.

I stand there feeling out of place, like I walked into a fight I had no business being in.

Kaye snorts in derision. “If the *dumb* apple doesn’t fall far from the *dumb* tree, then the *bully* apple doesn’t fall far from the *bully* tree. You think you’re so smart because you solved a problem I couldn’t. Now your dad is in the hospital, and you’ve got to deal with the fallout. Congratulations.” But before Xavier can respond, she storms out of the room. “Also, go fuck yourself.” The door slams shut behind her, startling Malcolm awake.

His eyes shoot open, and he quickly surveys his environment, coldly locking onto Xavier with a glare. He manages to croak a single word; the malice in his voice is unmistakable. “You,” Malcolm spits at his son.

“Good, you’re awake,” Xavier narrows his eyes. “Now you can explain to your *wife* why you wanted to fuck her *daughter*.”

“I’ll kill you.” Malcolm tries to lift himself from the stiff, sterile sheets of the hospital bed, but his strength fails him. “When I get out of here, I’ll find you, and I’ll kill you.”

Kaye’s gone, and I’ve been left with a pissed-off father and son. These two can snipe at each other for the rest of the day for all I care. But now that the truth is out there, to the fullest extent I feel I’m going to get the truth, I need to say what I came here to

say. “Malcolm,” I interrupt.

“Shut the fuck up,” he snaps at me. “Let me talk to my son.”

Xavier stands up for me for the first time in the three years I’ve known him. “Don’t yell at her. She didn’t do anything.”

With a grimace of discomfort, Malcolm’s hand fumbles around the bedside table until he feels the familiar shape of the remote. With a click and a whir, his bed gradually adjusts to a seated position. The movement shoots sharp jolts of pain through his body, making him wince and grit his teeth. “She knows what she did. I’ll make you pay for fucking me over, Carrie. Don’t think you can cheat on me and get off scot-free. I’ll fuck you until you’re dead and bleeding. You’ll regret ever—”

My heart hammers against my chest as I force the words out, each one feeling like a weighted stone dragging me down. “I’m leaving you,” I declare, my voice trembling with anger and fear. The deafening silence that follows is only broken by the sound of my ragged breaths, and I can feel the weight of Malcolm’s shock and disbelief hanging heavy in the air.

“Like hell you are.” He tosses back the blankets covering his lower half and tries to throw his feet over the side of the bed. Out of fear, I step back, colliding with the wall behind me. But Malcolm cries out in pain, and an alarm goes off, alerting the nurses to his situation.

When the door opens, the quiet nurse from before enters, and I flee. With one final glance, I look at the man who promised me a life of love and luxury. But as I look into his eyes, instead of seeing my knight in shining armor, I am met with the devil himself. His eyes burn with contempt and malice, radiating a hatred that pierces through my heart and shatters any illusions I have about our relationship. In an instant, my fairytale has turned into a nightmare. There is no trace of love, only pure contempt for me and what I thought we had.

Xavier follows me into the hallway, placing a protective hand on my shoulder and jolting me back to reality. “Are you okay?” He asks.

A sense of relief washes over me like a weight lifted from my chest. For the first time in a while, everything feels alright. “I have to go. Thank you for what you did for Kaye and me.”

He nods his head, his bruises sparkling under the hospital lights. “I’d do anything for your daughter, Carrie. I can’t apologize for how I’ve acted toward you over the years, but I’m sorry for how my father treated you. I know now that he isn’t the man I thought he was.”

It’s not much, but it’s a start.

“Take care. Maybe get yourself some security,” Xavier warns. “Malcolm will probably be in the hospital for a few more days, but when he gets out, he’ll come for you.”

He can come for me all he wants, but I am no longer a plaything for his twisted desires. I have my freedom, and I will defend it fiercely against anyone who tries to claim me as their own ever again.

Chapter 47

Jackson

Two days. That's all it takes to turn my entire relationship with Carrie upside down. She goes from wanting to end things with me to wanting me to move in. And I know it's because she's scared of her husband, but I do it anyway because I love her.

"What are you going to do with his things?" With a scoff, I rummage through Malcolm's closet, digging past neatly folded shirts and jackets to find a hidden gem—a plaid shirt tucked away in the back. It's hard to believe he owns a fabric this cheap, and I suspect it isn't his.

Carrie sits on the king-size bed with her feet curled beneath her. "I don't know. I spoke to my daughter this morning, and she tried to play everything off."

I've heard Carrie's side of the story about what led to the fight, plucked straight from the mouth of my half-brother. Malcolm wanted something from her daughter that she wasn't willing to give, and Xavier took it upon himself to stop his father from ever touching Kaye again. I have more in common with Malcolm's privileged, golden boy of a son than I do with him. Go figure.

"What did she say?" I ask, minutely interested in Carrie's daughter. I have known since day one that Kaye was never on my radar. She wasn't close enough to Malcolm, and to be honest, she was too young for my tastes.

Carrie sinks into the plush bed, her arms stretching out to feel the cool fabric against her skin. "She said it was all a mistake, that she took something Malcolm said to her the wrong way. It's like Kaye wanted to soothe my fears so I'd stay with Malcolm."

My blood turns to ice in my veins. "Why would she want you to do that? Have you confided in her about your relationship with him?" She's confided in me about everything. We've stayed up late talking about how he made her feel small and insignificant. We talked about the ways he scared her into submission, forcing her to bend to his rules with threats of sexual torture.

"No," she sighs. "It shouldn't be my daughter's job to save me. Lord knows I imposed that duty on her enough when she was younger, and I hate myself for it now. But Kaye is eighteen, and she's experiencing the world for the first time as an adult. I don't want her to worry about me."

I step away from Malcolm's closet, still unsure where to put my things and join Carrie on the bed. I lean over her, my fingertips gently brushing away a few stray strands of sun-kissed blonde hair that have fallen across her face. Her skin is warm and soft under my touch, like silk against my fingers. For a moment, I am lost in the beauty and innocence of this simple moment between us. "Let *me* worry about *you*. Tell me what happened at the hospital, Carrie. I'm a big boy. I can handle it. I can ease your burden."

Her watery green eyes meet mine. She winces as she tries to hold back the tears that threaten to spill over and betray her emotions. "He knows I was cheating on him with someone else, Jackson."

I allow myself to look confused even though I know what she's talking about. "He was cheating on you with someone else," I remind her. "Several someones, in fact. He was regularly going to sex parties without you knowing and endangering your health with potential sexually transmitted diseases."

"I know." A tear slides down the side of her face, and she quickly brushes it away. "I don't regret the choice I made. I should have left him months ago, maybe even a year ago. I've felt division in our relationship for a while now. I kept telling myself

that if I could figure out what was wrong, I could fix it before the rift got too big. I knew I couldn't get divorced. No one takes a woman seriously who's been married three times."

I hate that for her. I hate that she chose society's expectations over her own happiness.

"But this is what I always do. I married Franklin Pennington because I was having his baby. We were dumb kids when we got together, but my momma told me it was the right thing to do. You marry the father of your child, she said. So when we turned sixteen, our parents agreed to let us get married. What did we know about marriage?" She shakes her head. "Sixteen, Jackson. I was sixteen and married for the first time in my life. I knew girls who were begging their baby daddy to talk to them, and then there was me, living their dream. And all I could think about was, what if there was someone out there I could be happier with?"

She was so young when she got married. The relationships I had in high school barely lasted a couple of months. I can't imagine the strength it takes to love your high school sweetheart even when you know he isn't *'the one'*.

"Then Franklin died, and for a long time, I thought it was my fault. It was my fault for wondering what life would have been like if we hadn't decided to keep Kaye. Frank might have lived if I hadn't thought about getting divorced and dating other men. He would have survived the accident if I'd just been happy with what I had instead of always wanting more."

I drag my thumb across her cheek. "That's not fair, Carrie. You can't blame yourself for being sixteen years old and wanting more out of life. It's what we all want at that age."

"But I had a kid and a husband. I had everything girls are supposed to want." She reaches up to place her hand on my wrist, grounding herself in the reality of my touch. "And it didn't feel like enough. Not with Franklin, not with Owen, and not with Malcolm. What's wrong with me, Jackson?"

I gently press my forehead against hers, savoring the warmth and softness of her skin. I marvel at how every inch of our bodies effortlessly fits together. "There is *nothing* wrong with you, Carrie. There has never been anything wrong with you. Your feelings are valid. Your desires are valid."

She nestles into me, and I hold her as if it will protect her from all the heartache she's endured. "I wish I'd met you sooner."

A small chuckle escapes my lips as I lean down and gently press a kiss to the top of her head. "You're seven years older than me, Carrie. Too much sooner, and it would have been a crime."

We dissolve into laughter and spend the rest of the morning in bed, hiding beneath the covers and talking about all the dreams that are going to come true now that she's free of her husband.

Chapter 48

Carrie

A few days later, the consequences of my actions show up at my front door. As I'm looking through the classifieds and trying to figure out what my next step is, the doorbell rings. A gentle chime echoes through the house, causing tension to electrify my chest with discomfort. The clock in the living room says 9:35; I am not expecting anyone.

I set my laptop down and get to my feet. As I approach the door, my eyes catch a glimpse of Nora through the transparent glass panes. Seeing her standing there, poised and professional, makes my stomach clench with anxiety. Her dark hair is pinned up neatly, and her crisp suit hugs her figure perfectly, exuding an air of confidence.

My hand shakes slightly as I reach for the doorknob, and I silence the little voice in my head begging me not to answer. "Nora, hi. I didn't know—"

She cuts me off before I finish speaking. "Malcolm sent me. He has no desire to come back here," she says with a sneer as she looks me up and down. The disdain in her voice is palpable. "I'm to collect some things and sticker others that will need to be taken by a mover later this week. He'll be getting out of the hospital tomorrow *if* you care." Nora's dismissive tone cuts me to the bone.

"I care about Malcolm's health and well-being," I remind her as she brushes past me. "I'm glad he's doing better and will be able to finish recovering from home. However, he and I are no longer—"

"Together," Nora finishes for me. "Yes, he told me. Something about how you agreed to an open marriage and then decided to run off with the first man that would have you."

My mouth falls open, lips parting in disbelief. "Is-is that what Malcolm told you? That we had an open marriage?"

She rolls her eyes at me before heading upstairs. I follow closely behind as she gives me a scornful rundown of what she's been told about my relationship with my husband. Her words drip with judgment and disdain, making me feel small. "I've always known about your open marriage. Malcolm told me that you struggled to find other partners who felt comfortable engaging in a sexual relationship with you. He said you've always been a little needy, which was off-putting to other men in that lifestyle."

She takes the words right out of my mouth, leaving me speechless. I don't know how to respond. What I thought was the perfect marriage has been shattered by my husband's lies. Not only has he twisted the truth about our supposed open relationship, but he's also painted me as the needy and desperate problem that led to our ending.

"It's fine," Nora sighs when I don't immediately respond. "But I can see why he wants a divorce. You didn't have to send someone to beat him up, though. Your little thug boyfriend or whatever left him for dead in his office. Malcolm is going to have PTSD when he returns to work."

Nora's words hit me like a ton of bricks, leaving me stunned and paralyzed at the top of the stairs. I can't bring myself to follow her into the bedroom, my legs feeling like lead as I process the shocking truth of Malcolm's lies. He has spun the story to feed his ego, but worse still, he is pinning all responsibility on me for his hospitalization. My blood boils with anger and betrayal, my mind reeling as I struggle to comprehend how someone I trusted could do something so heinous.

"Where's Malcolm's clothes?" Nora emerges from my bedroom with her hands planted on her hips in a stance of authority. Her

lips purse into a slight frown as she says, “I was told they’d be in his closet, but Malcolm does not wear flannel or polyester.”

I point to a closed door down the hallway. “I moved his things,” is all I can manage.

Nora continues her mission, and the sound of hangers being taken off the rack quickly follows. While she works, she mumbles under her breath. I can’t make out what she says, but I know it’s disparaging.

My heart pounds in my chest as I am consumed by a fierce determination to set the record straight. Nora’s callousness sparks a fire inside me. She needs to know the truth, and I’ll stop at nothing to make sure she understands I’m innocent.

I burst into the spare bedroom, a lifetime of insecurity and abuse fueling my rage. “Listen here, Nora. You can take his clothes, put stickers on all the furniture, hell, you can kick me out of this house if you want. But don’t you dare blame me for what happened to Malcolm.”

“He said you’d—”

“No.” I cut her off with a satisfied smirk. A rush of power surges through me when her teeth snap together in a futile attempt to contain her annoyance. “Malcolm and I have *never* been in an open marriage. He was cheating on me with several women *at the same time*, but I didn’t know that until a few months ago.” Nora’s face softens a fraction of a percent. “But he’s in the hospital because he made a move on my daughter, and his son, his own flesh and blood, kicked his ass because of it. And the fact that he made a move on my daughter is the reason we’re getting divorced. Not the infidelity, which is reason enough. Not that he made me feel unsafe in my own home, though God knows that happened on more than one occasion. But because he threatened the person who means the most to me. So take whatever you want for your boss, but don’t get it twisted. Malcolm brought this all on himself.”

Nora’s expression remains unchanged, not a hint of emotion showing on her face. The wrinkles around her mouth have softened slightly, but the rest of her features remain rigid and unmoving, like a carved stone statue. “You’re only saying this because you know we’re in love,” she accuses. “Malcolm would never do any of that.”

As I suspected, Nora was never *just* my personal assistant; she is another one of Malcolm’s playthings. I hope she knows what she’s getting herself into. “You can have him, Nora. I don’t want him anymore.”

I am forced to accept the heartbreaking reality that the truth may never see the light of day. Malcolm McCade is a powerful man, his family’s name etched in gold at the top of every social ladder. He revels in his wealth, using it to manipulate and deceive with ease. He twists the truth to fit his needs, molding it like clay into whatever facade he desires. I am his victim, no better than Victoria. I should have known from the moment I met him that he was bad for me, but karma got me in the end. I broke up a marriage, and in return, mine was broken, too.

I can’t say I’m upset about what happened, but I won’t lose another night of sleep over it.

Chapter 49

Jackson

As the holidays roll around, I feel like I'm spending less time at my apartment in Rosedale and more time in Manhattan with Carrie. I don't mind because sleeping beside her at night has given me a renewed sense of hope when I wake up in the morning. However, we are careening toward the truth coming out about my relation to her and Malcolm.

I've luckily avoided my father since our run-in at the hospital. Carrie told me about her assistant dropping by to pick up Malcolm's things, and she mentioned a civil servant who served her with divorce papers a few days later. But my father hasn't attempted to visit me, and as far as I know, he hasn't tried to see his wife, either.

Carrie wants to invite her daughter over for dinner and tell her about the divorce and our relationship. But Kaye calls a couple of hours before she's supposed to arrive and asks if her best friend, Christine, can come.

"This isn't a good idea," Carrie stresses as she prepares dinner. "I should have said no. I need to tell Kaye about us."

"And you and Malcolm," I remind her.

Her lips form a small, uncertain smile before she nods her head. "Yes, she needs to know that Malcolm and I getting divorced, too." It's clear that her main concern isn't breaking the news of her split from Malcolm but rather the potential fallout that might come if her daughter discovers our secret relationship.

I wish I could comfort her, but she shrugs me off whenever I offer to take something off her plate or help her with dinner. When Kaye and Christine show up, she whisper-yells, "What do I do?"

I know she's been growing stronger since her separation from Malcolm, but this is one of those moments where she needs to borrow strength from someone else. Where her husband might have chastised her for panicking, I quietly pick up the mantle and take on her struggle.

"I'll take care of it." I lean in gently to press a soft kiss to her lips in an effort to calm her nerves. "I'll greet them. We'll tell Kaye that I'm your friend. We don't have to tell her the truth tonight."

As soon as I step into the grand foyer, my eyes immediately catch sight of Kaye. She is a dark version of her mother's ethereal, light beauty. Her red-headed friend isn't bad-looking, either; Pierce would like her. I make a mental note to introduce them when we get to know each other better.

"Hey," the corners of my lips turn up into a warm, welcoming smile as I extend my hand in greeting, "Kaye and Christine, right?"

Christine glides towards me with poise and grace, her hand outstretched in a gesture of greeting. Confidence radiates off her. "You know my name, but I don't know yours. Handsome, maybe?" She bats her eyelashes at me. "Gorgeous?"

In the back, Kaye bites her lip to keep from laughing, and I have to do the same. The age difference between Christine and me is the same as the age difference between Carrie and me, but I can't imagine dating an eighteen-year-old. She's pretty, but she's too young. And she isn't Carrie. "I'm Jackson, a friend of Carrie's. She's in the kitchen."

Kaye is probably more familiar with the McCade mansion than I am, but I lead her and Christine to the kitchen anyway. The girls are nice enough, but Carrie's daughter seems taken aback by my presence. Her eyes dart around nervously as if she's sizing me up.

As we enter the kitchen, Carrie is leaning over the oven, her hands covered in oven mitts as she checks on the lasagna. She straightens up with a casual smile, the corners of her apron tied neatly behind her back. The smell of garlic and tomato sauce fills the air, making our mouths water with hunger. Carrie's blonde hair is pulled back into a messy bun, strands escaping and framing her face. Her eyes sparkle as she greets us, wiping her hands on a dish towel. "Kaye! Chris! I see you've met Jackson."

"We've only made introductions," I tell with a subtle yet confident nod. Our eyes meet, and my gaze says it all: I am here for you, and I will not betray your trust. I understand she may not be prepared for her daughter to learn about our relationship under these circumstances, and I will not pressure her to reveal anything before she is ready.

Kaye shatters the silence by clearing her throat. Her sudden interruption brings our attention back to reality. "So, Jackson. How do you know my mother?"

I break eye contact with Carrie and smile politely at her daughter. "We met at a charity event a couple of months ago. It was for education in underserved communities and disadvantaged children in need."

She narrows her eyes at me in disbelief. "Really? And what is it that you do?" Kaye is the distrusting type. Carrie told me all about the men she's brought home over the years and how her behavior might have skewed her daughter's perception of men.

There's nothing I can do besides hold onto the hope that Kaye eventually comes around to liking me. "I work in Acquisitions at the McCade Library. I think you're familiar with it?" I ask. "Your mom mentioned you're a student at Blackmore."

Kaye's eyebrow rises slightly, her expression remaining impassive. "Interesting. And how does that correlate to the education of children in need?"

Carrie gives her daughter a pointed look. Her lips press into a thin line of disapproval. "Kaye, don't harass the poor man," she says nervously. As her eyes dart to me, I glimpse an unspoken apology hidden within their depths.

I can see why she is nervous about telling Kaye about our budding relationship. But I wink at Carrie, determined to ease the burden of this evening. "Be nice, Carrie. She's just curious."

As I turn my attention to Kaye, she looks even more annoyed at my presence. "The McCade Library has a lot of programs that support the local youth. Including career planning, traditional and digital literacy, STEM workshops, and even a program for BU students to earn internship experience by working at secondary education facilities."

Christine, who's been eating from the vegetable tray for the duration of the conversation, lets out a low whistle of appreciation. "He sounds really impressive, Kaye," she announces in a whisper meant to be loud enough for us all to hear.

However, Kaye does not look impressed, and it only upsets her mother. Carrie claps her hands together after a moment and says, "Well, dinner is almost ready. I just need to pull the lasagna out and get it on the table. Kaye, honey, why don't you grab water for everyone?"

I could use a beer and a shot of whiskey to get through tonight, but I settle for a glass of wine.

Dinner doesn't go any better than our initial encounter. Kaye glowers at me from across the table while Christine makes idle banter. By the time our plates are cleared, I'm wagering with God. *If you get me out of this, I'll apologize to Malcolm. I'll fight a bear if you end this dinner right now.* I'm willing to do almost anything to avoid sitting across from Carrie's daughter while she secretly judges me in the privacy of her own thoughts.

I was never good at handling teenage girls, even when I was a teenage boy. Kaye makes me feel uncomfortable and unsure of myself.

As dinner comes to an end, Carrie gives me a pleading look. I catch on quickly and ask Christine to give me a tour of the garden. Luckily, the red-headed beauty is more than happy to oblige my request.

Chapter 50

Carrie

I wish I could have talked more during dinner, but I'm more afraid of my daughter than I ever was of Malcolm. I wanted to leave him, which sounded scary to say out loud, but in the end, he wouldn't be around to say anything about it. Kaye will be around until the day I die, and I'm afraid she'll judge me for what has happened between Jackson and me. I'm also scared to tell her about my relationship with Malcolm. I'm worried she'll look at me dumbfounded and ask how I didn't learn from my mistakes when I was married to Owen.

As Jackson and Christine casually get up from the table, leaving me with my daughter, I follow suit and finish off the glass of wine in front of me. "Honey, do you want to grab the salad?" My voice sounds sharp and metallic, like the clang of a bell, but if I don't do something with my hands, they will start shaking.

I head to the kitchen with the plates, and Kaye follows closely behind. "Who is that kid, and why is he here?" She asks with a glare.

My laughter rings out a little too loudly as I wave off her question with an exaggerated motion. "Honey, *please*, he isn't a kid. He's older than you."

"And he's *younger* than you," she replies quickly.

I allow her that point; Jackson sits perfectly between us in age. "Yes, true. He's twenty-five." He's closer to my age than Malcolm was, but Kaye never mentioned the age difference when we were dating.

"Is he trying to get more money out of the McCades?" Kaye asks after a moment. "Because I'll tell him to leave, Mom. Just say the word, and Christine and I will make sure he never bothers you again."

I snort at her, amused that she thinks she and Christine could remove Jackson from the house. I've been trying to get rid of him since we first met, and I've failed at every turn. Granted, I wasn't very serious about telling him to back off because he saw right through me.

I bag up leftovers for Kaye and Christine. I've never been to college, but they don't have many home-cooked meals in their dorm. "Do you and Chris want any garlic bread?" I frown, staring at the half-finished loaf. "I don't know if it'll reheat in a microwave well, but if you want it, I'll pack some up."

"Mom," Kaye says in an exasperated tone, "you invited me to dinner to talk. Then, you didn't tell me you were going to have a guest until I asked if I could bring Christine. What's going on?"

The spatula in my hands still floats in midair, and I feel the weight of her words hit me like a ton of bricks. If I don't tell her something, she'll keep rooting until she gets it out of me. So I give her a crumb, a piece of the truth that needs to be told anyway: "I'm leaving Malcolm."

Kaye waits a beat before asking, "Are you leaving him for Jackson?"

Not exactly, I think to myself. If Jackson hadn't shown up, would I be divorcing my husband? Maybe, maybe not. Jackson showed me the rifts in my marriage, but ultimately, my husband's decision to pursue my daughter forced my hand. I might have stayed in a bad marriage for a few more years if Malcolm hadn't tried to hurt the only person who meant anything to me.

"No," I tell her honestly. "Jackson and I met at the fundraiser, and then I ran into him several times after." Each of those events

had been meticulously planned and orchestrated by either myself or Jackson. “It was a coincidence, really, but the more we talked, the more I realized that I wasn’t happy. He’s become one of my closest friends, Kaye.” Friend, lover, live-in boyfriend, security guard... it’s all part of one long title that encompasses all the aspects of our relationship.

“And you don’t think it’s *weird* that he works at the McCade Library? You don’t think he’s trying to use you for money?”

I whirl around to respond with a breezy laugh, but midway through, I realize she might be onto something. Jackson’s never asked me for money; he’s never asked for anything except to *be with* me. However, it’s weird that our paths have crossed so much over the years without either of us realizing it. He used to work for Malcolm; now, he works at the campus my daughter attends, in the library named after my husband’s family. But maybe that’s just a coincidence...

No, don’t think like that, the little voice in my head scolds. He used to attend Blackmore University, where he earned a degree in library science. It makes sense that he works at the McCade Library. There’s nothing weird about a series of coincidences.

But my nerves get the best of me. “Yes, we talked about the McCades a lot when we first became friends.” What else do two people talk about when one of them is married and the other is blatantly pursuing her regardless? “He seemed to have an interest in Malcolm and Xavier, and I thought the same thing, that maybe he was just interested in the family’s money.” Or at least that’s what I’m thinking now. I recall our text messages and chats about my husband and stepson; none seemed particularly predatory. “But Malcolm isn’t involved with the library; he doesn’t even sit on the Board,” I say more to myself than my daughter. “There’s no money to be gained by being my friend, Kaye.” Not anymore. “Jackson is a good man, and he’s helping me through a tough situation. That’s all.”

And as I say it, I believe it. I’ve made bad choices in the past, but Jackson isn’t one of them. He is the antithesis of all the men I’ve chosen before him.

After a minute, Kaye warns me to be cautious. “I just think you should be careful around him. Men can be gold diggers, too.”

They can, but not Jackson. I know in my bones that the only thing he wants is to spend the rest of his life with me, with or without the McCade family money.

Chapter 51

Jackson

After Kaye leaves our disastrous holiday dinner, Carrie and I curl up in bed and recount our experiences with one another. She tells me that her daughter thinks I'm a gold digger. I tell her that Christine hit on me and I might have hurt her feelings when I turned her down. We both laugh, even though it's not all that funny.

"I'm going to see my mom in a few days," I warn her. "I'm going to tell her about you and me."

Carrie sucks in a breath, holding it so long that I start to worry about her. Then she sighs heavily and asks, "Do you think she'll like me?"

I haven't introduced a girl to my mother since I was in high school. No one in college warranted the honor, and afterward, I was too engrossed in seeking revenge to date seriously. My ex, Paula, came close, but my friends were right: she was a little crazy.

"I don't know," I admit. "The last girl I introduced my mother to was someone I started dating in my first year of high school. We were off and on for a while, and by the time we finally called it quits, my mother said not to bring her back unless there was a ring on her finger."

I pause for a minute to think about my mother. Not a day has passed that she hasn't loved and supported my decisions, even when they were stupid. But I never told Elaine about my plans for Malcolm; I was afraid she'd try to convince me to forgive him. Even when I lied to her about why I no longer had student loans and didn't have to do work-study anymore, she didn't ask any questions because she had always trusted me.

"She'll love you because I love you," I tell Carrie after a long minute.

But I'm nervous. Because eventually, the truth will come out, and I don't know how Elaine or Carrie will take it.



My mother is a nurse, and she works nearly every holiday. One year, when I was nine, she had Thanksgiving off. I haven't spent a federal holiday with her since.

While banks, libraries, and most grocery stores close, hospitals do not. A lot of people stroke out after a big holiday meal or succumb to heart attacks when arguing with relatives about politics, religion, and new relationships. Elaine tries her best to leave the holidays to parents with younger children, a luxury she couldn't afford when she was the parent of a younger child. It's her way of giving back—as if being a nurse isn't giving enough back to the sick, wounded, and injured.

We have our version of Thanksgiving dinner a few days after my encounter with Carrie's daughter. I arrive with a bouquet of flowers while my mom is in the end stages of preparing a feast. She tells me to relax in the living room, which I do for five minutes before she announces she's finished.

"Everything is ready, Jack!" Elaine calls from the kitchen. "Come light the candles on the table!"

I oblige her request, swiftly making my way from the cozy living room to the kitchen. "It smells wonderful, ma."

She tosses a smile over her shoulder as she gives the mashed potatoes another stir. "I know, baby. Did you make a turkey for

Thanksgiving? You said you spent it with friends,” Elaine trails off, trying to lead me into an early confession.

I indulge her because it’s going to come out whether I tell her now or fib and wait until dinner is over. “I spent it with my girlfriend,” I explain. “Her daughter was there as well.” She doesn’t need to know about Christine.

My mother brings the bowl of mashed potatoes over to the table. The aroma of butter and garlic fills the air, making my stomach growl in anticipation. She gives me a pointed look, her eyebrow stretched to her hairline. “She has a daughter?” Her voice carries no hint of judgment despite the look on her face.

“Yeah. Actually, her daughter is eighteen.”

Now, there’s judgment—in her eyes, on her face, and in the words she speaks. “How old is this woman you’re dating, Jackson? My goodness. Her daughter is old enough to date you!”

I could never date someone as young as Kaye; we wouldn’t have anything in common. “I know, ma,” I say in an effort to calm her down. “But it isn’t like that. She’s thirty-two. She had her daughter when she was fourteen, and she’s done a remarkable job of turning her life around.” Then, I showed up to ruin her progress. I shouldn’t be concerned that my mom won’t like Carrie; I should be worried that she won’t like *me* when she finds out what I’ve done to sabotage Carrie’s marriage.

Elaine withholds her judgment long enough to grab the turkey from the oven and place it in the center of the table. “Carve that,” she orders.

I diligently obey. It’s a habit to walk to the drawer near the stove and find the carving knife. My feet carry me there, and second nature brings me back. I absentmindedly start carving the bird when my mother asks how I met my girlfriend. “At a charity gala. I told you about it. It was a couple of months ago, at the end of August, I think.”

She continues to bring side dishes and silverware to the table while I work. “She’s a rich girl, eh?”

“Yes, kind of.” Carrie has alluded to a windfall of money coming her way from a prenup she signed with Malcolm. “But I’m not after her for the money, ma. I make enough to pay the bills and save up for a rainy day.”

As the final dishes are placed on the table and the turkey is carved, Elaine gracefully takes the seat across from me. Her features are sharp yet delicate, her eyes filled with a hint of skepticism. “Are you serious about this girl, Jack? This is the first I’m hearing of her.”

I begin filling my plate, avoiding eye contact with my mother. “Our relationship is new, but I’m very serious about her. I think she’s the one, ma.”

Elaine gives me a funny look before she starts to dish up a plate of food for herself. I respectfully allow her to lead our conversation. But as she starts to eat, each bite is accompanied by a jarring clink as her fork slams against the delicate porcelain.

“Say something, ma.”

The fork scrapes loudly against the fine China in response. “What is there to say?” She asks. “I knew this day would come, but I didn’t realize it would come so soon. You’re my baby,” Elaine pleads. “My only child.”

A wave of guilt hits me square in the chest. It dawns on me that she isn’t angry about who I’m dating, but rather the fact that she’s slowly losing her son. Her anger is a mix of love and fear for what our relationship will become now that I’ve found someone else.

“I’ll always be your baby,” I quietly respond. Even when I am fully grown and think I know everything, I will still need her love and guidance. “Ma, no one will ever take your place in my life. Not Carrie, not any other woman, no one. You are my mother and a special place in my heart, and my life will only ever exist for you.”

With a gentle movement, I reach across the table and take her hand in mine. “I’ll bring her by soon. You’re going to love her.”

A stray tear crawls down her face in slow motion, and she hastily wipes it away before any others can follow. “I’ll love her because I love *you*, Jackson.”

I knew that was how she would respond. And I’m grateful to have a mother who loves and trusts me unconditionally, even when I know deep down that I don’t deserve it. I hope she’ll still feel this way when she finds out how I manipulated Carrie into leaving her husband for me.

Chapter 52

Carrie

My stomach churns like a ship on uneasy water. Tonight, I am meeting Jackson's mother, and despite his reassurances that she will adore me, I can't help but feel like a nervous teenager going to meet her boyfriend's parents for the first time. Which is an accurate assessment, but I'm not a teenager anymore.

I asked Jackson about his father again last night. After he and Elaine met for a belated Thanksgiving, he said he wanted to give her a few days to process everything before we met for the first time. In my nervousness, I asked about his other parent.

"We don't have a relationship," Jackson replied tersely. It was a little off-putting at first because he sounded annoyed with me. But a few hours later, he apologized. "It's not your fault for asking; you didn't know. My father wasn't around when I was a kid because he found out my mother was pregnant; he wanted nothing to do with either of us. It's a touchy subject because when I approached him a few years ago, he made it clear he wished I'd never been born."

I was fortunate enough to grow up in a loving household with parents who supported and cherished me through every obstacle, even when I got pregnant at fourteen. The thought of being rejected by one's parents is unfathomable. I decided not to push the issue any further with Jackson. Some things are better left unsaid, and some wounds are better left unexplored.

Then, this morning, while we were eating breakfast, Jackson asked if I wanted to meet his mother. My heart skipped a beat at the unexpected invitation, and without hesitation, I eagerly agreed. Jackson kissed me on the cheek and said he needed to get some things from his apartment for work the following week. "It'll only be a couple of hours," he insisted as he was on his way out. The thought of meeting his mother filled me with both excitement and nerves, and I anxiously cleaned the house while I awaited his return.

Living with Jackson almost full-time has been a night and day difference from living with Malcolm. He makes me breakfast when he gets up in the morning, even when I tell him I can do it myself. There isn't a day that goes by where he doesn't kiss me before he leaves. And he always tells me he loves me. Like a man grasping for a buoy, he holds onto those words like a lifeline. Jackson repeats them to me morning, noon, and night. And it is such a stark difference from the way my husband treated me that I fear I may wither away and die if Jackson ever stops.

"Would she like my hair up or down?" I ask my reflection.

Does it matter? The little voice in my head replies nastily. *You're still the older woman stealing her baby boy. She won't like you at all.*

The voice's words sting, perhaps because they vocalize my deepest insecurities. The little voice says that I am not good enough for Jackson because he's twenty-five and fresh, and I'm thirty-two and used. It reminds me that as I've aged, I've become more cynical of my self-image instead of embracing myself as I am.

I leave my hair down, flattening it into submission. Then, I apply the lightest layer of makeup as I remind myself that I do not have to look perfect for Jackson. Malcolm always wanted me to be pristine and blemish-free, but Jackson is not my former husband. He loves me as I am. "Therefore, his mother will love me," I mumble to my reflection.

This time, the little voice says nothing.

My phone begins to vibrate, jolting me out of my thoughts. The bright screen displays Jackson's name in bold letters as if he somehow sensed I was thinking of him. A smile tugs at the corners of my mouth as I eagerly answer the call, feeling a sense of peace as I hear his voice on the other end.

“Hey, gorgeous,” Jackson greets. “Is it okay if we meet at my mom’s place?”

Anxiety springs up uninvited and unwelcome. “I-well, yes,” I stutter. “That’s fine.”

Noticing the hesitation in my tone, Jackson quickly reassures me. “Something unexpected happened at my apartment, and I need to take care of some things before dinner.”

“Oh?” I ask, fishing for answers. “What happened?”

Jackson pauses for a beat, and I know he’s trying to decide whether or not to tell me what happened. In the end, he says, “My brother showed up.”

Chapter 53

Jackson

My apartment has become a collection of things I no longer use. I've moved most of my wardrobe and everyday use items to Carrie's, leaving my apartment feeling barren and empty. But occasionally, I remember something I left behind, and I have to swing by to pick it up.

I need to refer to a notebook in my spare bedroom closet with details about an upcoming work function. It was something I learned during one of my college classes I thought I'd never use. But in a meeting last week, my boss asked an off-handed question that reminded me of that long-forgotten lesson. My brain conjured up a vivid image of the dark green notebook nestled at the bottom of a cardboard box. The thought consumed me all night until I decided to drive back to my apartment in Rosedale and pick it up.

More than coincidence, it is fate that brought me here. I've spent so much of the last few weeks at Carrie's that I've missed mail and forgotten bills because I didn't come by for days at a time. So it must be destiny when someone knocks on the door as I'm burrowing through old notes. It's luck that I'm here at all; it's the cosmos aligning for divine intervention.

I leave my mess of notebooks scattered on the floor as I rush to answer the door. But when I swing it open, my breath catches in my throat as I'm met with an unexpected sight: my half-brother, Xavier McCade.

He is the perfect amalgamation of Malcolm and Victoria. He has his father's sturdy build but his mother's delicate bone structure. He has Malcolm's dark brilliance and Victoria's quiet intensity.

It makes me smile to see him here, on my doorstep, as if he found me by chance. After I met with Kaye, I knew it was only a matter of time before someone found out about my connection to Malcolm. I honestly thought it'd be sooner.

"Well, well, if it isn't Xavier McCade finally gracing me with his presence. It's about damn time. Given what Carrie told me about you, I expected you to be here weeks ago. I was starting to think you'd never work up the nerve to confront me."

Without warning, Xavier clenches his fist tightly before beginning to swing wildly. His first punch connects with a loud crack against my cheek. The force of the blow sends me stumbling backward, crashing through my apartment door and catching myself on the couch. I reach up to touch the aching spot on my lip where his knuckles collided, and my hand comes back tinged with blood. "You son of a bitch," I glare. Maybe I should have started with hello.

"Stay the hell away from Carrie and Kaye," Xavier instructs. "I don't know what you think you're doing, but it stops now—seeing Carrie, worming your way into her life, pretending to be the caring best friend. Blah, blah, blah. Stop." He cracks his knuckles, a menacing warning meant to keep me in line. But I am not afraid of my brother; his attempts to intimidate me won't work. "You leave them both alone, or next time, a little tap on the jaw won't be the only thing you'll have to worry about."

"That's rich, coming from you," I laugh for a second before beginning to cough, then I straighten my posture and rise to meet him eye-to-eye. "How long have you been stalking your stepsister, Xavier?"

I vividly recall what he did to our father. I saw Malcolm in his hospital bed, beaten black and blue and wrapped in bandages because of his son's actions. I know I should be afraid of him, but whether he knows it or not, Xavier and I are on the same team. "Don't worry. I don't want Kaye. She's cute, but pursuing her is a waste of my time. Carrie, on the other hand, Carrie's been lonely for a long time. Her husband was more interested in her daughter than her. That hurts, you know. It's enough to make a woman seek out the attention of another man."

Malcolm. His name ignites a fire in my chest, searing and unrelenting. He is the root of all our chaos and turmoil, a dark storm

cloud that looms over us. The very thought of him fuels a burning rage within me, twisting my gut and suffocating me with fury.

“If you want to blackmail our father, you go right ahead.” Xavier clenches his jaw and fists simultaneously. “I don’t give a shit what you do to Malcolm. But leave the Penningtons alone.”

He gets it, but he doesn’t. He understands, but he doesn’t. “Malcolm abandoned his wife for greener pastures, and he did it because of *you*. If anyone should stay away from Carrie, I think we both know who it is. So, how about *you* worry about *your* love life and let *me* worry about *mine*?”

Xavier shakes his head. “Fuck you, Jackson.”

“I’m only interested in fucking Carrie, but thanks.” One of these days, I’ll tell him the truth, and he’ll understand me better than anyone. No one could hate Malcolm McCade any more than his own sons, except maybe the women he’s targeted and pursued. “It’s only a matter of time before the divorce is finalized,” I announce. If he didn’t know about Malcolm and Carrie’s separation before, he does now. “Then I can have Carrie all to myself. She’s half in love with me already. I make her feel like she can do anything,” I taunt him.

I should be nicer to Xavier because he had to grow up with Malcolm. I’ve known all my life that my father didn’t want me, but at least I didn’t know him personally.

Xavier grew up with Malcolm and probably felt the same way I did, but his father was right there. He was raised with all the wealth a boy could want but not a shred of love. I didn’t have wealth, but I had love from a mother who would have set the world on fire to ensure I was safe and happy.

I should pity him, but I don’t.

“Face it, Xavier, Carrie trusts me. She *confides* in me; she tells me her hopes and dreams.” Though it took me longer than I’d like to get to this point. “She leans on me when she’s having a bad day. Actually, she was with me the day you fucked up Malcolm. Which, by the way,” I pause, “I just want to say that I’m glad you didn’t kill him. Since half the fun will be watching Malcolm accept that *his wife* left him for *his son*, I’m glad he isn’t dead. That would ruin all the hard work I put into this plan.”

This is a meticulously crafted, long con designed to deceive and manipulate. It has been in the works for years, with countless failed attempts along the way. But now, after enduring setback after setback, it is finally coming to fruition in a triumphant wave of success.

“You’re a sick man, Jackson,” Xavier replies coldly.

“No.” My features harden beneath his gaze. “*You’re* a sick man. Who obsesses over their stepsister?”

“Who obsesses over their father’s wife?” He snaps back.

I laugh wildly, feeling out of control, and then I step forward to grab the edge of the door frame. “Guess we’re more alike than you thought, eh, brother?”

As I look at Xavier, his face remains stoic, showing no hint of emotion. He doesn’t even bother to give me the courtesy of a response; instead, he turns his back and walks away. His strides are long and purposeful, leaving me standing there alone.

One of these days, I’ll make him understand, and he will appreciate what I’ve done for him. Xavier has been slowly chipping away at Malcolm’s family’s legacy, destroying it bit by bit from within. But my accomplishment is truly remarkable—I succeeded in tearing down my father’s empire from the outside.

In no time at all, Malcolm will be alone. No sons. No wives. Nothing but a bank account full of money and no one to love him.

Chapter 54

Carrie

I count the members of Jackson's family again.

His mother's name is Elaine. She's a nurse who lives in Manhattan. Their bond is unshakeable, forged from years of relying solely on each other.

Jackson's father has never been in the picture. He never talks about the man, nor has he told me who he is.

And now he has a brother. On which side of the family? I don't know. He told me he was an only child, but that's not what he said when we were on the phone earlier.

Why would Jackson lie to me?

Why would Jackson lie to me?

Why would Jackson lie to me?

It is a constant refrain that plagues me from my home to Elaine Reid's. The familiar taste of nervousness lingers in my mouth, a bitter reminder of what's waiting. Meeting Jackson's mother is nerve-wracking enough, but now there's a mystery brother for me to worry about. Why didn't he tell me about his brother before?

As I round the corner and pull up to Elaine's pristine white house, relief floods through me as I see Jackson's truck parked in the driveway. He stands tall and lean, his muscular frame leaning casually against the driver's side door. As I park, he pushes off in a single fluid motion and closes the distance between us with confident strides. His eyes meet mine, and a small smile tugs at the corner of his lips.

As I emerge from my car, I catch a glimpse of Jackson's swollen lip. He must be self-conscious about it because he immediately reassures me, "It isn't that bad." The corner of his mouth is red and slightly puffy, indicating a recent injury. Despite his attempt to make light of it, I can tell it's bothering him.

"Jesus, Jackson. What happened?"

He nonchalantly raises his hand to touch the tender, swollen area next to his mouth before casually shrugging his shoulders. "Nothing crazy. I got into a little fistfight. It was just the one punch. I'm fine."

I don't believe him; men downplay everything. "You said your brother showed up. Did he do this to you?"

My hand trembles as I reach up to touch the raised bump above Jackson's jaw. But before I can make contact, he swiftly grabs my hand and brings it to his lips, tenderly pressing a kiss against my skin. His hot breath tickles my fingers as he holds them gently. "Shhh, love. I'll tell you about the brother thing later. I don't want to worry my mom."

Oh, god. How dark and scary is the secret if his mother doesn't know about it? "Jackson, this is weird. What's going on?"

He tugs me across the lawn toward the front door, ignoring my question. "Ma had a shift last night, so she might be a little tired, but she'll do her best. I've never known her to be anything less than the hostess with the mostess."

My guilt shifts from the bruise forming above his chin to the weight I suddenly feel on my shoulders. I don't want to be a burden to his mother. I know what it's like to be exhausted after a long shift; I don't want her to have to cook for us if she's tired. "We can reschedule. We don't have to do this tonight. It can wait, Jackson," I offer.

“No,” he replies firmly. “She is expecting us.”

As if on cue, Elaine opens the front door with a wide grin, her face radiating warmth and joy. But as her gaze falls upon me and her son, her expression quickly shifts. A look of alarm crosses her features as she takes in his injuries. “Jackson Daniel Reid,” she says his name like an obscenity. “What kind of trouble did you get into this time?”

“That’s what I wanted to know,” I mumble under my breath.

“See?” She gestures to me and then to Jackson. “You worry your girlfriend *and* your mother. What did you do?”

Jackson slowly lets go of my hand, his fingers lingering for a moment before he turns to embrace his mother. His arms wrap around her in a tight hug, and I can see the love and adoration in his eyes as he presses a gentle kiss to each of her cheeks. The warmth between them is palpable, filling the air with a sense of familial love and affection. “It was a little misunderstanding, ma. Don’t worry.”

Elaine gives me a mother’s look, her perfectly arched eyebrow raised in disdain and disbelief at her son’s reassurance. The subtle twitch of her lips reveals her disapproval as she sizes me up with a critical eye. “*Don’t worry*, he says. Just like a son to think his mother won’t worry when he shows up with a busted lip. You have a daughter, right?”

“Yes, thank God,” I announce with a sigh of relief. “I don’t think I would have made it through the teen years if she were like him.” It’s the perfect thing to say, and we bond immediately.

Elaine Reid, with her soft brown eyes and infectious smile, is every bit as charming as her son. At another time, in another place, we might have become friends at the playground or taken our children on play dates together.

With a welcoming gesture, she ushers us inside and immediately begins to regale me with stories and embarrassing photos of Jackson. Each image is a snapshot of his journey from mischievous kindergartener to wild college student. She paints a vivid oral history with animated gestures and laughter, inviting me into their world of inside jokes and anecdotes. The room feels cozy, filled with the warmth of family and memories. “He was a good kid; only broke his arm three times,” she says with a wink and a hint of playful disrespect in her tone.

With a satisfied sigh, Jackson collapses onto the plush couch and stretches his legs out, resting them on the smooth surface of the coffee table. “Don’t neglect to tell her that one of those times was from a car accident where *you* were driving.”

Elaine snorts. “Yes, *I* was driving when someone rear-ended us going 40 mph. I should have seen that coming and told you to wear your seatbelt. *Again*,” she emphasizes. “Because you didn’t listen to me the first time.”

“Okay, that’s not fair,” Jackson rolls his eyes. “I was twelve. How are you going to hold me accountable for my actions at such a young age?”

“You’re lucky you didn’t have boys. This one is a handful,” Elaine reiterates with a wink.

We stroll into the kitchen where she’s set the table for three. Her home is larger than the one Kaye, and I had before Malcolm came into our lives but much smaller than the one I occupy now with her son. Still, she adorns the table with a fresh flower centerpiece and tea lights.

“Kaye wasn’t quite the handful as a child as I imagine Jackson must have been, but she had to have her tonsils and appendix removed in the same year. I remember wanting to put her in a bubble so she couldn’t get hurt again, and she didn’t even break anything. A sprained wrist, once, because she fell off her bike in the sixth grade, but that was it.”

I notice Jackson watching the two of us with a smile. I bump into his hip with mine and whisper, “What are you so happy about?”

He chuckles softly, flashing me a mega-watt grin. “Nothing, everything,” he shrugs. “This is going better than I expected it to.”

Chapter 55

Jackson

“Tell me about yourself.” My mother grasps the slender stem of her wine glass, her fingers tracing its curves. She brings it to her lips in a single graceful motion, leaving a print of coral pink lipstick on the rim. “Jackson has been very sparse with details.”

I roll my eyes and wave off my mother’s accusation with a dramatic flourish. “She doesn’t want the third degree, mother. She’s just here for dinner.”

Elaine makes a gesture of disdain. “I haven’t asked any questions, honey.”

I feel uneasy and exposed; there are some secrets that I’m not ready for my mother to find out about. But Carrie exudes a sense of ease and confidence and responds with practiced grace, carefully choosing her words and hiding any hint of vulnerability. “It’s okay, Jackson. She can ask all the questions she wants. I would be worried if Kaye brought home a man with an eighteen-year-old son.”

My mother gives me a knowing look and a wink. “She’s a smart one, Jackson.”

“My daughter was an accident, but a much-loved accident. I was fourteen when I fell for her father, but we were careless. The kind of kids who thought getting pregnant couldn’t happen to us.” Carrie swallows hard, the lump in her throat bobbing as she chokes back emotion. But she takes a deep breath and wills herself to remain composed. “Unfortunately, Franklin passed when I was nineteen. A drunk driver ran a red light,” she trails off.

Elaine’s eyes widen in astonishment as the story unfolds, her mouth falling slightly agape before she quickly covers it with her hand. “I’m so sorry, Carrie. That’s horrible.”

Carrie’s lips turn upwards in a faint smile, but it doesn’t reach her eyes. “It was certainly unexpected, but I think much of life is. If we knew exactly how it was supposed to go from beginning to end, it would be a sad, boring affair. Don’t you think?”

“Very true, my dear,” my mother replies with a smile before changing the subject. “What do you do?”

Carrie skillfully dodges the questions with half-truths: “I work with several foundations that prioritize education and wellness in children and the underprivileged.”

“That’s an interesting career path to pursue,” Elaine comments tonelessly. “What made you choose to work with children and those in poverty?”

“Truthfully?” Carrie’s hand trembles as she reaches forward to grab her glass of water. She takes a long, desperate gulp before setting it back down. “There was a time after Frank’s passing that my daughter and I were living off food stamps and handouts from foundations like these. We waited in long lines to get commodities from churches and fresh produce from organic organizations giving back to the community. Luckily, the tide turned, and it allowed me to be the kind face people see when they are in need of assistance. I remember how embarrassing it was to be there every week or month needing help.”

Elaine reaches across the table to take Carrie’s hand. My heart swells with love for these two extraordinary women who mean more to me than life itself. “You have a good heart, Carrie. I am so thankful my son found you.”

Carrie smiles as if my mother’s acceptance is all she needs. “I feel lucky to have found your son, Ms. Reid. I assure you, I will never take him for granted.”

“You can call me Elaine,” she interjects quickly. “I was worried when Jackson said he was bringing you home, but everything happens for a reason.”

She doesn’t realize the profound truth of her words. The concept of fate and destiny, some higher power guiding our paths, is often dismissed as a mere belief or superstition. It comes with unexpected and sometimes unwelcome outcomes, like falling in love with your father’s second wife. But that’s the beauty of the universe—it has a way of surprising us and completely transforming our lives.

Chapter 56

Carrie

I'm going to tell Kaye about Jackson. She expected it at Thanksgiving, going as far as to accuse him of being a gold digger, but I wasn't ready to trust her with the truth all those weeks ago.

But it's Christmas, and there are only a few days until the new year. I want to go into 2024 unburdened by my secrets and lies.

I make sure everything is perfect. With Jackson spending Christmas morning with his mother before she goes to her late afternoon shift at the hospital, I want to give Kaye my full attention. I want to look her in the eyes and tell her I'm in love with someone new. I want to see the look on her face when I tell her that I finally got it right. That all the men before Jackson were just practice for the real thing.

I meticulously adorn every nook and cranny of the house with sparkling Christmas lights and lush garland. The grounds staff arranged and set up the front yard with illuminated displays and draped multi-colored string lights from every tree and bush. There are Christmas trees in every room, and music plays softly from the whole-house speaker system when Kaye walks through the door.

"Mom, I'm home!" She announces.

I'm so excited; I've prepared every holiday dish I could think of. "I'm in the dining room!" The table is decorated with a dozen candles and a centerpiece fit for a banquet.

"It smells amazing." Kaye walks into the dining room wearing a soft cashmere sweater and a pair of comfortable pants. She smooths the fabric across her stomach, picking off an invisible piece of lint and flicking it to the floor. After a minute, her eyes travel the length of the table and grow with overwhelm. "Mom, this is incredible. It looks and smells delicious," she repeats.

I come around the table to wrap my arms around her, holding her as tightly as she'll let me. "Merry Christmas, honey."

"Merry Christmas," she smiles.

"I hope you don't mind, but Jackson will be coming over in a bit," I warn her. "He's having Christmas cocktails with his family, then dinner here afterward. I told him we might eat before he arrives," since he wasn't sure when he'd be finished at Elaine's, "and he said that was fine. He just wants to spend Christmas with me."

Kaye pauses for a long minute, looking momentarily unsure. She offers to wait until Jackson arrives before we begin dinner. "I want to talk to you anyway," she says.

Anxiety gnaws at my mind, etching deep lines into my furrowed brows as I conjure up a thousand different scenarios that could unfold after her statement. "Is everything okay?"

As she parts her lips to speak, I sense a heaviness in the air, as if she is struggling with what to say. Kaye's expression shifts from guarded to vulnerable, and I can almost see the thoughts racing behind her eyes as she begins to speak, "Mom, it's about Jackson."

Every muscle in my body tenses. "What about him?"

With jittery hands, Kaye grips the edge of the table. Her fingers dance nervously over the crisp white tablecloth as she traces the intricate pattern with unease. "Jackson is Malcolm's son from an affair he had when he was married to Victoria," she says quickly, all the words coming out in a rush.

All conscious thought leaves my mind. I feel a dozen different emotions simultaneously: shock, surprise, fear, anger, frustration, confusion. I turn Kaye's words over in my head, trying to make sense of them, but I can't seem to latch onto the truth she's admitted.

"I forgot something," I mumble. I need a moment to myself. "Take a seat!" I insist as I head for the safety of my sterile, all-white kitchen.

The walls are wrapped in a calming shade of eggshell, spreading a soft and comforting glow throughout the room. Adorning them are stunning pictures depicting the landscape of the Italian countryside. The rolling hills of Sicily come to life in vibrant shades of green and gold. However, the longer I look at them, the more my stomach churns with unsettling queasiness.

I walk to the heart of the kitchen and start moving everything from the counter to the sink. I try to procrastinate productively, but my mind is racing a thousand miles an hour.

Jackson is Malcolm's son. How? Malcolm never told me he had another son. And I thought Jackson didn't know who his father was.

My mind is in turmoil, and I gravitate towards the refrigerator. I can feel my stomach churning as I pour myself a glass of wine and finish it off in the same breath, but deep down, I know I'll finish the whole bottle today. I need something to calm my thoughts, to make sense of this chaos that has suddenly consumed me. I can't shake the feeling that everything is spiraling out of control, and I don't know what to do. "It's okay," I mumble as I adjust my shirt and swipe my hand across my mouth. "I'll figure this out."

I stumble back to the dining room with the alcohol already swirling in my veins. It numbs the shock that lingers after Kaye's unexpected announcement. "Shall we eat?"

Kaye warily starts to load up her plate. "This is a lot, Mom," she mumbles, referencing the never-ending plates and side dishes covering the table.

I felt anxious when I got up this morning to start Christmas dinner. I just kept making food, dish after dish, until I felt less nervous. If I had known that my daughter was going to show up with earth-shattering news about my boyfriend, I would have kept cooking.

"Most of the leftovers will be donated to a homeless shelter," I make up on the spot. But it sounds like a good idea, now that I think about it. I'm sure there are plenty of shelters that could use five pounds of mashed potatoes.

"Mom," Kaye starts.

But I know she wants to ask me about Jackson. I can see the concern etched on her features, and I stop her before she can say anything else. "Kaye, please," I cling to the smile pinned on my face, "this is a conversation I need to have with Jackson, not you. Let's talk about something else." If I have this discussion with my daughter, I will unravel completely. I can feel my grip on reality slipping into madness, and I know I must cling to other thoughts if I wish to stay in control.

Because her news means that Jackson is not who I thought he was. It means this has all been a lie. It means he bid on me at the gala, knowing who I was. It means he kissed me, knowing I was married to his father. It means he knowingly put me in a position to ruin Malcolm's reputation.

"I'm pregnant," Kaye chimes in after a few seconds.

My fork is midair when the words come out of her mouth. I drop it on the fine China plate filled with food, causing a loud clatter that echoes through the quiet room. The force of her words reverberates through me, leaving me dizzy and breathless.

"It's Xavier's baby," she adds after a second.

The gentle buzz from the earlier glass of Pinot Grigio is not enough to calm my frayed nerves. I push back from the table and march to the fridge, determined to find something stronger. My hand lands on a bottle of rosé, a gift from one of Malcolm's clients that he had deemed undrinkable. But at this moment, I couldn't care less. With one swift motion, I uncork the bottle and take a long, satisfying swig, relishing the feeling of cool liquid sliding down my throat this Christmas Day. The sweet notes of strawberry and raspberry dance on my tongue, momentarily distracting me from the chaos.

"This will do," I mumble as I bring the bottle back to the dining room. "Say that again," I instruct Kaye as I sit down and take another sip, savoring the cheap wine. God, it takes me back to simpler times.

Kaye quietly repeats herself. “I’m pregnant with Xavier McCade’s baby.”

I pour a glass and take another healthy swig. My daughter is sleeping with her stepbrother, and I’m sleeping with my stepson. This is going to make family get-togethers a blast.

“Your father and I didn’t mean to get pregnant in high school. You know that, right?” I remind her, suddenly feeling nostalgic. It feels like my daughter is following in my footsteps in the worst possible way.

My daughter nods her head. “It was an accident,” she replies, repeating the words I told her over and over again through the years to keep her from thinking that having a baby with a man would solve her problems.

“A *happy* accident,” I clarify. “Because we had you. And you were the most beautiful baby girl with the sweetest demeanor. You never cried, you slept well, you ate well, you were perfect.” I had my fair share of sleepless nights, but not like some of the moms I met. I was lucky. “But,” I pop Kaye’s bubble before she gets too excited, “it made it extremely difficult to finish high school. Your father graduated a semester behind his class. When you were a baby, I had to take online classes, and I graduated a year after I was supposed to. I also knew I couldn’t go to college. I couldn’t afford the classes, and I couldn’t afford to put you in daycare or hire someone to take care of you. It was tough, Kaye.”

I want her to understand that having a child will change her life—it will turn everything upside down. I’ve been exhausted every day since I found out I was pregnant.

Kaye misconstrues my intention and stubbornly says, “I’m not giving up my baby.”

It breaks my heart that she thinks that’s what I want her to do. I shake my head slightly, trying to dissuade her from this notion. “That’s not what I mean, baby. Your father should have been around to see your tenth birthday. He should have been there when you had your first period and when you turned sixteen. He should have celebrated your middle school and high school graduation. He should have been there through first loves, heartbreaks, school dances, crushes, and everything in between. But he wasn’t. He was taken from us by a drunk driver, and that made your life and mine that much harder. It wasn’t his fault, but it’s the reason we’re having this conversation.”

I reach out to grab the wine glass again, but my hands are shaking. “If he never died, I never would have met and married Owen. Which means I never would have sought out Malcolm’s services as a divorce attorney. I never would have gone on a date with him, and you never would have met Xavier. Sometimes, I think about this when I’m going to sleep at night. Especially lately, as I’ve gotten to know Jackson better. He makes me feel like no other man ever has. And I realize that in order to have met Jackson, I needed all the bad, terrible, ugly, hard things to happen to me.”

If I’d known that the choices I made as a freshman in high school would lead to this, I would have become a nun. I would have done anything to spare my daughter the heartbreak of following in my footsteps. Sure, she’s eighteen, and she’s already graduated high school. She’s an adult and much stronger than I was at her age. But I never wanted this for her. I never wanted her to be a young mother like me. It was the hardest thing I’ve ever done—even harder than getting married and divorced twice more.

“Do you love him, Kaye?” I break the silence. I yearn for her to be with someone who sustains her, who makes her feel the way Franklin made me feel in the beginning. “Does he make you happy?”

Kaye thinks about it for a minute. I see the wheels in her head churning before she replies. “I think we could be good for one another. Things haven’t always been good between us, but Xave and I are figuring it out. I think we could be happy. We just need time.”

Time is a funny concept. On some days, it crawls forward agonizingly slow, and each second feeling like an eternity. But on other days, it rushes past in a blur, slipping through our fingers like grains of sand. “Time is not a luxury you have,” I tell my daughter. “When are you due?”

“August.”

I turn thirty-three in June, and then I’ll become a grandmother in August. These were never the plans I had in store for Kaye and me, but fate had other ideas.

I decide to tell my daughter the most important lesson I’ve learned over the years, a lesson I’m still learning today. Maybe it’ll save her heart from being battered and broken like mine. “You can always leave a bad relationship, honey. I’ve proven that time and time again. But creating a good relationship is harder. If you think you and Xavier have what it takes to be happy, then pursue it with all your heart because I would trade everything I have now if I could go back and change what happened to your

father. You deserved to have him there on the best and worst days of your life. Give that gift to your child if you can. You will never regret it.”

Kaye cocks her head, giving me a poignant look. “I’ll try, Mom, I really will. But there’s a lot that we need to overcome first.”

“It’s Christmas time, honey. Anything is possible.”

Xavier McCade. I would never have guessed, though I suspected after what he did to his father. There are worse men out there. As long as he treats her with love and respect, the rest will come.

Chapter 57

Jackson

My mom is working a twelve-hour shift on Christmas, but luckily, it doesn't start until 3:00 pm. We get a chance to spend a few hours together before she kisses me on the cheek and tells me to wish my girlfriend a Merry Christmas for her.

I know Kaye is at the house. Carrie told me last night that she would break the news to her daughter today about our relationship. I've been anxious all morning, but I didn't want to disrespect Elaine by calling Carrie to ask how it went.

Curiously, Kaye's car is not in the driveway when I pull up. I take it as a sign that Carrie's daughter freaked out when she found out about the two of us. I could tell she didn't like me after our first encounter, but I hope that'll change with time.

"Hey," I announce my entrance as I walk through the front door. "Where are you, Carrie?"

"In the living room." Her voice sounds stiff as she calls back to me. It lacks the usual warmth and ease I'm used to.

I prepare myself for the worst as I follow the sound of her voice. Carrie is sitting on the couch in the living room, her legs tightly crossed and her cheeks flushed with a bright red hue. She cradles a glass of wine in her hand, her fingers wrapped around the stem in a death grip. "Merry Christmas, beautiful," I smile as I walk toward her.

Carrie points at the chair across from the couch. "Sit," she orders.

With slow, deliberate movements, I cock my head. Is she angry? What happened in the hours that I was gone? "Did you tell Kaye about us?" I ask before following her command. The chair is less comfortable than the couch.

"I didn't have the time." Carrie purses her lips.

I'm not sure what to say. My body tenses as I shift restlessly from one side of the chair to the other. "Then what's the problem? Because you seem upset." Might as well attack this head-on. Whatever the problem is, we'll figure it out together.

Carrie impatiently taps her perfectly manicured nails against the smooth glass surface. Her gaze roams my face, searching for something. Curiosity and suspicion flicker in her eyes as she studies every inch of my features. I can feel her silently questioning me, judging me. "My daughter told me today that she's pregnant. Due in August. I'm going to be a grandmother."

With a deep sigh of relief, my anxiety deflates. For a second, I thought I was the problem. But I can see how finding out on Christmas that your eighteen-year-old daughter is pregnant would be disconcerting news. "Did she tell you who the father is?"

"Oh, yes," Carrie nods to emphasize her point. "Her stepbrother, Xavier. Or former stepbrother. I'm not sure. The divorce hasn't been finalized yet."

My throat tightens with unease again, and I can't put my finger on why. "I wasn't aware that Xavier and Kaye were together." It is the safest path to take, even if it's a lie. I've kept my eye on my half-brother and my girlfriend's daughter. I know all about the two of them.

Carrie takes a quick sip from her glass. "I don't know much about their relationship either, just that they're expecting. It was a shock because Xavier and Kaye have never seemed to like one another. I always thought they bickered like siblings because they were so different. He was a little older, he came from money, he was an only child, that sort of thing. I figure he picked on Kaye because he didn't like her or me or what his father had done. So this sudden change of circumstances is new to me," she confesses.

Everything she says makes sense. On paper, Xavier seems like the kind of man who would pick a woman exactly like his mother—the Oedipus-complex type. But when I learned about his little love affair with his stepsister, I had to reevaluate everything I knew about the guy. One day, I'd like to sit down and have a conversation with him.

“Unfortunately, that wasn’t even the most shocking news I heard today,” Carrie goes on. She yawns, politely covering her mouth. “My daughter showed up this afternoon to tell me that *not only* is she pregnant with her stepbrother’s baby, but that I’m dating my stepson.”

“What?” I ask sharply, not realizing for a few seconds what she said.

Carrie sets the glass of wine on the table before crossing her arms over her chest. Her posture is confident yet guarded, angry yet vulnerable. “You’re Malcolm’s son, aren’t you?”

I knew it was only a matter of time before she found out, but this wasn’t how I wanted it to happen. Nonetheless, I tell her the truth. There’s no point in lying anymore. “Yes.”

Chapter 58

Carrie

I sent Kaye home after lunch. I couldn't stomach her being around when Jackson showed up. I didn't want to see the judgment in her eyes when he walked through the door. Nor did I want to feel the hard press of her glare boring into my back when I forgave him.

Because I know without a doubt that I'll forgive him, as comforting and unsettling as that is to think about—to say otherwise would be blasphemous to my heart. I didn't wreck my marriage and blow up my entire life to give up on Jackson because of a few lies.

But I don't plan to let him off easy, either. Who does something like this? Who lies to someone for months on end about something so important? I need to know before I forgive him.



"I need you to understand why I did this," Jackson's voice breaks through the heavy silence, laced with desperation and concern. His usual smiling face is now twisted into a mask of urgency.

There's a reason for his betrayal. I knew there had to be. I broke bread with his mother, a woman who'd slept with my husband years before I ever knew who he was. I felt a kinship with her, one mother to another. In reality, it was more like one of Malcolm's discarded women to the next.

"When Malcolm was first married, he was having an affair with my mom. She thought he was going to leave Victoria because he told her so often that they were unhappy. He swore they'd be together, and she believed him."

Jackson's pleas on behalf of his mother sound like mine from so many years ago. I remember sitting outside Malcolm's office, saying those exact words to myself.

"But then she got pregnant. It was an accident, like when you got pregnant with Kaye. It was never meant to happen," Jackson swears. "Elaine went to Malcolm in hopes that he'd finally leave Victoria like he kept promising he'd do. But instead, he offered her money to get an abortion and disappear."

The force of my husband's proposition hits me like a physical blow, causing me to flinch and recoil away from Jackson. He leans forward in his seat, knees brushing against the coffee table as he pleads with his eyes. "He wouldn't." The words tumble out before I can catch them, before I can think twice about what Jackson said.

His face takes on a serious expression, his eyebrows furrowed, and his lips pressed into a thin line. He lowers his head slightly, and there is a somberness in his eyes as he nods slowly. "Malcolm paid her off with the expectation that she would abort me. He didn't want to have kids."

"But he had Xavier," I frown.

"Because *Victoria* wanted a child," Jackson replies gently. "Malcolm McCade never wanted to be a father."

I reflect on the discussions we had about starting a family before we tied the knot. Malcolm was always laid-back and agreeable. He promised to support me whether I wanted one child or a hundred. "But he said we could have kids." My features melt into confusion as I try to remember the conversation in detail. "Why didn't we have kids?"

Because he didn't want kids, not really, I remember it now. I recall his reluctance when we first got married. He framed it as wanting to spend more time with me. He convinced me that the first year of marriage was for couples to get to know each other more deeply and intimately. He preyed on my feelings about having a baby so early on in life. He told me that I was entering my freedom era. "With Kaye about to turn eighteen, it's time you have your life back," he swore. "We can go anywhere, do anything, and not have to worry about a child waiting for us at home or planning around nap time." I let him talk me into not having any more kids because he painted a seductive picture of our childless future.

Jackson replies to my earlier question, even kinder now. "You didn't have kids because *Malcolm* didn't want them. He's a selfish man; you should see the way he treats Xavier."

Xavier. They don't seem very close, especially after that incident at Malcolm's office. "I still don't understand, though," I beg, feeling as though I'm wading through quicksand. "How are you involved in all this? Why are you here?"

"Because a few years ago, Elaine finally told me who my father was. I thought it was cool that my father was a prominent attorney in Manhattan who was doing so well for himself. I was bothered that he'd try to pay off my mother to get rid of me, but I still wanted to meet him. Unfortunately, the sentiment was not the same."

Chapter 59

Jackson

I shift restlessly in the stiff, uncomfortable chair. Finally unable to stay still any longer. I rise to my feet. My fingertips tingle with nervous energy, sending electric pulses through my body. I begin to pace around the room, the air thick with tension as I continue my story. “I showed up at his office ready for a fairytale reunion with my dear ol’ dad. Then I took one look at him and saw his handsome, smiling face, and I hated him instantly. I couldn’t believe someone would treat their kid the way Malcolm had treated me.”

Instead of revealing the truth and sharing a touching moment, I demanded compensation for the years of neglect and abandonment. My tone was laced with bitterness and resentment, but deep down, I was desperate for his approval.

“Needless to say, our first interaction didn’t go well. I was too angry to be civil, and he threatened to sue my mother for breach of contract. It ended poorly.”

Carrie’s eyes widen as she listens intently to my story, her whole body leaning forward in anticipation. Her posture shifts from a cool and distant stance to one of interest.

“Then I left my father’s office and ran into a pretty blonde not half a block away. She was sitting on a bench, crying, and I could tell she needed someone to talk to. Imagine my surprise when I found out she was sleeping with my father. Of all the people to run into on that particular day. I thought he would have learned his lesson from knocking up my mother and leaving her. But no, he was cheating on Victoria again. This time, with a woman closer to my age. A gorgeous, beautiful woman who made my heart do backflips.”

A slow, creeping realization washes over her, causing her to recoil and sink back into the couch. Her fists clench tightly in her lap, knuckles turning white as she struggles to contain her mounting anger and frustration. “You knew who I was when you met me.”

I shake my head. “Not at first. I didn’t know when I sat down. When I sat down, I thought you were a pretty girl who needed a friend. Then you opened up to me, and I realized that we were both secrets Malcolm never wanted to come to light.”

“But he left Victoria for me,” she protests. “I wasn’t a secret for much longer.”

“You’re right. You weren’t a secret for much longer. When I discovered that you married Malcolm a year later, you stopped being a secret and started being a plan for revenge. You see, I tried to make amends with my father. I saw him several times after that first encounter, and the meetings always ended badly. I wanted my father to love me, and when he didn’t, I wanted everything else from him instead.”

I should have listened when he asked me to leave him alone, but my selfishness consumed me. I should have accepted that I would never have a father that loved me. But I know that no amount of ‘*should haves*’ can fix what Malcolm did.

“I craved for Malcolm to feel the same excruciating pain I did when he coldly rejected me. And I was willing to inflict harm on anyone who stood in my way.”

Tears pool in the corners of Carrie’s eyes, but she refuses to let them fall. Her voice booms with unwavering determination, defying me to challenge her resolve. “Just say it. Just say you were willing to hurt me in the process.”

The terrible, ugly truth is *she’s right*. When this all began, I would have torn her down right alongside my father without a second thought. Destroying her would have been a small price to pay for bringing my father to his knees. I deceived and

manipulated dozens of people along the way to my success. If I had to do it all over again, I would.

“It’s not that simple, Carrie. When I found out that Malcolm remarried, I considered you collateral damage. After all, you cheated with a married man. I told myself it’s what you deserved.”

Her body jolts upright, causing her shins to collide with the sharp edge of the coffee table. The impact sends her wine glass tumbling, splattering crimson liquid across the pristine surface. “Your mother cheated with a married man, Jackson. You think she deserved what she got?”

Anger courses through my veins. “Don’t talk about my mother.”

“Don’t talk about the woman I remind you so much of?” She scoffs. “Don’t *remind you* that the entire reason you did all this was out of some twisted desire to make Malcolm pay for what he did to her?”

“What he did *to me*,” I glare. “He *abandoned* me. I was his son. I just wanted him to love me.”

Carrie’s eyes roll back in a manic frenzy as she stalks towards me, her steps measured and predatory. She circles the coffee table with rapacious grace, each step like a ticking time bomb building up to an explosive attack. “You got revenge for both of you. Don’t pretend it was just for you. Your mother was scorned by Malcolm, and I was this close to being in the same boat. If I hadn’t run into you that day outside his office, I wouldn’t have given him an ultimatum. I would have kept letting him use me until he got bored and left me.”

“You would have been safer if he would have discarded you like a used napkin.” She wouldn’t have made the mistake of saying ‘*I do*’ and tying herself to a ruthless monster. Her daughter wouldn’t have been marked as prey by a hunter like Malcolm, who relishes in the chase and destruction of innocent lives.

“You’re not wrong,” Carrie laughs bitterly. “Kaye and I were living paycheck to paycheck. I was working three jobs just to get by some months. We ate a lot of pasta and rice because it was filling, but also because it was cheap. We were one emergency away from losing everything we had. But I’d trade it all to be back there again if it meant Kaye didn’t have to go through what I did with Malcolm. She never deserved to face the consequences of my actions.”

We stand in the opulent living room paid for by a man we both despise, each waiting for the other to make the first move.

This story holds secrets that go far beyond the surface, dark truths that I can’t even begin to put into words. And all we can do is stare at one another.

Chapter 60

Carrie

An eternity passes between us, one second at a time.

I stare at the handsome face of the man I've come to love, and I recognize Malcolm's features. I see it in his blue eyes, in the square of his shoulders, in the twitch of his lips every time he smiles. I thought I was falling for the love of my life, but it turns out I was falling for my husband's son—they are one and the same.

"Was any of this real?" I ask, my voice cracking with emotion. I clear my throat and force myself to take a deep breath, trying to ground myself in this moment. "Did you love me, or was it all just to get back at Malcolm?"

Jackson reaches up to run a hand through his tousled hair, the strands slipping between his fingers like silk. A rueful smile tugs at the corners of his lips as he sighs and returns his hand to his side. "Why can't it be both, Carrie?"

"Because it can't. Either you loved me, or you wanted to hurt Malcolm."

He takes a step toward me, and I take a step back, putting the couch between us. If I let him touch me, I'll crack. I'll break into a million little pieces and be his forever. I need to know that this is real before I let that happen.

"From beginning to end, I wanted to hurt Malcolm. When he and Victoria were getting divorced, I thought I was right there. I was so close to getting what I wanted. But then he married you shortly after, and instead of being unhappy for the rest of his life, he married the prettiest woman I'd ever met. He was living his happily ever after, and I was broken inside." Jackson hangs his head. "It made me happy to tear you down with Malcolm if that's what it took. I told myself for years that I wouldn't care if you got hurt or your heart was broken. You were an acceptable loss in all of this. I was selfish, I know that, but the heart wants what it wants. And for years, all my angry, black heart wanted was for my father to feel as badly as I did."

I can feel my face turning red as he speaks. The back of my eyelids prickle as I realize I've been nothing more to him than a means to an end. "You introduced me to your friends." My voice trembles with desperation and need. "You took me home to meet your mother. You let me introduce you to my daughter."

Jackson strides confidently towards me, his long legs effortlessly carrying him closer. His hand extends towards mine, a silent invitation for me to take it, and I can't resist the pull of his touch. As our fingers interlock, a current of electricity shoots through my body, igniting every nerve ending. "Let me finish, Carrie."

"What else is there to say?" Tears slide down my cheeks, and I bitterly regret everything I did that brought me here.

"I've been plotting against Malcolm for years, dreaming of tearing him down and claiming everything he loves as my own. But I never anticipated falling for you in the process." His words strike like a blow from a sledgehammer, shattering the air around us into deafening silence.

Afraid that I don't understand, he keeps talking. "I knew you were going to be at that charity gala. I planned to casually bump into you and bring up our past conversation in an attempt to worm my way into your life. Then, by a stroke of luck, you were auctioned off like a prize to be won. I saw you standing on that stage, the spotlight gleaming down on you, and I knew that whatever came next would be worth any price I had to pay. This all might have started because I wanted revenge, but how I feel about you is real. I would never have met your daughter or introduced you to my mother if it wasn't."

I desperately want to believe him. His words are like a soothing melody, crafted perfectly for my ears. But as much as I long to trust him, there is still a nagging doubt that lingers in the back of my mind. "The other day when you told me your brother came

by,” I frown. “Was that Xavier?”

Jackson nods. “I don’t know how he found out about me, but he knew somehow. He showed up and told me to stay away from you and Kaye. But by then, I’d already moved in with you. I figured it was only a matter of time before you found out. Xavier and Kaye are close. If he knew who I was, he’d tell her.”

That explains why my daughter knew about Jackson’s affiliation with the McCade family before I did. Still, it hurts to be the last one to find out.

“You said it couldn’t be both, that I couldn’t love you *and* want to hurt Malcolm, but both are true.” Jackson draws near, and the warmth of his body reflects onto mine. “When this started, I didn’t care about you, but the more time we spent together, the harder it became to resist you. I wanted to. God knows how much easier it would have been if I could have put you out of my mind at the end of the day. But from our very first kiss, I knew you would be impossible to forget. You are everything I have ever wanted and never knew I needed.”

Each word chips away at the fear that I was *only* a tool to achieve Jackson’s goals.

His eyes sweep over me, a storm of emotion churning in a sea of blue. “You’ve changed everything,” he whispers, his voice barely more than a sigh. “Before you, my days were nothing but a sequence of shallow breaths and half-lived moments waiting for revenge. My father’s ghost haunted me at every turn, and I dreamt about vengeance and retaliation.”

His hand raises to delicately brush a strand of hair from my face—a simple gesture laden with a tenderness that does not match the actions he is admitting to. “But then you opened up to me, and it was like dawn breaking over the darkest night. You scattered the shadows with your laughter and banished the cold with the warmth of your smile. With you, I found something that I never set out to find. You showed me that my father’s love didn’t matter when I had *real* love—love that didn’t care about winning and revenge, but love that cared about giving, sacrificing, and cherishing.”

A small, tentative smile tugs at the corners of my mouth, unsure whether to emerge or retreat back within. But as Jackson’s words wash over me, the smile grows larger and more certain, spreading across my face like a sunrise breaking through the clouds.

“Malcolm no longer has a hold on me. I was blackmailing him for money, but I don’t need his money anymore; I don’t need his connections. The anger, the revenge, the hatred, all the conflicting emotions I felt about him—none of it matters anymore because I have you. You are my sunrise and sunset. You are my today and all of my tomorrows. If you can forgive me for what I did, I promise to spend every day of the rest of my life making it up to you. Carrie,” he pauses, and the way he utters my name sounds like he’s making a sacred vow, “I love you.”

My heart races as I listen to Jackson’s passionate words, and I feel my anger toward him start to thaw. I knew it was only a matter of time before I gave in and allowed him to win me over.

Memories cascade through my mind like a series of sepia-toned vignettes—fleeting instances of despair and loneliness that brought me to this moment. I see myself standing in front of Franklin’s grave on the day he was laid to rest. I see the apologetic look on Owen’s face the first time he hit me, later twisting into satisfaction when he realized hitting me felt good. I see Malcolm’s smile on the day we married, coiling into sick gratification every time he humiliated me.

Yet through it all—through the dark moments and the light—fate was silently working to bring Jackson and I together. Fate made our paths cross in a chance encounter outside my future husband’s law office when I was at my lowest. And it was fate that he was my husband’s secret son; their relationship eroded by time and malice.

Every struggle was a stepping stone leading me to Jackson.

I can feel the apprehension in his body, the fear of baring his soul without certainty of reciprocation, and I stand on my toes to kiss it away. He is what I’ve been looking for all my life, and I can’t believe it took thirty-two years of searching to find him.

I pull back slightly to look into his eyes, whispering, “I love you, too.”



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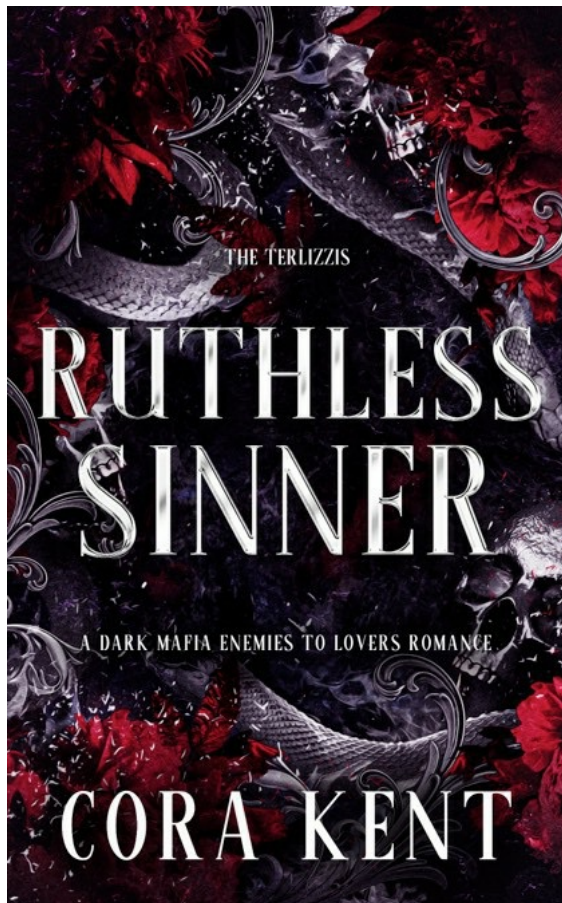
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Also by Cora Kent



I was born to inherit the family business. Father braided darkness into my soul before I spoke my first word.

Adalina Martinelli is collateral.

At first, I take her because her father is in debt to mine.

But after one night together, she becomes my *prisoner*.

Locked in a gilded cage, I set forth to transform her.

Father wants me to marry, and I've found the perfect *wife*.

She may be *younger* than me...

She may be the daughter of our *enemies*...

She may need *stern* convincing...

But I will *bend and break her* until she agrees to my twisted guarantee of safety.

[Ruthless Sinner](#)

About the Author



Cora Kent's first love was Scar, and she was devastated when he didn't get a happily ever after. That's why all her books feature villains, dark romance, and a hint of the forbidden.

Ever since she was a kid, Cora has rooted for the bad guy. If the Big Bad Wolf ate out Little Red Riding Hood, it would have made for a better story—which is why all her books have a happily ever after for the morally grey anti-hero who will move heaven and earth for his woman.

When Cora isn't living out her fantasies through writing, she's hanging out with her cat, drinking margaritas, and reminding her husband that the trash goes out on Sunday nights.

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